

WARHAMMER

THE HORUS HERESY



RALDORON

Revenant

Guy Haley

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It is a time of legend.

Mighty heroes battle for the right to rule the galaxy. The vast armies of the Emperor of Mankind conquer the stars in a Great Crusade – the myriad alien races are to be smashed by His elite warriors and wiped from the face of history.

The dawn of a new age of supremacy for humanity beckons. Gleaming citadels of marble and gold celebrate the many victories of the Emperor, as system after system is brought back under His control. Triumphs are raised on a million worlds to record the epic deeds of His most powerful champions.

First and foremost amongst these are the primarchs, superhuman beings who have led the Space Marine Legions in campaign after campaign. They are unstoppable and magnificent, the pinnacle of the Emperor's genetic experimentation, while the Space Marines themselves are the mightiest human warriors the galaxy has ever known, each capable of besting a hundred normal men or more in combat.

Many are the tales told of these legendary beings. From the halls of the Imperial Palace on Terra to the outermost reaches of Ultima Segmentum, their deeds are known to be shaping the very future of the galaxy. But can such souls remain free of doubt and corruption forever? Or will the temptation of greater power prove too much for even the most loyal sons of the Emperor?

The seeds of heresy have already been sown, and the start of the greatest war in the history of mankind is but a few years away...



RALDORON: REVENANT

GUY HALEY



CHAPTER ONE

THE THIRST

In a desert of dead grey sand lit by an ugly moon, a scream rent the night.

The beast came to a halt, the whine of his power armour a strange and dissonant noise in the ruins. His head snapped round and he sniffed at the air, showing his face to the sky. The angels of the old religions were less beautiful. He was a sculpted paean to symmetry. His brow was noble, his lips full, his cheekbones sharp.

But his expression was not that of an angel.

Across his features, the fury of a beast raged reasonless and foul. Splashes of blood, black in the soulless light, marred the perfection of his skin. Clots of gore matted his long hair. His teeth were cruelly sharp.

The screaming turned to a terrified gurgle. Quiet followed. The beast listened, gene-engineered ears straining at the newly haunted silence.

The beast's breath plumed. Sometime during the rout he had lost his helmet. He did not remember when. He did not remember chasing the foe from the field. He did not even remember his name. The hunger took all but sensation from him. Blood tang excited his senses, making him drool uncontrollably. The night wind chilled it on his chin. Gore, drying to a cracked shell, stiffened his skin. Warm air venting from the power unit upon his back twisted around him in currents that wavered, enveloped him, and dispersed. Beyond this shell of machine heat, it was bitterly cold, as befitted this tomb of a city, where eroded slabs of concrete jutted from the wastes,

gravestones to a civilisation nobody recalled. From the clear sky, cold stars gazed in sorrowful hosts at the ruin of mankind's domains.

This worn devastation had no effect upon him. Only his hunger mattered.

The beast sniffed again, seeking prey. He smelled fire, and smoke, spilled oil and spilled guts, and blood, of course. Blood called to him from every place, but it was old and gelid. He yearned for the rich heat of fresh blood more than anything else in the world.

The men of the Turuci had fled from the horrors the Emperor had unleashed upon them. Back in the saltpans, where they had made their stand against things that were both more and less than men, the Turuci's bodies were in pieces, blasted apart by bolt and volkite. That was not the case between the scattered mesas of rubble. The corpses there were untidy heaps on the dunes, rent by frenzied hands.

Hands like the beast's. He looked at them uncomprehendingly, as if they were new to him, those hinges of muscle and lengths of bone. He frowned, as if he had expected to find claws instead of gauntlets. He clenched his fists. Blood dribbled from them. The pulse pounding in his ears drowned out all reason, all feeling, all hope. It roared to other blood, calling to it, urging it to join in his body in the torrent of endless thunder.

The blood's cry drove him to run. He did not know where.

His gun had gone. His empty knife scabbard clacked on his thigh. He missed neither. He ran towards one of the leaning spires, racing up its long shadow towards a deeper darkness. The building fragment was flat, an old wall bent outwards under its own weight, the regular shapes of its many windows eroded to ragged holes. Ancient, orange steel showed in the cracked concrete. There was no sense of streets here, no sense of order. Whatever pattern the ancient city once possessed was lost, buried under the wreckage of its own corpse.

The beast rounded the spire, ran between curls of impossibly ancient metal.

He stopped. Eyes pierced the silvered desert gloom. To normal human vision, it was a landscape of hard whites and blacks, flattened and treacherous. To the beast's enhanced sight, it was clear as full day.

Ahead, the telltale pits of bipedal locomotion pocked the side of a dune. The beast loped right to follow them. As he neared, he smelled fresh fear and fresh sweat.

A man.

Prey.

The beast's pace increased. The purr of his armour was the loudest sound in that desolate place, his footsteps only soft and sinister thumps. The scent drew him up the drift of sand onto a slope of compacted rubble, then to a cave, the entrance barely recognisable as an age-lost door. Stacked slabs of collapsed floors formed the roof, worn by time into nearly natural forms.

He leapt, the strength boost of his armour carrying him over the threshold between moonlight and true dark. Ceramite scraped on false stone. In the confined space, his breathing echoed loudly, the hum of armour systems intensified. Neither could compete with the howl of the blood. Nothing could.

The scent was strong. The beast bared long fangs stained with earlier kills. His unnatural eyes struggled against the gloom.

At the back of the cave, muzzle flash winked yellow. A gun blatted. A solid slug whined off the beast's armour-clad arm. The guns of the dust basin tribes were underpowered, poorly made; they could not hope to penetrate powered plate.

Earlier that day, when the beast had worn the seeming of a man, when the beast had self-possession enough to reflect on man's folly, he had wondered why the Turuci did not see they could not win. Why could they not understand? The reunification of mankind was unstoppable. They could not win, the Emperor could not lose. Opposing His design brought only death. The man the beast sometimes was watched the defiant army roar onto the field in cavalcades of light vehicles, arrogantly decorated with spikes, flags and skulls, the salt dust of their passing covering the sun, and he had pitied them.

There was no pity now. There was only the Thirst. The roar of the blood call. Hunger.

The beast charged, covering the thirty metres between the cave mouth and his skulking prey in six strides. The gun fired again, rapidly now. A stream of bullets cracked off the beast's armour, ricocheting in every direction, turning his front into a blizzard of sparks. Perhaps a lucky shot to the eye or the mouth might have killed the beast. Perhaps not. One bullet struck his head, scoring a groove in his scalp that ran with a sudden, liquid fire he registered but did not feel.

The beast closed the distance and wrenched the poorly made stubber from his prey's hands, smashing the gun into pieces on the wall of tumbled blocks. The man fell and scrambled back. He wore an iron mask fashioned to look like a skull. Bulky plates were strapped over his loose robes. It must have been fearsome to those he oppressed, but it appeared in that moment as if the man wore the costume of a monster, a childish mock of the beast's own panoply.

The beast reached down, plucking the iron mask free. A red-scarred face stared up at him. One eye was milky with cataracts, the nose forced over by a squamous growth that crowded his good eye. It was a miracle he had fired so straight.

'Please, no! Compliance! Compliance!' the man begged, stinking breath filtered through rotting teeth. He was already dead, putrefying from the inside out.

'Blood,' growled the beast.

The warrior threw up his arm to cover his face. It was cankerous, blighted with tumours, the muscles feeble, the bones sharp beneath loose skin.

The beast had once been this way, an example of humanity born of twisted genes. The Emperor had changed that, mending that which mankind had corrupted, remaking his young body, changing something that could barely be called a man into an exemplar of purity, at least on the outside.

The beast did not think of these things. He did not consider the similarities between himself and his prey, so soon to die and be consumed. He did not think, as the man the beast sometimes was thought, that the Emperor had performed a cruel trick, a sleight of hand that had turned the boy inside out, putting the ugliness within, exchanging internal decency for a superficial beauty that hid new evils.

The beast thought none of these things. The beast thought only of blood.

The beast punched, a sharp, precise blow that detached the prey's sternum and forced the rib ends from their sockets. The man gaped at him, as if in shock at the beast's impoliteness. His mouth worked, but his lungs drew in no breath. Shock gave way to panic. His eyes widened. He was suffocating.

The beast's head drove down. His mouth latched on to the neck. Sharp fangs penetrated the prematurely wrinkled skin, hooked in, and the beast wrenched back his head. A hot chunk of flesh came away clamped in his

mouth, salt wet running down his throat. Arterial spray coated his armour with a fresh, glistening layer.

The prey choked. Blood welled. His struggles lessened; he was nearly dead. The beast dipped his head again and, gently now, fed.

Later, as the meat cooled, the beast would open the man's head as easily as cracking an egg. Crouching there in the dark, he would feast upon the still warm meat of his brains, the soft matter barely chewed, swallowed in chunks, and wait for the blooming of memory. He would learn how this man disagreed with his warlord's decision to fight, and not just from fear. He had heard the stories. He hoped for a better world for his kin. The word of the Emperor was spreading. Resistance was dying. This world would soon be compliant.

Not that such things absolved the warrior. He had followed his master to battle, and there opposed the Emperor's Angels. In doing so, he had made himself prey. The beast would feel no remorse.

In the morning, the man would return and the beast would be a beast no more. Still he would look upon the broken remains of this warrior with a complete lack of feeling. He would not bury the body. He would walk out into the dawn and seek out his fellows and stir them from their own bloody awakenings.

Before he left the cave, on a whim, the beast took the warrior's crude iron mask. Though the man the beast sometimes was would often ask himself why he did so in the years of crusading to come, he would never be able to answer.

That would be tomorrow. For now, there was only the beast, and his thirst, and the blood. Vitae ran down his face, his breastplate, his arms. It pooled in the hollow of his neck where bodyglove met ceramite, overflowing it. As it spilled down his breastplate, it filled the lettering of a brass plaque riveted above his primary heart. A plaque that bore in simple script a noble name. A name lost to hunger, and covered by blood.

That name was Raldoron.

CHAPTER TWO

ARCHEIN

*Imperial battle cruiser Promissum Sanguinem, in orbit,
128 Minoris-Garmon, local nomenclature: 'Thorne's Landing'*

Raldoron sat statue-still in his chambers. Flat eyes stared at the iron mask resting upon his desk, a memento of a distant conflict. As he looked at it, he remembered. He remembered the times before the rebellion, before his apotheosis, before he met Sanguinius. He remembered being human. He remembered being weak. He had been many things since the Emperor changed him: an angel, a monster, a leader... Weak was not among them.

A man spoke from the door. It was Solar Marshal Faisal Subarai-Almazi, a handsome, dark-skinned Saiphani in his late fifties, and he was dressed in all the resplendence of high rank.

‘Archein.’

Raldoron was too lost in the sharp verities of transhuman memory to hear. He reached out and rolled the iron mask gently from side to side. His fingers were enlarged hugely beyond the human norm, yet still somehow elegant. The iron mask had turned a deep maroon with age, polished to a leaden grey where he most often handled it. Otherwise, it was exactly as it had been when he had taken it from the cave.

The iron smell of it reminded him of blood.

Almazi cleared his throat loudly. 'My apologies, Archein. I do not mean to disturb you, but the leadership of Thorne's Landing will be ready to receive you soon. It is time to prepare for the descent. They will expect a certain show, to mark our shared victory.'

This time, Raldoron, Archein of the First Company of the Blood Angels Legion, ranked among the mightiest and noblest of all Imperial heroes, heard.

Raldoron let his fingertips rest a moment on the mask, then withdrew them. He turned to face Faisal. The golden thread in the robes he wore rasped harshly. For a moment he did not speak, just stared. Faisal bore the weight of his gaze, while the somnolent hum of the ship filled the space between every breath.

'I am sorry. I am preoccupied.' Raldoron got to his feet and took in the dress uniform of the solar marshal. His ceremonial breastplate gleamed, his weapons and leatherwork shone with fresh oil. His tunic and trousers were sharply pressed and laundered. The faint smell of plain soap came off him under the scent of perfume. Of course, beneath it all was the smell of flesh, and of blood. Raldoron acknowledged them, then put them from his mind. 'You present a fine figure, Faisal. I am sure the clan lords will be impressed.'

Almazi clicked his heels and dipped his head in a curt salute. 'Hard war is no excuse for low standards. We all have an impression to make.'

'Appearances are important,' Raldoron agreed. For a reason he could not fathom, he glanced back at the mask resting on his desk. It stared at the painted ceiling blindly.

'You are to take centre stage, my lord, but we bit players have our role. When I stand by your side, I intend to look like I belong there.'

Raldoron examined the marshal's face. He had never been good at judging human emotion. Intent, yes, but the finer subtleties of human feeling had a tendency to elude him. Raldoron's calm demeanour came with a certain seriousness. This was not, as some had said, a result of his transformation, which stripped some neophytes of their emotional affect even back in the Days of Wonder. No, Raldoron had been that way since he was a child. Born grave, his father had said, and his transformation had only reinforced his solemn tendencies. So it took him a moment to see Faisal was making

light, by which time it was too late to attempt a smile when he realised he should have. Instead he nodded in acknowledgement.

It was all he could think to do.

They talked as they made their way to the central armoury. It was Raldoron's habit to share armoury space with the other officers. Though Legion tradition allowed the higher ranks to maintain their own arming chambers, and Raldoron was the highest of all, second only to the primarch himself, he eschewed his right to solitude. Brotherhood was more important than ever now, when so many bonds of kinship had been irrevocably broken.

'The final pockets of the enemy are being snuffed out,' Faisal reported. 'There was ongoing resistance from a few small groups in the Ventasi Ranges. A few remain. I believe that is all.'

Raldoron looked at him questioningly.

'The mountains on the northern land mass, my lord,' Faisal explained smoothly. 'Sector Q Four.'

'Thank you,' Raldoron said. He kept his pace slow so that the marshal was not forced to run. He had no wish to inflict that indignity upon anyone, and Faisal was an especially good man, worthy of respect. 'This advance is relentless.'

Many men and women hastened by, all of them occupied, few of them even seeing their angelic master as he passed. One battle was done, another awaited; there was no time to salute or hail him, no time to marvel at the glorious being among them.

'Hard to learn all the names,' the marshal said. Raldoron thought he was attempting sympathy.

What Faisal said was not strictly true. Raldoron's enhanced memory could retain any information presented to it. It was more that in a war of this kind, where planet after planet must be subdued rapidly, he was often not exposed to these things to learn them in the first place. Codenames, numeric designations, coordinates and other shorthands of war took the place of such niceties as names. It made it easier that way. Easier to kill worlds.

'Victory is assured. Dominion Vallis has committed some of the new legionaries to finishing off the most troublesome fortresses.'

‘The Angforia are in the field, then. It is high time they were tested properly.’

‘Indeed. Lord Vallis selected the site as a good demonstration of their capabilities. He believes they are ready now to operate under looser oversight.’

‘I agree,’ said Raldoron.

‘The last of it should be over by nightfall. There will of course be those traitors who have gone back into the civilian population, but I doubt there will be sufficient numbers to cause much trouble. We shall remain vigilant.’

‘Good,’ said Raldoron. Already his mind was ranging ahead, moving from the solved problem of Thorne’s Landing to the conquest of the next of the Minoris-Garmon worlds. These were populated systems, scattered thickly throughout the star cluster gathered around Beta-Garmon – less important than the prime worlds, but still vital stepping-stones to the great confrontation coming at the core.

‘All three space ports are entirely in our hands and ready to recommence operations. It appears there has been minimal damage to key infrastructure. No sabotage to the facilities – at least, not much. We have resupply shipping already inbound from the system’s edge.’

‘The traitors will have wanted the void ports whole,’ Raldoron said. ‘They desire the same things as we do. Men, supplies, logistics.’ A truth so self-evident, he wondered why he had gone to the trouble of saying it. *I must be distracted*, he thought.

They entered a lifter. The doors hissed shut on an interior heavy with carvings. Hand-painted images of the Blood Angels at war occupied panels on three of the walls. Each of them was exquisite, the height of human artistry. The doors were a confection of mirrors and filigree. All of it had been rendered by Space Marine hands.

‘Have your audits been finished? How much materiel will we recover?’ Raldoron asked.

At this Faisal became less positive. He looked at the toes of his polished boots and flexed his back. ‘An amount. Not as much as we hoped. It will take some time to finish going through the manifests of the ports. A lot of it was food. Its transit was halted when the Warmaster’s traitors contested the world, and much has obviously spoiled, given the time it’s been sitting there. There are very few military supplies, but assuming we can stabilise

the surrounding worlds, and get agricultural production up and running again, we should be able to begin sending supplies on to Terra soon.'

'What else is there besides food? Anything useful?'

'Initial tallying suggests ores, timbers, processed minerals, suchlike things.'

Materials for building empires, thought Raldoron, not for saving them.

'Then we are done here. We will depart as soon as possible. You have chosen a cohort of your men to serve as garrison?'

'It is already done, my lord Archein.'

There were many fighting men on Thorne's Landing. Men were the principal reason for intervening on these modest planets, the Archein's fleet targeting places where concentrations of loyal troops were to be found. Raldoron would fold the militias who had battled here into his own force, conveying them to the killing fields of the cluster core. But the world needed a garrison, and Raldoron wanted one whose loyalty could be relied upon. It was too risky to let the inhabitants of Thorne's Landing guard their own world. They were too open to infiltration. He need not explain that to Faisal.

'Have your men prepare all assets for removal. We shall have to arrange guarded shipping routes in from system's edge. Thorne's Landing remains at risk of counter-strike. Detail our astropathic choirs to send messages. Any shipments of provender to be directed to Delta-Garmon directly for onward shipment to Terra as soon as possible. We must prioritise agricultural produce.'

'Yes, my lord,' Faisal said. 'And after we are gone?'

'We are not going to abandon the system. The best use of Thorne's Landing until this war is over will be as a muster point should we need to regroup and fall back,' he explained. 'We will prepare for the eventuality that we must retreat. Make that clear to your men. That is to be their primary purpose here. In the meantime, this world will serve as it always did, as a shipping nexus.' He thought a moment. 'And have the ports rigged for demolition should the worst come to pass. The traitors were fools not to do it themselves.'

They went down six decks, emerging from the lifter into the bustle of the central armoury deck. Raldoron picked up speed. They had so much to do, and little time to do it in. Faisal extended his stride.

‘May I suggest that such information may affect their morale? I can give them their orders in a more uplifting form.’

‘I trust you to dress it up as it must be, but do not overdo it, Faisal. Lies serve no one,’ Raldoron said. ‘The Garmon Cluster is aflame from end to end. I hope greatly that we will triumph here, and halt Horus well away from Sol, but what is a hope but a lie we tell ourselves? We must strive for the best yet prepare for the worst. Complacency is our enemy.’

Faisal nodded. ‘Of course, Archein.’

Raldoron went to the arming chamber he shared with Dominion Vallis and the task force’s other captains. The door opened. Thralls within bowed and came forward to do his bidding. Raldoron looked down at the marshal.

‘How is your son? I forgot to ask. Is Assan hale?’ He reminded himself of the importance of family bonds to baseline humans.

He was rewarded with a smile.

‘He lives, my lord. He fought well. He is a fine leader in the making, if you will permit me a little pride. He performs well as a captain. One day, I am sure, he will serve as a marshal.’

‘No permission is needed for your pride. It is righteous. Assan is as talented a warrior as his father. Indeed, all your Elevatii have performed well here,’ Raldoron said. ‘I shall see that appropriate honours are distributed.’

‘The induction of the men of Saiph into the Ninth Legion is privilege enough,’ said Faisal modestly.

‘And yet you shall receive more. The flags of the Forty-Sixth will grow heavy before this campaign is done.’

Raldoron was stolid and straightforward to a fault, and so had little use for ostentation. To him the words sounded hollow, but he understood the human need for approval. There was precious little else to fight for in this fratricidal war.

‘Thank you, my lord Archein.’ Faisal bowed. He was a large, strong man, but he looked small before his commander, and more so in supplication. ‘If I may beg your leave? I have matters to attend to before we descend. I shall meet you upon the embarkation deck. Shall we say in an hour? The flight will take two.’

Raldoron nodded assent, then went to his serfs. The door slid shut behind him, and the Archein’s arming began.

CHAPTER THREE

ANGFORIOS

The last sliver of day glanced off the horizon and scintillated in Simeon's eyes. He blinked.

The dazzle was enough to break the fugue, and his first clear thought since the morning was that the sun reminded him of the patterns that ended the hypnomat sessions. Simeon breathed hard. His secondary heart beat counter-time to his primary, a sign it was slowing and close to stalling now it was no longer needed. Whatever had happened was over. What that was, he had little idea. He could not recall how he had come to be where he was.

Simeon turned on the spot. His helm was missing, and the sun was warm on his exposed face. At first the warmth was all he could think of, it was so pleasant. Then he noticed the quiet, and the still, and the stink.

He was at the top of a mountain slope. In the morning he had been at its foot. He remembered Dominion Vallis' speech, telling them to go forth and fight. Then... shooting. Close fighting? Certainly fighting. He had a flash of running up the steep slope. That was all. Now he was among the defence lines snaking under the rocky overhangs of the granite peak and there were bodies everywhere. He thought for a moment their assault had broken only the outer defences, but as he completed his slow turn, taking in the valley and shattered firing points dug out of the mountainside, he found himself facing the main entrance to the traitors' fastness. The plasteel door was burned through, the bubbled slag in slicks around the entry still shimmering

with heat, the work of melta bombs. Black smoke boiled ceaselessly from inside.

‘Over...?’ The word was poorly formed. His teeth felt too big and too sharp for his mouth. ‘Victory?’ he asked the empty field. By the breached door lay the corpse of a lone Blood Angel, the red of his shattered chestplate blending seamlessly with his exposed innards.

He looked over himself, half fearing to find similar wounds. He was whole, but the blood on his armour told its own story, and there was more blood in his mouth. The metallic, heavy taste of it coated his tongue. Suddenly disgusted, he spat. Stringy gobbets of congealing vitae flew from his lips, but that did not clear it, so he spat again.

A flash of unwelcome, intrusive imagery impinged upon his mind. A memory, but not his own. He was looking through the eyes of an unenhanced man, at the Blood Angels charging up the hill, their black arms and pauldrons marking them out as Angforia, new troops, hurriedly raised, the kind some Traitor Legions named ‘inductii’, not worthy of wearing the full Legion red. Through the other man’s eyes, Simeon saw himself leading the others. He saw his chainsword screaming in his fist.

He felt the man’s overwhelming fear, felt hands that were not his own shake around a lasrifle.

He, Simeon, this other self seen from outside, threw away his pistol and tore off his helm with a single clumsy hand, the movement made with such force and haste it ripped his earlobe.

The man who was about to die watched Simeon come for him. Simeon had trouble recognising his own face. The screaming figure was undoubtedly him – that was his armour, the red and the black; that was his chainsword, his face – but surely this was some trick. It could not be him. He had never felt such rage as that which he saw torturing his features.

The terrified man’s shaking hands did not move. They could not. They did not level the rifle, they did not fire. They clutched the weapon to a chest sheltering a hammering heart, as if cradling the gun alone would shield the bearer.

It did not.

A crushing weight of armour and engineered flesh slammed into the soldier. His vision exploded with stars on a field of fizzing black, followed by a ripping agony at the neck.

Final darkness fell.

Simeon squeezed his eyes shut, pressed at the bridge of his nose, trying to banish the memory of second-hand death. There was a dull throb in his throat, painful, yet almost pleasant. How well he had come to know that feeling. How it would rise and rise and then overwhelm him, the pulse of a thirst that could never be slaked, though joy came in the trying, the briefest release, followed by scattered moments of calm, like this. It would not last.

Simeon probed his ear and found dull pain. His angel's gifts were already knitting the flesh. His hands were empty, his weapons gone. His face itched. He wiped dried blood from his mouth. The Thirst was subdued, become a feeble longing. It would return fully in time.

Once again he spat. He wished for a drink – an actual drink of pure water, not the intravenous hydration his armour provided. He wanted the damnable taste of blood out of his mouth. He spied a canteen on one of the fallen, and snatched at it with such urgency he mangled the clip that held it to the dead man's belt. He made similarly rough work of the stopper, half crushing the stamped metal in his need to get at the water. He sucked greedily at the torn lip, letting the warm liquid wash his mouth clean and take away the taint of stolen memory. Suddenly repulsed, he scrubbed at his chin, but that only spread more blood from his gauntlets across his face, and he suffered an attack of perfect despair.

'Focus,' he told himself. 'This is normal. This is the test, the test we must overcome.' He mumbled words taught by the masters of recruits. 'The test of the Thirst. We are the sons of Sanguinius. We are bold. We are glorious. We rise over the worst of our natures to become the best of humanity.'

The words sounded like lies. Surely it was not meant to be like this? The others, the Legion veterans, they did not fight with such abandon and savagery. They did not kill like animals did, tearing at their foes. They had control.

Not for the first time, he feared something was terribly wrong with him.

He went to the places the stolen memories said his helm and weapons should be and found them lying in the battlefield's wrack. He went to his sword first. The chain track was clogged with flesh. He had not cleared it in the way he had been instructed, gunning the motor between kills. He did so now, gripping and releasing the bar trigger to rev the power unit. Minced flesh sprayed. It was already beginning to smell rotten. Satisfied the sword

would work if needed, he secured it in the scabbard clip dangling from his belt, then hunted out his pistol, checked and reloaded it. All this was done methodically. His fury had gone. He looked about for his squad in the mess of shattered bodies but was unable to find any other Blood Angels besides the corpse outside the gate. He wondered if they had all perished and he was alone. He searched between the humans piled in the coign of the ground and defence lines, hanging from bunker firing slits, littering the slope, turning them over where they were deep enough to hide a legionary. For a while he found no further sign of transhuman dead, though there was Legion equipment everywhere, weapons cast aside in favour of more intimate slaughter. The enemy had been savaged. He had not done all this himself.

He spied a black gauntlet poking from a heap of the dead.

By the time evening was well into its assault on the sky, he had found three more of his dead inductii brothers. None of them were wearing their helmets, and two had died because of that. Lasrifle shots had taken their eyes and their lives.

The last had been blasted in two. His upper body lay a metre away from his legs and pelvis. The parts were neatly divided, incongruously so, as if separated carefully and laid out for inspection. The warrior's guts were charred, the armour marked by the burns of volkite beams. Seeing these signs, Simeon experienced a flash of the battle, his own memory this time, the howling scream of the volkites coming from a knot of turncoat Solar Auxilia anchoring the garrison's centre. He looked back up the hill to their post. Where they had fought, the defence line was shattered rubble. Smoke blew over the blackened lip, the wind carrying the smell of charred meat.

He looked back into his brother's dead eyes. The glint of sentience had been extinguished. His angelically perfect face gazed at the heavens. Fibres of muscle were caught between his teeth. Simeon lost himself a while. He had barely known this man. He had been Alvic Lopen, from the Atlantean ridge hives. He had been taken by the IX Legion's recruitment masters, and become Mandeus the legionnaire. Now he was neither Lopen nor Mandeus. Now he was dead.

The first stars were coming out. Among them, the lights of the anchored fleet shimmered with implacable purpose.

'Power,' a voice said behind him.

He knew the voice – Ismael, of his squad – but he did not recognise the rank immediately, though it was his. In the Aenokhian tongue employed by the Legion, ‘power’ meant a sergeant, a reference to the hierarchies of Baal’s mythical angels.

He was not a leader of angels. He was a leader of monsters.

‘Power Simeon. Brother.’

Simeon sought out Ismael, finding him standing ten metres down the hill. The slope was steep.

‘Ismael,’ Simeon said. ‘Where are the others?’

‘Down there,’ said Ismael. His retinas flared silver in the gathering gloom, like a felid’s eyes caught in a lamp beam. ‘Simeon, you must come. You must come now.’

Simeon stared, waiting for more, too disassociated to ask for it.

‘It is Andael. He is lost.’

Simeon looked at the dead Angforia lying among their foes.

‘Not like that. His mind has gone. We have him cornered, but he is fighting us. We do not know what to do.’

Simeon still held his bolt pistol. It felt suddenly heavy in his hand. He shifted his grip. The blood on his gauntlets stuck to it. This was not the first time one of his men had lost their mind.

There was only one solution.

‘I shall see to it.’

CHAPTER FOUR

BY THE PRIMARCH'S COMMAND

Raldoron remained silent while the serfs armoured him. Once he had donned his bodyglove he took his place in the arming cradle, hands outstretched and gripping the handles on the ends of its arms, so that he resembled the sacrificed god of ancient Catherism. He relaxed, and lost himself in thought. He had had so little time to think these last months, and so seized upon every opportunity for reflection like a starving man will seize morsels of food. The purr of the cranes the mortals used to lift the heavier pieces of plate into position and the whine of power tools bolting them into place receded from his conscious mind.

He was thinking of Sanguinius and their departure from Terra.

Raldoron was present on the command deck of the Red Tear when Sanguinius delivered his address to the Reprisal Fleet. His gene-father had rarely looked so resplendent, his feathers groomed and so dazzlingly white even in the dim light emitted by screens and dulled lumen globes. Golden charms hung from his wings, glinting with artistry, each one crafted by a favoured son as a gift for their perfect father.

The primarch gave a signal: a raising of the two first fingers on his right hand, palm out. A holo-beam shone upon him, and he became as a statue illuminated by a single, carefully positioned shaft of light in the holiest of temples. Seeing him so, the exemplar of the Emperor's art, Raldoron

thought how easy it would have been for Sanguinius to cast aside the Imperial Truth and proclaim himself a god. He could have done it. Now Raldoron had seen that the universe was not so simple as the Emperor had proclaimed, that the gods He had denied were instead terrifyingly real, how easy it would have been for this veritable angel to insist on his place among them – and yet he had not. He had followed his father's will. He had accepted Horus' elevation to Warmaster over himself without demur. Sanguinius' humility was part of his perfection.

A nod from the master of vox. The feed to the fleet was ready. The Blood Angels portion of the Imperial Reprisal Fleet numbered nearly four thousand ships, twenty-seven thousand legionaries, hundreds of thousands of mortal men and women, and all were waiting for their leader to speak. Across the void at the edge of the Sol System, Raldoron imagined their collective breath held.

Sanguinius began, and his voice was a balm. Hearing him made everything seem possible, no challenge insurmountable. His voice made the war seem winnable.

'My sons, loyal servants of the Emperor, men and women of the Imperium,' the primarch began. 'I speak to you now from the Red Tear on this day of our departure, and I must speak to you of duty.'

'Many years ago, my father, the Emperor of Mankind, arose from the ruins of Old Earth with a vision to restore humanity to its rightful mastery of the stars. Salvation for we who stood upon the brink of extinction, our realms divided, our forms debased, who had fallen so far from glory. Few remembered the heights of our ancient power, and fewer still thought it could ever be regained. Yet He believed. He recalled the times of our ancestors, when our species bestrode the cosmos, when nothing seemed beyond our grasp, and eternity ours for the taking. My father knew that those times could come again.'

'From the ruination of the empires of the past, the Emperor raised us. He gave us purpose, saving us from the perils of the alien, of Old Night, of human folly, uniting the disparate kingdoms of humanity and crafting from the ruins of ages this Imperium which we all now so proudly serve.'

'My brother Horus threatens all my father strove for. His betrayal pains me still, he who was once dearest to me, who was once the most loyal of all of my brothers, he whom I loved the most. He was given the highest honours

by our father, and yet he did not thank Him, nor hold love for Him in his heart, but turned his face from Him, and spat upon his oaths of loyalty, risking the end of our species for his own selfishness. Corrupted by his own power, consumed by pride, humility burned to nothing by his naked lust for power. He, who claims the Emperor lies, endangers our entire race.'

The Great Angel bowed his head.

'It is our duty to stop him. Out there, in the stars, he approaches. His armies lay waste to the Garmon Cluster. If he triumphs there the road to Sol will be open, and if that happens it is inevitable that his warriors will tread the soil of Terra herself.

'We cannot let this happen. The Emperor has charged us with stopping Horus at Garmon. We do not stand alone. Already my brother Jaghatai Khan heads to do battle there. Within the cluster, millions of loyal Imperial warriors await our arrival. With them at our side, we shall throw back my fallen brother and his deluded followers. With your courage, your dedication, your will to remain unbowed, we shall bring this war to an end.'

Everyone on the command deck, baseline human and legionary alike, regarded the primarch raptly. It was the same across the fleet. In every space with a holo-projector, round every voxmitter and viewscreen, from the highest spire to the lowest, most crowded compartment, men and women watched and listened.

'I do not say this will be easy. I do not promise that we shall return together in triumph, and yet we must try. We must exert ourselves, we who have given so much already. It is in the spirit of the Emperor's great dream that I stand before you, and ask of you once more to give of yourselves. It is in the spirit of hope that I ask you to lay down your lives. Hope that humanity may yet triumph, that we may bring peace to the galaxy, that the traitors may be halted, and the work of the Great Crusade completed. Join with me. Fight with me. If not in certainty, then in the hope that has carried us this far already. I ask of you only that which I ask of myself. Fight with me, for the Imperium, for the Emperor, and for the future.'

The holo-beam went out. A moment of silence so profound Raldoron suspected he would never experience the like again descended across the fleet. He could feel it, a quiet greater than that of the void. Then it was gone; the command deck erupted into wild cheers and applause. A chant went up of, 'Sanguinius! Sanguinius! Sanguinius!'

The Great Angel put his fist upon his breast in salute to his followers. Raldoron wondered if he alone could see the sadness hidden behind the gesture.

How it should have been him, Raldoron thought, as he watched Sanguinius go among his officers, speaking with them, listening to them, laying reassuring hands upon their shoulders. Each interaction bore up the recipient of the primarch's attention, making them stand more steadily. Yes, Raldoron thought, choosing Horus over Sanguinius as Warmaster was the Emperor's most singular error.

The ships were already under way before the crowds broke up and went back to their duties, faces suffused with light after so many months of darkness. Yet when Sanguinius stopped to greet him, Raldoron once more saw the flicker of doubt in his eyes.

Plates were brought carefully into position around Raldoron's left arm. Plugs clicked into the sockets in his upper and lower arms, the spikes that conveyed his neural impulses to his armour meshing with his nervous system. The sensation was unique, a sort of short-lived needling along the line of each nerve. The plates were closed. The retaining bolts drilled home. At a nod from his armourer, Raldoron flexed his arms, banishing the sensation.

Sanguinius had not told the whole truth. Lies were the hallmark of this war, perhaps of the Imperium entire. Horus was, in a sense, correct. The Emperor had lied from the beginning. Raldoron had learned that at Signus. In his speech, Sanguinius had not mentioned the unspeakable, inhuman powers that waited beyond the fringes of reality, nor that those beings hungered for the reality of the materium, and would consume it utterly if they could. Horus had been right – the Emperor had lied. And yet, Raldoron did not resent Him for it. Knowledge like that was too bleak for mortal minds to entertain.

What troubled Raldoron most was not lies, but the hope Sanguinius spoke of, because hope was something the primarch no longer felt. Raldoron had seen that the last time they met, the day before the Reprisal Fleet had split.

'Raldoron, my favoured son.' The Great Angel greeted him cordially, his affection undimmed, yet there was something to his movement, a lessening

of his usual fluidity and grace that suggested the burden he carried, and Raldoron recalled the flickers of doubt he had caught in his father's eyes upon the command deck. 'You are ready to depart?'

'I am, my lord,' Raldoron said. It troubled him, he who was imperturbable, to see his father bowed, even so little. 'I have my plans, if you wish to examine them?'

'It will not be necessary,' Sanguinius said. 'I trust you to carry through my orders, most steadfast of my warriors.'

The plans had been discussed at length, in any case, at a council of war days before. Raldoron was to take a substantial part of the fleet, some four hundred ships carrying more than two thousand Blood Angels of the First and 107th companies – of whom several hundred were Angforia recently raised on Terra – the prime cohort of the 46th Saiphan Elevatii Solar Auxilia, and numerous assets from less vaunted Imperial Army formations. Such a complement of legionaries, supported by forty thousand mortals under arms, had been a force sufficient to conquer alien kingdoms and lost human worlds alike during the crusade. Now that they were facing their own kind, men enhanced and armed as they were, victory was far from assured.

Raldoron's orders were simple. He was to leave the main body of the Legion fleet and sweep through the so-called Minoris-Garmon worlds to oust traitor garrisons and gather up as many loyal men as he could, before driving on to rejoin Sanguinius in the inner systems.

'Sit with me a while,' said Sanguinius. 'I have nothing of very much consequence to discuss. I only desired to speak with you before you departed, as we once did.'

'As you wish, my lord.'

Sanguinius led him to a table set out with a modest meal, each of the seven dishes presented on ceramic plates of exquisite artistry, the rims bearing abstract patterns, the flat bases mythical heroes.

'Will you eat?' Sanguinius poured wine into a heavy brass goblet and handed it to Raldoron. No servants waited upon him. The perfect angel served his son by his own hand.

'Gladly.'

They ate and talked a while. Sanguinius only touched on Raldoron's objectives. Mostly he seemed regretful about their lack of recent contact.

‘We have had so little time to speak with one another these last days. We once enjoyed such easy intimacies,’ Sanguinius said. ‘You are often at my side, but we rarely converse like we used to.’

‘Times have changed for the worse, my lord,’ Raldoron said. ‘We both have much to occupy us.’

‘So they have,’ Sanguinius said, ‘and I have much to accomplish...’ He stopped, put his goblet down. He met Raldoron’s eyes.

It could have been solipsism, but such was the effect the primarch had on those with whom he interacted, it was possible to think oneself uniquely blessed above all others. As unlikely as it sounded, Raldoron believed that might be true, at least in a sense. Sanguinius cared deeply about everyone under his charge. Raldoron remembered the night they had first met on Baal; that tendency to care had been clear from the moment he had set eyes on his sire. Even before Sanguinius had changed Raldoron’s life forever, the primarch’s kindness had saved the Legion from its days of savagery, raised them up and made them anew. Sanguinius had shown them all the goodness in their hearts, changing them from the despised revenants of old into a glorious brotherhood of angels. Still, it saddened Raldoron also, for behind Sanguinius’ perfect face was a perfect soul, and upon that soul the glum weight of a perfect sorrow. Though Raldoron was among Sanguinius’ favoured sons, there existed a gulf of being between them that no kindness could bridge, no matter how strongly one might try. The difference between man and primarch was simply too great.

‘We might have a chance to set things right,’ Sanguinius said. ‘The Ruinstorm is over. The powers that aid my brother have suffered a blow.’

Bold words, yet the primarch’s melancholy continued to press on Raldoron.

‘Will we succeed? What do you really see, my father?’

Sanguinius’ shoulders tensed a little, sending a shiver through his furled wings.

‘I cannot tell you. How we judge our efforts depends on what our definition of success is. We shall surely detain Horus, and he shall bleed. We will weaken his hosts. Every day he is held at Garmon brings the Legions of my loyal brothers a day closer, and another day for Dorn to reinforce the defences of Terra.’ He looked away, golden eyes piercing the veil of time. ‘But can we stop him? That is unclear, and my fear says no,

where my foresight fails me. Whatever occurs, an end of one sort or another is approaching. I feel it as a great blackness on the horizons of my perceptions, crowding in the future. I...'

The slightest frown creased the flawless skin between his eyebrows. He broke off again. This reluctance to finish his thoughts was a new habit. Raldoron feared it was born of certainties that could not, at that moment, be voiced.

'It is some time away.' His gene-father smiled tightly. 'We must do what we can, the Emperor can ask no more of us than that.'

Raldoron nodded. He had never been an effusive man. He preferred to think rather than talk, but at that moment he felt the need to say something to alleviate his father's suffering.

'Then I shall do as you and He command.'

'Who can say what effort will avail us, in the end?' said Sanguinius. 'Be cautious – that is all the counsel I may offer, and what use is it telling you, my most level-headed of sons, to take care?' The primarch's smile warmed. 'Do your duty, Raldoron, as I know you shall. Gather the scattered warriors of the Minoris-Garmon worlds. Make me an army to be proud of.' He tapped the table with one slender finger, almost as pale as the marble top. 'I have a boon for you. To ensure we shall meet again at the core systems, I am sending you three of my own Seraphim to guard you.'

'It is not necessary—'

'It is already done, my son. Do not begrudge me this small act of protection.'

'Then I thank you, father.'

They conversed a while longer, discussing more pleasant things: memories of the past, the achievements of Raldoron's company, how the Imperium might heal from this terrible betrayal. Things less connected to the immediacy of the task at hand, though never free from war.

While Horus lived, how could they ever be free from that?

Raldoron's armour was all in place except his power unit, gauntlets, and helm. Arrayed for battle he cut a severe figure, his plate being artfully constructed but free of the adornment favoured by others of his Legion.

With a small, silent gesture, the lead thrall indicated Raldoron might come down from the cradle, and so the Archein released the grips from the

cruciform rack, and held out his hands in front of himself. Reverently, a pair of thralls on either side slipped his gauntlets on and locked them into place. He stepped heavily from the foot plates, stoically bearing the immense weight of the unpowered armour. He stood a moment while the thralls wheeled the cradle away, then they guided him backwards to where the power pack hung from the wall. Raldoron took a final forceful step, slamming the mating lug into the pack's socket. Clamps locked. With a thought, he activated the reactor unit, sending power into his armour. Immediately the ceramite's great weight lessened.

Moving easily now, he went to his armaments cabinet. His weapons were as simple as his armour. Where others might favour exotic paragon blades, or specialised charnabal swords, he carried the *Encarmine Warblade*, a plain power sword, paired with an equally simple bolt pistol. No arcane guns of alien or ancient provenance for him. This wargear had served well for over a century, and he had no desire to replace any of it nor to smother it in gold. He hung the sheath and holster from his belt, took his sword and gun from their pegs, and put them in their places. His thralls then wheeled his helmet to him upon a gurney. He waited while two of them climbed short ladders behind him to hang his cloak, a purely decorative mark of office, from his armour, brooches locking magnetically in place.

He took up his helm but did not don it.

'I am ready,' he said to the thralls. 'I thank you for your diligence. Your work was smoothly done.'

They bowed in gratitude. He left.

A short shuttle flight away, the victorious lading clans of Thorne's Landing awaited him. He had words of praise, talk of ultimate victory, an outline of the demands their planet would be expected to bear. The clan lords who had fought so hard to keep the world out of Horus' hands expected these things. They would hear his words of congratulation with pride. They would accept his condolences for their losses. They would not expect Raldoron's orders that most of them leave their homes forever to fight for the Emperor, and that their youth be gathered to be remade into angels. He anticipated that they would grimly obey; only later, when they realised their world would ultimately be abandoned and their children lost to them forever, would they become aggrieved. By then, most of them would be dead.

Raldoron pitied them, but there was no other way.

Thus it was with a heavy heart he met with Marshal Faisal Subarai-Almazi, Dominion Vallis, Forgemaster Arnovael, Primus Medicae Laertes and the rest of the force's chief officers on the embarkation deck. Together they took ship and flew down to the Carnery, the largest of the world's space ports. There, on landing aprons of rockcrete already shimmering in the heat of the morning, tens of thousands of battle-weary clansmen would be told that their war was far from over.

CHAPTER FIVE

COUNCIL OF WAR

Frantic activity followed Raldoron's speech. The clansmen took his news better than he could have hoped, and the majority pledged themselves to his service there and then. There were only a few desertions, and therefore few executions. Raldoron felt it went as well as it could have.

Then came the real work.

It is a monumental undertaking to empty a world of supplies and armies. Nonetheless, it was accomplished by Raldoron's fleet in a matter of weeks. Hundreds of thousands of hands working together might lift the heaviest burden. Sanguinius had furnished Raldoron's flotilla with dozens of troop transporters, and the greatest effort went into gathering the clan militia, structuring them into something approaching standard regimental organisation, and getting them into orbit. The skies were filled with shuttlecraft and lighters, the roar of their engines never ceasing, their nav-lights garlanding the world in chains of blues, reds, and greens.

When all was done, and all left behind on Thorne's Landing were weeping for those who were taken, the fleet prepared to set sail. Raldoron was eager to be away. Although their initial foray from Delta-Garmon into the minoris worlds had taken the enemy off guard, after reconquering four systems, news of the Blood Angels' advance would now be widespread. Speed was necessary to preserve what little advantage of surprise they maintained, and

so he called his officers to him, and laid out their goals for the coming weeks.

Transhumans and humans filled the principal strategium of the *Promissum Sanguinem*. Holo-projections of the sector floated in ghostly hosts over the assembled officers, whose eyes reflected back a hundred different versions of miniature, light-woven star maps.

‘Our next target is One-Four-Seven-Gamma Minoris-Garmon. Local name, Gallia,’ Raldoron told them in his usual straightforward way. He had a display centred on the system that hosted the world. Beside 147, three lifeless balls of rock and a single moonless giant orbited a feeble orange star. A parsimonious measure of asteroids divided inner from outer worlds.

‘This system may seem to present a target of low military significance,’ the Archein continued. Datatags unrolled themselves, showing pre-war population, major exports, tithing level, and other statistics of interest. ‘Gallia is an agri world of middling grade. The population is low. It is off the major warp conduits. However, two Imperial Army regiments supported by elements of the Three-Hundred-and-Fifty-Sixth Armoured and Twenty-Ninth Saturnyne Heavy Assault Solar Auxilia were caught there in transit when the war began and have been stranded since. In conjunction with local forces, these regiments have been holding the world against all odds for the last six years. Thanks to the disturbances in the warp, One-Four-Seven-Gamma’s astropathic messages are garbled, but so far as we can ascertain there have been at least three separate attempts to seize the world by the traitors. These attacks have been repulsed. The addition of One-Four-Seven-Gamma’s forces will further bolster the Reprisal Fleet. Additionally, our last intelligence suggests that the planet’s food production facilities were largely intact as of a year ago. Terra is starving. Any supplies that can be brought up from the world’s stores or harvested while we are in a position to protect them must be gathered, to which end I am willing to delay there for a period of up to two weeks. Therefore, our aims remain twofold, as they have been so far – the collection of men and war materiel for the battles to come, and the acquisition of sustenance for Terra. We must be aware that the enemy will attempt to deprive us of both. All battle plans have been drawn to accommodate these goals. They will remain your priority throughout.’

‘We are not to move on One-Three-Nine Minoris-Garmon?’ Captain Assan Faisal-Almazi asked. He was taller than his father, but that aside the

resemblance between them was striking: the same hawkish nose, clever eyes always in motion, drawing in as much information as possible. Raldoron caught the look the father cast his son, half approving that he had been bold enough to speak, half warning him not to question the Archein's judgement.

‘Our plans have changed,’ Raldoron said. ‘Five days ago we received an astropathic message from Gallia requesting aid. They are facing a fresh assault. From what we can tell, several ships of the Death Guard were detected making their way in from the system edge. Therefore, this world has now become our priority.’

‘Then what strength shall we be facing?’ General Molvis asked this question. He had been elected by the lading clans of Thorne's Landing to be their leader. The rank was entirely self-assigned – the man had been an aristo-bureaucrat before the war – but Raldoron did not dispute Molvis' right to the title. He had learned the craft of battle well.

‘As of now, it is unclear. So far as we can tell, the Death Guard are not present in the Garmon theatre of war in any great number. I would estimate a low legionary presence. Solar Auxilia regiments bonded to the Fourteenth Legion have been active in this subsector. Refugee reports collated at Delta-Garmon spoke of “poison ships” escorted by legionary auxiliaries laying waste to several lightly defended worlds over the last few months, largely through the use of proscribed weaponry – virus, high-rad, phosphex, and other poisons.’

Dominion Vallis of the 107th Company spoke. ‘The enemy stepped up their efforts once the Reprisal Fleet broke warp at Delta-Garmon. Their pattern of activity suggests a new strategy on the part of the Warmaster's armies, in this part of the cluster, at least.’ Though normally a cheerful soul, just then Vallis was uncharacteristically grave. ‘Scorched earth rather than retention and defence.’

‘Then we have them worried,’ said Assan through a thin smile.

There was a smattering of laughter. Raldoron liked the man – his father was right in being proud – but he frowned at Assan's levity. Humour was rarely at the fore of the Archein's mind, and at times like this he deemed it inappropriate.

‘Worried or not, we must approach cautiously,’ Raldoron said. ‘The enemy know the supply lines to Terra are squeezed. They may rise to meet us.’ He

looked to the men in the room with a serious countenance. ‘Though the enemy has turned on the Emperor, and embraced insane beliefs, it does not mean they are beyond rationality. While we have enjoyed success, resistance to our advance is gathering. We must be quick.’

Raldoron expanded the field of view depicted on the holo. ‘The attack could also be a diversion to pull us away from One-Three-Nine Minoris-Garmon, so they might attack there while we are occupied at One-Four-Seven. One-Three-Nine is well fortified and supplied, but it is my judgement that additional resources would enable them to hold out longer if the assault on Gallia is a ruse. Therefore, I have decided to dispatch a second force aboard the *Selene*, the *Audovar* and the *Purview* to provide defence while extraction of military assets is undertaken. Dominion Isma will lead. Solar marshal, if you would suggest an officer to direct the mortal contingent, I would find it most welcome.’

‘It will be done, my lord Archein,’ said Faisal.

‘Further emissaries will be sent with small contingents of troops, transport ships and escorts to One-Three-One, One-Three-Two and One-One-Five Minoris-Garmon to oversee the collection of assets based on those worlds. I doubt you will face any opposition,’ he said, looking at the human officers he had chosen to lead these missions. ‘They lie far from the front, deep within Imperial territory. One-Four-Seven and One-Three-Nine are the larger prizes, and we cannot be everywhere at once. If you are challenged, you are to run.’

Murmurs of ‘Yes, Archein’ were returned by the group.

‘My lords, bold officers, my brothers – the chronometer runs fast. It is time to begin planning our voyage to the core. Our efforts here are drawing to a close.’

He looked around the room. Eager faces, for the most part; not sure of victory, but not despairing.

‘My lord generals, I do not split our forces lightly, even to this minimal degree. Our targets are broadly spread, and all are at risk. We work against stiff odds, under pressure of time. Nevertheless, we shall fulfil our orders. The lord Sanguinius has put his trust in us all. I will not see the primarch disappointed. If any of you have questions about your role, come to me personally. I will be available from the third watch bell. Is that clear?’

More murmurs of assent. Raldoron did not expect many would need further clarification. Sanguinius had been generous with the quality of officers he had provided.

‘For Sanguinius!’ Vallis called.

‘For the Emperor! For Terra!’ men and transhumans responded together. The meeting broke up.

Vallis hung back while Raldoron spoke with General Molvis. The dock lord kept up a stern front, but he was nervous for all that. He had little experience dealing with the Astartes directly as anything other than enemies. Raldoron did his best to quiet the general’s fears, and it transpired all he wanted was more training for his men during the transit to Gallia, something Raldoron gladly granted. The militiamen of Thorne’s Landing had been effective guerrillas, but were not yet true soldiers. A few more minor matters, short conversations with officers requiring guidance and support, then it was over. The last of them left. Only then did Vallis approach Raldoron.

‘Are we concluded here?’

Raldoron’s eyes lingered on the star charts, seeking out details he might have missed. ‘We are,’ he said finally, forcing himself to turn away. The strategy had been set in motion. He could not endlessly tinker with it.

‘Then might we attend to our other matter? I need your advice, Archein.’ Vallis frowned. ‘I will not lie, some of what I am to show you makes for troubling viewing.’

‘Now?’

‘If you have the time.’

‘I shall make some.’

CHAPTER SIX

TACTICARIUM

The tacticaria were quiet in those dark days. During the Crusade there had always been something to learn, some new xenos abomination to study and overcome, some bizarre alien technology to counter. In those times, Raldoron had spent many hours assessing the performance of his men, seeking out improvements in training, formation and tactics. After the initial shock of having to fight their cousins, and the scramble to model Legion versus Legion warfare, the tacticaria had fallen idle. Beneath their idiosyncrasies, Space Marines used similar methods, and each Legion's preferences were understood by the others thanks to long familiarity. The last time Raldoron had dedicated much time to such study, he had been trying to learn something of the Neverborn the Legion had faced at Signus, but more often than not recordings of them were corrupted, as if the machines recoiled from holding their images, and his efforts had yielded little.

There were a handful of human technicians in the room where once there had been dozens. Most of the cogitator terminals were inactive, their operators assigned to more pressing duties. The Blood Angels' desire for beauty still prevailed, and the room was scrupulously clean. Not a speck of dust had been permitted to settle, yet a sepulchral air gathered thickly, and Vallis and Raldoron found themselves dropping the volume of their voices.

They went to a row of terminals designed for armoured legionaries. There were no seats. The terminals were meant to be viewed standing. Of the eight, six were covered in tight plastek wrap. Only one was humming with internal activity, the screens mounted high off the floor, glowing with readiness. Laertes awaited them by the machine, dressed in his medical robes, his huge forearms bare.

‘Primus Medicae Laertes,’ Raldoron greeted him.

‘Archein.’ Vallis gave a signal to a thrall in Legion uniform. The man went away to work a smaller console. Forty or so thumbnail vid-capt's blinked onto the screen. ‘This is the helm feed from the assault on the Thirty-Seventh’s command post.’

For the moment, the images showed inductii preparing for battle, taken by the capters integrated into their helms.

‘I sent in two squads,’ said Vallis. ‘After our discussions some weeks past, I deemed this position a good test of their capabilities. This was the first time they had operated without direct oversight. I wanted a challenge, but I did not want to employ too many at once.’

‘I advised him against deploying them alone, even in such low numbers. The incident on Borcan gave me pause. They are unstable.’

‘I am aware of this, Laertes.’ Raldoron cupped his chin in the angle of his thumb and forefinger. ‘I gave Vallis permission to grant them combat autonomy myself. If you see any fault in this, it lies with me.’

‘Then I must say that I do not agree it is a good idea to continue autonomous operations with these neophytes,’ said Laertes.

‘What use are they if they cannot fight on their own?’ Raldoron said.

‘Though some of them lost control at Borcan, in prior engagements, most squads have otherwise performed as well as any new unit.’ Vallis pushed a button and a subsidiary screen displayed lists of combat statistics. ‘Eighty per cent effectiveness in direct comparison with legionaries of five years’ service. They are learning fast.’

‘Their instability is inherent,’ said Laertes. ‘We already have eighteen documented incidents of neophytes succumbing to the Thirst and losing tactical coherency in battle.’

‘I hear they lost themselves a while here, but returned to lucidity. Do not overlook the fact that they won the battle,’ Raldoron said. The views on the screen were moving, swinging with the jogging stride of the men, giving a

mosaic impression of an advance out of cover towards the base of a hill. As soon as they were out of the trees, streaks of tracer and las fire cut the air.

Laertes' expression was stony. The struggle between the need for manpower and his duty to the Legion's purity was clear. 'Then I ask that recruitment is slowed until the problems are addressed,' he said finally.

'We shall see,' said Raldoron.

'You need to watch this, Raldoron. My words are not sufficient,' Vallis said, drawing the Archein's attention back to the screen. 'What you will see reminds me of Signus.'

Raldoron looked at him sharply.

'Even Vallis agrees with me on that,' said Laertes.

The Angforia squads were running, their armour powering them quickly up the slope. Most of them were clad in new suits of Mark VI armour.

'Their battle gear, at least, is performing well,' Raldoron said. It was lighter than earlier marks, its engineering more sophisticated than all but the fourth, and allowed the wearer a greater degree of movement than any other pattern. Heavy boots pushed great clods of earth out of the ground, sending slips of material down the hill behind them, yet the men did not stumble, but moved upwards with frightening speed through the storm of fire. Lack of supply dictated that they were armed with simple weaponry. All of them bore chainswords and bolt pistols, nothing more potent. They fired as they advanced, their accuracy commendable given the difficulty of the terrain.

Traitor Solar Auxilia and Imperial Army leaned out to fire from the shelter of defence lines built into the top of the mountain. Their guns, a mix of lasrifles and solid-shot autoguns, did little against the Space Marines. Two of the Angforia were felled by lucky shots. In return, many baseline humans died, their bodies ripped to shreds of flesh and bone by bolt rounds. Only the heavier armour of the Solar Auxilia mingled among the levy was any protection. Only the few volkites they carried posed a real threat. The enemy had some heavier weapons, but they were of little use, as the angle of the slope prevented them drawing firing lines.

'Who conceived of this plan of attack?' Raldoron asked.

'Power Simeon – he is the leader of the One Hundred and Forty-Second Squad. He is gifted. That was clear enough during combat indoctrination.' Vallis gestured at green text scrolling down a subsidiary screen. 'He was promoted to the rank of Power soon after his elevation.'

‘He is bold. This is a difficult approach, but clever. I see the enemy did not expect a direct ground assault from this direction. The angles are in our favour, the defences weaker.’

‘It is the Power we are to watch,’ said Vallis. He brought Simeon’s helm view to the fore.

The screen showed a rush of motion. Bullets sprayed off the Space Marine’s armour. Lasguns stitched dazzling lines around him. Simeon reached the first defence line, ran up the talus and vaulted the steeper wall topping it, landing amid the panicked defenders. There the real killing began. Simeon’s chainsword flashed around him. There was no audex capture, so they watched the Blood Angel’s victims die silently screaming. An army trooper lifted a pistol. He lost his hand, then his life. A Solar Auxilia officer came at Simeon, wielding a power sword. He was confident. He was skilful. He lasted seconds against Simeon, who knocked him down after parrying the first blow, and stamped his head flat. The cost to the Power was a handful of chain teeth lost from his sword.

A black smear passed across the view. Fingers groped at the helm, hooked under it. The feed cut out as it was wrenched free.

‘He removed his helmet,’ said Vallis.

‘I can see that.’

‘Then you can also see that the Thirst claws mercilessly at these warriors,’ Laertes said. ‘At this point, Simeon loses himself to frenzy along with the rest of his men.’

Vallis switched to another view. This warrior died to a melta shot, but before his armour systems blew out, Raldoron got a clear view of Simeon biting out the throat of a cowering man. All across the battlefield, the neophytes were tearing off their helms, casting aside their weapons, going berserk.

Vallis switched between various helm feeds, giving a confusion of overlaid imagery that nevertheless conveyed one clear message: the Angforia had abandoned themselves to the Thirst, almost all of them, and early into their battle.

Vallis reached for the controls again. Raldoron caught his wrist.

‘There is more,’ said Vallis.

‘I have seen enough,’ said Raldoron. ‘How many dead?’

‘Seven.’

Raldoron's eyes narrowed. 'Seven legionaries lost to baseline traitors?'

'As you said, they won. Their fury carried the day,' said Vallis with heavy irony.

'What if they had come against legionaries? What if this position had been held by the Fourteenth or the Fourth? They would have died to a man,' Laertes said.

'You are right to show this to me,' Raldoron said. 'Nevertheless, we need these warriors.'

'I am afraid it becomes worse,' said Laertes. 'One of them, by the name of Andael, did not return to himself. The Thirst did not abate once combat had finished.'

'This has happened before,' said Raldoron. 'It is not insurmountable. The loss of one is acceptable.'

Laertes nodded. 'Perhaps, but this time, Andael killed one of his brothers.'

'I see,' Raldoron said. 'Where is this Andael now?'

'He too is dead. Simeon executed him, after his brothers managed to restrain him.'

'We have the combat record for that moment also,' said Vallis.

'There is no need to replay it for me,' said Raldoron. 'So, nine warriors dead from forty?'

'Thirty-four, Archein.'

'High casualties,' Laertes stated.

'And your recommendation is to remove these men from frontline duty?'

'It troubles me to say so, Archein. As you say, we need the men. But temporarily, yes,' said Laertes.

'Vallis, what do you say?'

'We must use them as we find them, Archein. We do not have the manpower to put them into reserve. Their anger can be harnessed. In earlier engagements, they performed well.'

'Only when watched closely,' countered Laertes. 'It will reduce the efficacy of the rest of the Legion if we are nursemaiding recruits.'

'They are not many. We can accommodate them,' said Vallis, but his tone was doubtful.

'It is certain we will come to deploy more and more units like these as the war goes on,' said Raldoron.

'I would rather not do so, knowing what we do,' said Laertes.

‘Then you must find a way.’ Raldoron thought a moment. ‘Vallis is right. I say reluctantly that we have no choice but to deploy them. The mortification index predicts high casualties. If we cannot replenish our ranks, then we will fail as a fighting force. When Horus gets to Terra’ – he looked at his officers – ‘and I mean *when*, if these Angforia cannot serve, then neither will those recruits that follow them, and then what use will we be? We need replenishment. What exactly is causing these issues?’

‘The compressed timescale of implantation,’ said Laertes. ‘The hypnomat, lack of care given to implantation, the short training period, the speed of deployment. A combination of all of them is having a destabilising effect on their biochemistry. Our lord’s gene-seed demands more care than this. Further, most are Terran, and their beliefs are culturally incompatible with ours. A high proportion are suffering from a form of identity crisis – they are disassociated, in a deep mental shock. All of these things together make a poor psychological basis for managing the Thirst. Imagine if they were exposed to the same malign influences we suffered at Signus. What we see here is only the start of our problems.’

‘To me, this scale of recruitment is reminiscent of the days of the Revenant Legion,’ said Raldoron. ‘The Legion rebuilt itself many times before the primarch came, often at speed, and with similar results. We were known for our bloodlust, until Lord Sanguinius lifted us up from savagery. There were problems, too, between Terran-born and the recruits from Baal at the start. If he could meld us together, and change our hearts, then we can do it again. I agree that the speed of implantation can be slowed, but recruitment cannot be stopped.’

‘Perhaps if we relied less on the direct implantation of knowledge, and slowed the process down, using traditional methods of training...’ Laertes lifted an equivocal hand. The neural plugs in his forearm glinted in the light of the displays. ‘I believe the crucial phases to arrest psychological dissonance are during the final implantation stages and in training. Even so, changes we implement now will not help the legionaries we have already created.’

‘Continue with implantation of the new tithings. Take the newest warriors, those still undergoing training, off the hypnomat. We have two weeks before we reach One-Four-Seven – we will be in transit for eight more en route to Beta-Garmon once we are finished with these lesser worlds. No

new warrior is to be committed to combat before we arrive at the core. Intensify live training. Sequester veteran sergeants to lead, one for every forty neophytes. Bestow upon them the rank of Lesser Dominion – that should blunt any protest.’

‘What about those under arms? Will these methods work for them? Come the main fight for the cluster, we will need them,’ said Vallis.

‘Increase their time in the foundries and workshops. Have them practise our arts. They are ready to fight – their skill is not lacking, their control is. I want the more capable of them used to reinforce existing squads, at your discretion, of course, Laertes. Let them learn from our veterans.’

‘The veterans will disapprove,’ said Vallis.

‘Then they need to learn to see them as brothers, not as problems.’

Raldoron’s companions still looked doubtful.

‘Come now, brothers, it cannot be impossible. I hear Dominion Crohne of the Ninety-Fourth has had good results with his Angforia.’

‘All you command shall be done,’ said Laertes.

‘Archein,’ said Vallis. ‘I have a request.’

‘Which is?’ said Raldoron.

‘Speak to the Angforia. A few words from you will go further than a thousand from me.’

‘I cannot pass up the opportunity to spare them one of your speeches,’ said Raldoron.

A ghost of Vallis’ usual smile haunted his lips. ‘Matters must have reached a sorry pass if Raldoron jests.’

‘Despite what you might have heard, Vallis, I do have a sense of humour. Not much of one, I admit, but it is there.’ Raldoron passed his hand over his head in an unaccustomed show of tiredness, causing ceramite to rasp on stubble. ‘I will speak first with this Simeon alone. Have him come to my chambers. Make plans to assemble the rest for first watch tomorrow. All of them. Do it here, on the *Promissum Sanguinem*’s embarkation deck. I will address them while we are under way to the Mandeville point, before we hit the warp.’

‘I will see it done.’

Raldoron stood back, the better to address both men at once. He spoke a little more firmly, a little more loudly, not caring if he disturbed the melancholy of the tactarium. ‘Eyes forward to the future, brothers,’ he

said. ‘Do not fear the return of the past. Those days are done. We will make Blood Angels of these recruits, I swear.’

CHAPTER SEVEN

A POISONED SOUL

Raldoron was examining the iron mask when his thrall Quincus announced the arrival of Simeon. The dull iron features, so crudely shaped, caught his attention more and more these days. For decades it had sat ignored in his quarters in whatever ship he had travelled on, little more than a grotesque paperweight. Now, its crooked mouth and wide eyes, at once fearsome and fearful, invaded his thoughts. It seemed pertinent, somehow. An ugly mask that hid an uglier truth.

‘The Power Simeon, One Hundred and Forty-Second Angforia Squad,’ Quincus announced, breaking Raldoron out of his introspection.

‘Send him in.’

Simeon entered cautiously, making Raldoron suspect that Vallis had given him no clear idea why he had been summoned. His expression was not quite composed enough to conceal that he expected censure; it revealed not fear – Space Marines rarely suffered that – but a guarded anticipation of pain or shame. Even so, his eyes darted curiously about the many objects Raldoron had in his chamber, resting on the artworks, the ancient gauntlet in its crystal case, the examples of weaponry borne by races now extinct in the display unit built into the wall.

‘Sit down, Power Simeon,’ Raldoron said.

There were several chairs sized for the legionaries in the room. Raldoron often hosted meetings in there, when he wanted to be away from the bustle

of the strategium and command deck. Calm helped him marshal his thoughts. Simeon glanced behind him, selected the nearest chair, and set it down before Raldoron's desk. A construction of leather and heavy wood big enough for a mortal child to sleep on, the chair creaked under his weight when he sat.

Though he possessed the over-muscled bulk of a Space Marine, Simeon was no more than a boy. The Legions had abandoned many of their recruitment strictures, and were taking whoever tested compatible for their gene-seed from every planet they visited. The youth of Terran hives fought alongside back-world villagers. The children of Thorne's Landing would soon join them. No matter their origin, they were pressed into service as soon as the implantation process was done, little better than cannon fodder. With induction programmes accelerated to less than a year, that meant Simeon could be as young as nineteen Terran years. He wasn't much older than that, Raldoron was sure.

Simeon certainly looked like a Blood Angel. A little heavier built than some, but like all of them his features had been overwritten by the glorious beauty of Sanguinius. His eyes were pale, like the primarch's, and the bristles of his close-cropped hair gleamed gold. There was however a certain blandness about him, a carelessly manufactured beauty. He reminded Raldoron of a copy of an artwork stamped out by machines.

'Archein Raldoron, you summoned me.'

'I did. Be at ease. I wished to commend you for your battle plan in the Ventasi Range.'

Simeon appeared surprised, then relieved. 'Thank you, my lord. I serve the Legion and the primarch. It was a great honour to be given the—'

Raldoron silenced him with a look. 'I also wish to speak to you of your experiences with the Thirst, and the actions you were forced to undertake after the battle.'

The young Space Marine looked down, and his cheeks coloured. 'You mean our loss of control. It shames me.' He looked up, and he was anguished. 'I do not know what it means.'

'You know that it is the burden of all Blood Angels to bear,' said Raldoron.

'Even you, Archein?'

'Even I.' Raldoron got up, went to the crystal case holding the gauntlet, and unlocked it. 'The Emperor granted us many gifts, Simeon. We are

hardy, strong, ageless. We do not forget. We do not fear.’ He removed the gauntlet from its stand and brought it out carefully. ‘We of the Ninth are especially blessed, because we are the sons of the Emperor’s most perfect son. Sanguinius is a true angel. He alone is completely noble in thought and deed. There is no match to him among his brothers. We should be proud to be his.’ He held the gauntlet in his hands, the weight of it still familiar even after so long. ‘Yet there is a price to pay for this privilege, a poison of the mind we must overcome, a battle only will can fight. We are human, and cannot easily carry the weight of his perfection.’ He placed the gauntlet on the wooden desk in front of Simeon. ‘That is the anger you feel, Simeon. We are not alone in suffering this choler. You see it in the fury of the World Eaters, and the viciousness of the Night Lords. We were made as weapons. It is only right that anger be a tool, but ours is difficult, for with the righteous fury of combat comes a thirst.’ He put his hand on the gauntlet. ‘I wore this glove for many years. During that time I suffered as you did yesterday. Again, and again, and again.’

Raldoron took his hand away from the gauntlet.

‘Pick it up.’

Simeon reached out, then hesitated.

‘Take it,’ Raldoron commanded. ‘Feel its weight.’

Simeon overcame his reluctance and picked it up. ‘It is heavy.’

‘It is an old model,’ said Raldoron. ‘Less sophisticated than the armour you wear, but sufficient to carry the crusade across the galaxy.’

Simeon moved the glove from side to side. The unpowered fingers slackly opened and closed, wrinkling the soft-seal glove that held the gauntlet together. He repeated the motion aimlessly, the half-absorbed fidgeting of a boy.

‘Its weight does not reside in ceramite alone. Ill deeds make it heavy. You can feel them, the things I did. You hold my sins in your hands,’ Raldoron said. ‘Tell me what happened to you. I have seen the combat records, but I want to hear your own words.’

The youth shrugged, put the gauntlet down. He could not meet the Archein’s eyes.

‘I lost myself. That is the only way I can describe it. I was in control, leading my men up the slope, then the blood began to flow, the smell of it...’ His eyes closed momentarily. ‘I could not shut it out. It called to me. I

removed my helmet. After that, I recall nothing until the setting sun flashed into my eyes, and my senses returned...' Painful emotions halted his words. 'I did not expect this evil. Why did they not tell us?'

'You were told,' Raldoron said plainly, though not unkindly.

'Afterwards! Only after we were chosen. We were told we were to be made into warriors to serve the Emperor, not...' He lifted his hands helplessly, shifted uncomfortably in his seat. His hands fell, as did his gaze. 'Not beasts.'

'You were told,' said Raldoron more firmly. 'You were trained to resist it.'

'By the machine? Being told to paint, and craft, to sing songs and write poetry? What use is that?' The bitter smile he directed at the floor had a cynical edge Raldoron did not care for.

'Look at me, Simeon.'

Reluctantly, the Power looked up. Two identical pairs of pale eyes met.

'We were once the Revenant Legion, and we were feared because this affliction, that which we call the Red Thirst, ran unchecked in us. After every battle we feasted on the flesh of the fallen. The old warriors told themselves that they did so to learn the ways of the enemy. In truth, they were giving in to savagery. They hungered for flesh, and for blood. Then, we were the ones who were feared, not Curze's men, or Angron's.' He paused, his heart heavy. 'This was a time of great shame for us, though it is not widely spoken of. Then Sanguinius came and we became as you see us now.' He turned his palms out. 'We mastered the Thirst. So can you.'

'If he saved us, why am I afflicted?'

'Because the saving of us was not some miracle. Do you believe it to be immediate? Things rarely are as the legends say.' Raldoron spread his hands upon the worn wood of his desk. 'Do you think I was always this way? This calm, this collected?'

Simeon looked at him blankly.

'I was not. Even after the primarch came, blood called to us loudly, and I did many things that I was ashamed of. His teachings did not take in an instant. It was only after I had met him myself that I calmed my own Thirst.'

'Let me tell you of the first time I saw Sanguinius. My chapter was called back to Baal after the compliance of Turuc, a minor world. We had conquered it for the Emperor, in the name of the Imperium. A bloody compliance. In truth, they all were.'

That day was never far from Raldoron's thoughts, and with little effort he could see it again: the walls of the Arx Angelicum rising black and perfect from the red sands of Baal; the heaviness of the swollen world's pull; the yawning caverns of the docking slots cut into the side of the ancient volcano. That day, that day...

The most profound day of his life.

'I was recruited some time after Sanguinius returned, and I never met him as we were trained, equipped, and sent out to fight, like you. And like you, we suffered, and because of our suffering, we were savage, and so we were called back. We expected censure. There were only a thousand of us left of our battle group, all killers steeped in death. It was our way to expend ourselves in furious bloodshed, losing many of our own in the process, then build ourselves up from those we had conquered before moving on to do it all over again. These had been the habits of the old Revenant Legion, and despite what you might have heard, they were long in dying. We had feasted on the dead, believing we were honouring our fallen by taking on their memories as our own. That helped, sometimes, to integrate our new recruits. These were the old ways, you understand – by then mostly suppressed, yet still employed under the guise of ritual.'

He fixed Simeon with his gaze, and he wondered fleetingly if this was how his gene-sire had felt when speaking to him that first time, reassuring him of a finer purpose. 'You have done this?'

Simeon nodded hesitantly. The boy had been taken from some deep-hive hell, but there were taboos even in such places.

'Then you will know the mix of emotion it brings. The blending of another man's memories with your own. The loss of self.' He looked questioningly at the boy. Again, Simeon nodded. 'And you know the thirst for it? The need for it? The Thirst cannot be banished, only controlled, sometimes slaked, but it is always there. It always returns.'

Simeon looked away. The Archein continued his tale.

'I wondered then, as I came back to Baal, what manner of father Sanguinius would be. We had all heard the stories of an angel, a perfect being gifted with foresight, but I feared a sanguine beast to match our temperament. Most primarchs are like their sons, Simeon, but more so, and what was more than we were, other than more violence, more blood, more death? Perhaps worse, if he were as perfect as they said, then how could he

possibly accept us, who had failed to follow his example? Fear, not joy, was what I felt as our chapter assembled to meet him. I did not expect something that would save us, but something that would damn us.'

His eyes strayed to the iron mask upon the desk. Simeon followed his gaze. Their eyes met again.

'I was wrong. When his ship arrived and he descended the ramp, the sight of him was so perfect I could not credit it. Only when he came among us did I understand he truly was as I saw him, that his countenance, his pure white wings, his noble bearing, all were real, that it was no trick. I swear, although I am not one of the Foresaken – I have no second sight – I swear I saw the purity of his soul, as clearly as if it were a candle burning in a lantern, and when he called us to him one by one and asked us our names, the very same thing he had done after his revelation on Teghar Pentaurus, I knew that this being would save us from ourselves.

'In the days that followed, the primarch taught us mercy, humility, and kindness. But the truth was, Simeon, all of these traits were in us already. They are an essential part of our humanity. We feared we had left that state behind in favour of blood and war. He showed us we had not. It is the same for you. You have not lost your humanity, Simeon. You are of the Legiones Astartes, but you remain a man. Do you understand what I am trying to tell you?'

The boy-man thought hard a moment. 'That I have a choice?'

Raldoron inclined his head.

Simeon's face hardened. 'But I do not have a choice. The Thirst comes. It takes me. I lose control, and you tell us to read poetry. What use is that?'

'In better times, very useful.'

'I do not believe it.'

'That is because we have failed you. We have not passed on what we learned.'

'Then what should I do?'

Raldoron looked at him steadily. 'There are other ways to learn control.' He got up from his desk. 'Come with me.'

The training hall was empty but for one pair of veteran Blood Angels testing their weapons. When they saw Raldoron leading Simeon into the hall, they dipped their heads in respect and left.

Raldoron went to a rack of training staves hanging on a wall, and took two long shock batons down. Weighted and hilted like swords, they were otherwise blunt.

‘Take this,’ Raldoron said, and tossed one of the batons to Simeon. He activated his own. It buzzed quietly. ‘Turn it to the maximum setting,’ he said, and walked past the Angforios, heading down a short flight of five steps onto a recessed, hexagonal duelling ground. There were a dozen of these, nested together like the cells of a hive of social insects. Walkways between gave access. Raised platforms around the walls permitted viewing, though there was no one to watch.

As Raldoron reached the centre of the ground, spot lumens came on, illuminating the space with a fierce light that pushed the rest of the hall into darkness.

‘Come here,’ Raldoron ordered Simeon, who was still standing up on the testing range. ‘Face me.’

‘Yes, my lord,’ Simeon said, coming down and standing apart from Raldoron at sparring distance, where the tips of their batons would cross if outstretched.

‘Can you feel the Thirst?’ Raldoron asked him.

Simeon, uneasy at his loss of control in battle, more so with this attention from the highest of lords, frowned. ‘Yes.’

‘You always can, yes?’

Simeon nodded. ‘Sometimes it is distant, far from me. Sometimes, I can almost forget it.’

‘Now?’

‘Distant. If I seek it, I hear your pulse.’

‘That is all?’

‘Yes.’

‘Then we must wake it,’ said Raldoron, and he stepped in, lifting his baton and striking before the words had finished leaving his mouth. Simeon reacted enough to catch the blow, but Raldoron folded his arm, and continued forward, trapping Simeon’s weapon and arm. The sergeant simultaneously received a nerve-jarring shock and the tip of Raldoron’s elbow mashing into his throat.

Simeon staggered backwards, his breath stolen. He clumsily presented his weapon in defence, but Raldoron did not follow up his attack.

‘How about now? Do you feel it rising? Do you feel it stir?’

Simeon choked, coughed; his throat opened, able to draw breath again, yet he still could not speak. He nodded.

‘Good.’

Again Raldoron moved. He was not close to the Angforios, but crossed the distance with astonishing speed. Simeon managed to parry, then again, the shock field around the smooth batons crackling off each other. He stepped one foot back, meaning to buy himself time to think, but Raldoron was already on him. With his free hand he disarmed the youth, and smashed his baton across his face, bursting his lips. Pain exploded through Simeon’s skull.

His secondary heart started. The first ran faster. Simeon felt the Thirst truly then, awoken by the blood flooding his mouth. His senses quickened. Raldoron could see, and nodded in approval. When he came in again, Simeon was ready. He was still on the defensive, but managed to attempt a counter-strike, which Raldoron easily dealt with, before stepping in and dealing Simeon a sharp rap across the top of his skull.

Energy coursed through his brain, for a moment threatening blackness.

‘You have some skill, but have much to learn,’ Raldoron said.

There were five warriors of the Legions reckoned the finest swordsmen in the galaxy. Lucius of the Emperor’s Children, Khârn of the World Eaters, Sigismund of the Imperial Fists, Jago Sevatarion of the Night Lords, and Raldoron of the Blood Angels. This was an opinion so widely held it was accepted as objective fact, yet Raldoron showed no arrogance in his superior ability; there was no scolding or crowing over Simeon’s helplessness, only a cool appraisal.

‘You are tense – this makes you slow. The Thirst wishes to be slaked. It makes us strong. Strength is beaten by suppleness of movement, and by intention.’

Again the baton hit, shocking Simeon’s arm beneath his deltoid. His fingers went loose. The baton clattered to the floor. Raldoron stopped.

‘Pick it up,’ he said.

Simeon stooped, snatched up the training sword. His nerves fizzed unpleasantly with aftershocks. His hearts were pounding. He could hear Raldoron’s doubled beat, so much slower than his own. So calm.

‘We are not barbarians. We are not Russ’ savages. The Thirst brings fury, because it is urgent – it would master us to serve itself. You cannot allow that. Equally, you cannot ignore it. It must be used. Attempt to suppress it, and you will drown in it. Acknowledge it, master it, and its strength will be yours, then nothing shall stop you in battle. Do you understand this?’

Simeon breathed raggedly. ‘Yes, my lord.’

‘Then reach into yourself, welcome the Thirst, take it into you, but do not forget that you are a man.’

‘How?’

They circled each other.

‘Breathe deliberately. Listen to your hearts. Set a pattern to quell your rage. Let yourself know that your Thirst will be fed, but on your terms, not its.’

Simeon focused on his breathing.

‘Good,’ said Raldoron. ‘And when I come in again, cover your centre. Your guard drifts too far to your right.’

Again he moved, that terrifying fluidity, smooth as a serpent’s strike. Simeon felt the Thirst surge at this, enraged by his impotency. It almost overwhelmed him then, but he pushed back at it, rode the wave of its energies, and concentrated on Raldoron’s quicksilver movements.

‘That’s better. Stay calm. Mastery of self is the denial of anger. Victory favours those who think.’ As he spoke he struck and struck again, driving Simeon back.

Simeon parried with increasing desperation, the three ripostes he managed going wilder and wilder, until Raldoron tired of toying with him, or so it seemed, disarmed him with a cold ease that would have been contemptuous from any other master, slammed his fist into Simeon’s ear, stepped his leg around the back of Simeon’s knee, and flipped him onto the floor.

Simeon went down hard. His tenuous control of his humours slipped from him, and he bared his teeth and hissed.

‘There we are, the other face of our brotherhood shows itself at last,’ said Raldoron. He stepped back, looking on Simeon with a detached curiosity that Simeon would have seen as complete control, had he had any grip on his faculties.

He did not. He leapt to his feet, and threw himself at Raldoron. There was a flicker of something on the Archein’s stony features, perhaps surprise,

perhaps admiration at the boy's speed. Then somehow Simeon was flat on the floor again, face down this time, pinned with a knee to the small of his back and his arm stretched up and behind him in a painful, unbreakable lock. He thrashed against it.

'Still yourself,' Raldoron said. 'The Thirst is on you. Provoked by shame, it becomes rage. Rage undoes us all. Take it. Calm it. Calm yourself.'

Simeon did not know how long he fought hopelessly against his lord's grip. Raldoron continued to speak to him, the content of his words lost on the youth, but the tone and the rhythm became hypnotic, and through them, in time, Simeon found himself, and ceased his struggles.

'You are with us again?'

'Yes,' said Simeon.

'Then that is enough for today.'

Raldoron let go and got up. Simeon rolled over onto his back. Raldoron reached down. Simeon took the proffered hand, and the Archein helped him up.

'There are two sides to this,' said the Archein. 'The second is mastery in battle. You must learn to control your gifts and not allow them to overwhelm you when you fight. But the first, the most important, is mastery at all times. When you are away from combat, you believe yourself in control. You are not. The Thirst is always there. It waits. The arts you so decried help us find it, and understand it. The focus required to maintain your wits is only learned when danger is absent. Do you understand?'

'I think so, Archein.'

'Good, then write your poetry,' he said with a wry smile. 'There is a point to it. Remember these words. When you feel the Thirst rising, and trying to take you, the moments of calm and of beauty will remind you that you are a man and not a beast.'

'What about Andael?'

'There are only a rare few who cannot master the Thirst. Had Andael simply had the lesson I have just given you, he may have survived. You will conquer the darkness. This is why we practise art, why we celebrate the sublime, and why only we can truly understand what bedevils us. We seek beauty in truth, and truth in beauty. The truth may be dark, but because we have seen the worst of humanity in ourselves, we may excel at the best. People look to us as exemplars of the Emperor's warriors. And we are so, I

say this with pride, but true glory only comes with acceptance of our darker side. Acknowledge our flaws. You cannot ignore them.'

'Yes, Archein.' Simeon spat a wad of blood on the floor.

Raldoron grasped Simeon's face and turned it this way and that. 'I do not think I have damaged you too much. You should be fine.'

'I will bear my injuries with pride. They will help me reflect on what you have said.'

'Then I will come to your men tomorrow, and I will speak with them all.'

'May I ask something, my lord?'

'Of course.'

'Why did you come to me first?'

'Because I was impressed by your actions, and I have a feeling you shall be important. Prove me right. I hope you will take my words away with you from here, and share them. Let your brothers know that these impulses you suffer are not new or aberrant, but are a part of who we are.'

Simeon frowned.

'You are still troubled?'

The younger Space Marine nodded.

'Then speak.'

Simeon wetted his lips with his tongue. 'Archein, how can I hold onto my humanity when my grasp is so slicked with blood? I can feel my sanity slipping from me each time we fight.'

Raldoron smiled sadly. 'That is the great challenge of all Blood Angels, brother, but it is one you will rise to. Do you know what "angforios" means?'

'It is Aenokhian, for messenger,' said Simeon.

'That is so. There are many names for legionaries raised like you have been. Some use inductii, or newborn, or neophytes.'

'What does it matter what you call us? These are just names. We are looked down upon. The older brothers think us impure, inferior,' said Simeon.

'It matters because our name for you carries our intentions. You are to be our messengers to the future. You will carry our legacy past this time of war. These men who see you as lesser, many of them are going to die. Your numbers grow while legionaries raised on Baal, Canopus and Saiph

dwindle. All things pass. We, like all humans across time, must look to those who come after us to carry our ways forward.'

Simeon looked at him disbelievingly, and Raldoron thought that perhaps this talk had been a waste of effort, and that he had taught Simeon nothing, but then the boy steadied, and he nodded, and a look of fresh resolution came over him.

'I will heed your words, Archein.'

CHAPTER EIGHT

DEPARTURE

The next stage of the war called with silent urgency in every compartment of every ship, but when Raldoron addressed the Angforia it was old wars, and old blood, that weighed on his mind.

There were around six hundred Angforia, though as he, Laertes and Vallis had discussed, their numbers could only grow. The larger ships in the Reprisal Fleet carried all the necessary facilities to transform men into angels, and they were hungry for flesh to rework.

The inductii were fully armoured. All were battered, like an army of corpses made to stand; true revenants, he thought. Ceramite was cracked, bonding studs missing; in some cases the outer layers had crumbled right down to the structural mesh. This was the accumulation of damage from several engagements, not just that received in the mountains of Thorne's Landing. These new men placed little emphasis on repair, and by following logic they probably did not care for their bodies either. That too would have to change; good order was a sign of control of the self, and control of the self mastered the Thirst.

The parlous state of their armour reminded him unwelcomely of Signus, when his own wargear had become as the Angforia's was for lack of attention. Memories of Signus were sunk as deep into him as the day he had met the primarch, and were far less welcome. He heard again the screams of unearthly creatures, more alien than the worst xenos he had ever faced.

Things of horn and bone and wicked claws that tore their way from outside reality to lay down the sons of Sanguinius.

These men had replaced some of the tens of thousands lost to the nightmares. All the technological might of the Imperium, their training, their heavy guns and thick armour, their pride. None of that had mattered when fighting creatures even legend dared not recall. Lapped at by the warp, the Thirst had come on the Blood Angels, and with it a horrifying descent into mindlessness.

Raldoron had wondered since if it were not the fury that existed in them all that had saved them. Sometime later Mkani Kano had told him that those things – he forced himself to use the proper word – those *daemons*, were made of men's soured thoughts and humours. Anger was a potent creator. Kano had said that sometimes it was appropriate to fight fire with fire.

Magic, daemons, cathedrals of bone, such insanity. Only Kano had any grip on the reality of it.

Raldoron wondered where the Librarian was now. He missed his counsel.

The Angforia wore their helmets in a half-hearted attempt at uniformity. Many of them twitched, a few shifted restlessly. They watched him with lupine attention as he took to the rostrum set at the head of the deck, beneath the broad windows of the control gallery.

'Remove your helmets,' he said.

A few hesitated, then all complied. A wave of movement passed through the crowd. Clicks, snaps, the hiss of regularising pressures, the clunk of helms rested against hips. Then silence again.

Raldoron saw eyes dulled by rapid memetic implantation staring out of Sanguinius' beautiful face. He wondered how to start, how to push these unfinished angels towards righteousness.

As Sanguinius had acted, so too must he. Raldoron came down from the rostrum, went among the Space Marines. The ranks parted, breaking up the wavered lines to let him pass. Disorder seemed more natural than forced discipline. The atmosphere lightened a little.

'You,' Raldoron asked a Space Marine, whose cold, golden eyes seemed to look at some fixed point of atrocity behind the Archein. 'Tell me your name.'

The void engines were growling at full acceleration, shuddering the *Autarch of Saiph* from end to end, when Faisal Subarai-Almazi inadvertently upset his son.

Raldoron was good to his word. He sent Dominion Araphes, the task force's Auxilia overseer, to present medals and fresh insignia to the Elevatii. All the officers of the 46th were present in person – Faisal insisted on that – and the ceremony was broadcast to every troop ship in the flotilla. Faisal had selected a number of men from the ranks for commendation, while over a dozen tercios were to receive additions to their colours for their valour. There were promotions to replace officers lost in battle. Assan received a Legion blood drop with pride that Faisal himself felt twice over when Araphes pinned it to his son's chest. A banquet was planned. Additional rations of potent Saiphan arrafin were ready to be distributed, and damn the fact that it would dent their supplies significantly. They sang the songs of their ancestors, and added knots to the fringes of their tribal sashes to mark their kills. Everything seemed to be going so well that it was an unpleasant surprise when it went wrong.

The ceremony finished with the Dispersal of Arms, where Faisal presented notable commanders with new weaponry, an old chieftain's tradition from home to honour bold men that was a sight more useful, in Faisal's eyes, than yet another bauble. He gave out the usual collection of rare pistols and masterwork swords to officers whose eyes gleamed at these marks of his approval. He knew these men would treasure the gifts. He knew they would stir to greater efforts with such things in their hands. The weapons might even keep their recipients alive.

Then he got to his son.

He read the appropriate words from a scroll held up for him in the ritual posture, relics of the ways of old Saiph, spoken in the guttural tongue of the deep wastes. 'To Captain Assan Faisal-Almazi, of the Clan Ishtiq, honoured already this day for his bravery in battle, to be honoured again for his skill at command.'

His son was trying hard not to smile. Faisal struggled too, but when Faisal's lieutenant lifted the sand whistle to his lips and played the call of homecoming – once piped over desert forts when the clans returned from raiding – and in came twenty Solar Auxilia Veletarii in gleaming armour, each of them bearing a volkite charger, the smile vanished from Assan's

eyes. He could say nothing, of course – protocol demanded that he accept his reward – but by the time Assan was walking with Faisal to inspect his new troops, his face was grey, and his lips white. Faisal was dismayed, but he too was bound by tradition, and could react no more than his son could.

‘From my own bodyguard, I grant you command of these men, the lauded Swords of the Sickle Moon, veterans of many years and bearers of many honours, inheritors of the ways of Clan Ishtiq, our clan, the people of the falcon.’

Assan said nothing. There were no words prescribed for the recipient at this point in the ceremony. Faisal expected at least a thank you, but when loyal old Adjutant Dieres came forward to kneel and offer up his sword, Assan mumbled the responses. Dieres gave his general a troubled glance, and it was then that Faisal really knew something was wrong. He had to wait all the way through the rest of the ceremonies before beckoning his son to him.

‘With me, now,’ he said.

Together they left the great hall, by which time Assan was shaking with the kind of anger only a father can kindle in his son.

They entered the stateroom at a brisk march.

‘What has got into you?’ Faisal demanded before the doors had fully closed, almost certainly loud enough for his lifeguards to hear. They betrayed nothing, keeping their eyes front and their stances at attention outside.

‘You know what,’ said Assan rigidly.

The marshal tugged off his gloves and threw them on the long, gleaming table. The hands beneath were wrinkled. The light of three dozen suns had called out spots on their backs. He suddenly felt every one of his fifty-six years pressing into his soul.

‘I really don’t. What has got into you?’

‘You show me favour, father.’

Faisal felt a bewildering mix of annoyance and confusion. He felt suddenly very hot, and very tired. ‘The squads?’

‘Yes.’

‘Those men could mean the difference between life and death to you.’

There was a long pause. Assan clenched his jaw so tightly his teeth creaked.

‘Explain yourself, Assan, and before you decide to petulantly hold your silence, that is a direct order. Speak to me, you are not a child any more.’

‘In order to preserve me by granting me those squads, you look like you are elevating me in importance above all others. By your nepotism, you weaken other parts of the regiment.’

‘Is that it? You are angry because of that? What am I supposed to do? You are my son, Assan.’

‘And everyone knows it, father. I am not the only officer in your army. There are others who are better and braver.’

‘Nonsense. You earned the right to the Veletarii squads.’

‘It doesn’t matter. How many times do you think I have had to endure the whispers of envious men, who point to me and say I owe my position to blood and not ability?’

‘That is the way of things.’

‘Not on Saiph,’ Assan said. ‘Not back home.’

‘Oh,’ said Faisal with a cold measure of civility. ‘So you would rather have an honour duel, and kill a useful man to prove yourself worthy of this small gift?’

‘If that is what is necessary, then yes.’ Assan’s skin darkened with anger. He held his hands before him, turning inward, as if he bore the mockery of all who doubted him in a shameful bundle and wished to show his father. ‘It is the honour of the man that counts. It is his skill with the blade, not who his father or his mother is. This has always been our way. At home I would have fought to win approval, and you just give it to me! You undermine me with your generosity. Now, even more than before, they will say I have my position not because of what I am, but who I am.’

‘Son, we are soldiers of the Imperium – we are no longer desert warriors. That is not our way any longer. It has not been so for three generations. I am trying to do you an honour—’

‘Yet you dishonour me!’ Assan turned away from his father. His rage was so great that it threatened to unleash tears.

For a moment, Faisal felt an urge to shout at his son for his ungratefulness. A wave of anger rose in him, but it crested, collapsed, and vanished from him as soon as it had come. Maybe Assan had a point, though his argument was not nearly so strong as he might think.

‘Son, my son. I did not wish to embarrass you.’ Faisal spoke calmly. His son’s shoulders were shaking, his head was bowed. Faisal could not see if Assan indeed wept. He suspected it was so. As a child he had been a hostage to his emotions. ‘My boy, turn to me, and look at me.’

He grasped Assan’s shoulder. At the first attempt to turn him around, Assan yanked himself free, but Faisal would not be denied, and he grabbed his son hard and spun him about.

‘Now, listen. Do you not think I know men? Answer me!’

Assan gave him such a despairing look of betrayal that Faisal’s own heart wavered. His boy, a man now, he reminded himself, was not weeping. This anger was worse, in its way. He pushed dismay away. A hardness settled on Faisal’s features. He could not show how he truly felt. The responsibilities of commander and father were rarely compatible.

‘This goes both ways. For fear of looking favoured, you take risks in battle and so put yourself and your tercios in danger. Do not deny it. So what then am I supposed to do? I have commanded the Saiphan Forty-Sixth for twenty years. I know what men say. I know what they think and what they feel.’ Faisal’s own anger was tight inside his chest, though his was mixed with a fear for his son. He experienced a moment of doubt. Had he indeed let this fear override his judgement? ‘I know they will not follow a man they deem unworthy. Did you see them? Did they look ashamed, did they smirk at you beneath their helms?’

Assan said nothing, but looked aside.

‘They think it an honour to fight for you, even if you do not.’ He grasped Assan’s other shoulder, so they were nearly embracing, and searched out his son’s eyes, holding his gaze so Assan could not look away again. ‘More than either of those things, my son, I know you. I know you will lead your men bravely, that you will take risks in order to prove your worth. These so-called weakened tercios are mine. They are stuck at the rear when they hunger to fight, so I give them the chance by giving them to you. It is true, is it not? It is true that you would lead your men from the very front of the formation if I gave you nothing but laspistols to fight with.’

Assan blinked. His eyes were red-rimmed.

‘So lead them into battle! There will be fighting on board ship, Assan, before we get to Gallia, you can be sure of that. We will be fighting other Solar Auxilia regiments, at least. At least, my son! There is a likelihood you

will face Legion-bonded Elevatii, veterans like us. We will probably face their legionaries, too. Think about that – legionaries, in boarding actions, fighting men without their gifts, and you want me to send you out under-equipped, my hot-headed son, who is so desperate to show the galaxy his honour carries more weight than his name? I cannot stop you throwing yourself into the fray, nor would I dream of doing so. You are honourable, my son, and you are brave. Yet you cannot fault an old man for providing a little additional assurance that you will prevail. One day I expect you to succeed me as commander-in-chief of this regiment.’ He cut off a further attempt at protest from Assan. ‘A position you will win for yourself – it will not be handed to you. Honourable, brave men are no use to anyone if they are dead.’

Faisal let go. Assan was pale now where before he had been flushed, but his fury had not left him, only retreated deep inside, settling in his bones, trembling him so hard that his medals clattered.

‘Then I shall do the best I can with your very generous gift, sir.’

Deliberately, slowly, Assan saluted his father, turned about crisply and marched from the room. He did not ask for permission to be dismissed. Faisal let him go anyway. The door opened onto the rising sounds of celebration. The arrafin had been distributed, the tables were occupied; food would come soon. He could smell the sweet spices, redolent of home, and he felt a sudden flush of nostalgia for his boyhood of sand and heat and his youthful, uncomplicated yearning for glory. He should go out to be seen by his men. Instead he let the doors shut again, cutting him off from the cheers, and with it his son’s fury.

Faisal leaned on the table, straight-armed, old hands pressing knuckles down into the polished wood. Then he forced himself upright. He rubbed his forehead, wondering how he had managed to handle the situation so badly.

‘Twenty thousand men I can command, but not one son.’

A strong desire for arrafin pushed him to his drinks cabinet. He pulled out the first bottle his hand found and poured himself a generous measure. He gulped it down without tasting it.

There was still the feast to endure, and his appetite was quite spoiled.

CHAPTER NINE

SIGNUS REMEMBERED

The theatre of sleep held horrors for Raldoron. Consciousness slipped away. Red smoke parted as smoothly as the curtains of a stage, revealing a scene that had become wearily familiar.

He was dreaming of Signus again.

The dreams followed the same general plot, always with the same setting, but they were never exactly the same. Variations of his actual memories. In nearly all of them, he and his warriors were in column, trudging across the wasted landscapes of Signus Prime. Ahead was the baroque, towering monstrosity of the Cathedral of the Mark. This too was never exactly the same from one appearance to the next, and rarely looked as it had in those insane, blood-soaked days of the campaign. The mind could not keep the shape of it, or maybe the mind made the shape of it anew each time, like the machine spirits of the tactarium struggling to record the daemons. Nevertheless, it felt like a splinter of the cathedral had lodged in his soul. It was too real not to be so.

They trudged through the dust of ten million corpses. It rose in billows, filled the air, caked armour that beneath the powdered bone was sometimes Blood Angels red, sometimes Revenant grey. Helm lenses shone through the pall. There was no sun, no night, no day, only a sanguinary gloom.

Tanks matched the pace of the infantry on squealing treads. Self-propelled artillery was mixed in for protection. The foes' bizarre weaponry and

random manifestations made a mockery of warfare's norms. The Legion had no order, because that place had no use for order; only chaos, and death.

They had been weary by the time they marched upon the cathedral. Space Marine minds, though hardened against all forms of shock, were not immune to the extremes the Signus campaign provided, the falling away of all prior assumptions, even those of reality itself. The men were tense, close to breaking, each and every one, and the enemy were coming again.

The air sparked like feast-day pyrotechnics, gauzy orbs of red and pink swelling into being over the wastes and the ruins. They had come to understand the signs only too well.

'Manifestation!' The cry went up, carried down the line. They had to shout; the vox served them not at all. Every word spoken into it was twisted into something obscene. Blood-hungry howls accompanied every reply. 'Manifestation!'

The column stopped. Tank turrets tracked about to point into the blasted landscape. Space Marines spread out to protect their vehicles. They levelled bolters. Hard though it was to believe, some of the hands holding them were unsteady.

The orbs collapsed with booms that were half thunderclap, half mocking laugh. Gates of iron and brass were suddenly there, amazingly solid, as if they always had been. They crackled, falls of unnatural energies pouring from their apexes; these parted, and daemons poured through. There was nothing behind the gates – the daemons came from nowhere. Red, lithe things that writhed, long tongues lashing back and forth in excitement. They bore huge, impractical swords of dull black stone, bronze, and brass – materials ill-suited to butchery forged in shapes ill-suited to balance. And yet these weapons had proven themselves deadly adequate against the Space Marines and their armour. The daemons' skin was studded with bony nodules, their heads bore sweeping horns. Before them rolled a charnel stink that paid no respect to void-sealed armour or breathing filters.

The daemons rushed forward in a mass, their battle cries given in languages too impure for human ears to process, and so heard only as the sibilant curses of snakes.

In the dream, the Blood Angels froze. It had not been this way in reality. But in the dream, not one gun spoke. Raldoron moved among his army, the sole warrior in motion.

‘Open fire!’ Raldoron yelled. ‘Open fire!’ He pushed at his men.

Finally boltguns boomed, but the bolts flew from muzzles only to freeze in front of the Space Marines, candle motors bright but still. Raldoron’s movements became harder, trapped in the thick, viscous nightmare fear that has dogged man’s sleep since the dawn of time.

The daemons came on, their hissing, incomprehensible speech filling up every part of him. They neared the lines, then, to Raldoron’s amazement, cast aside their weapons. They leapt, each one seizing a frozen Space Marine in a spidery embrace, locking their arms and legs around their prey, and in that moment Raldoron saw there was a blood-red daemon for each and every Space Marine, not one more, not one less.

There was one for him, much bigger than its brethren, with skin of so dark a red it was almost black, like old blood gone to tar. Its horns were broad and twisted into a skull-like rune. Yellow eyes brimmed with violence, but behind that was a sharp cunning, and an ancient, unfathomable intelligence.

Raldoron wanted to kill it, but he could not draw his pistol. Solid air trapped him as surely as cooled glass. The daemons, though, they had no such difficulty. They passed through easily, as if the strange unreality sustained them, as fish are supported by water.

The little movement available to Raldoron became less, became none. All around him, daemons tore off the helmets of the frozen Space Marines. Glassy human eyes stared blankly at the creatures enfolding them.

His own daemon approached him. He knew it, and it knew him. In the yellow of its irises he saw his bloody past, and his sins reflected in the black of its feline pupils – in the crusade, in the civil war, and with it futures too awful to comprehend.

The creature dropped its brazen sword into the dust, and with a claw plucked free Raldoron’s helm.

‘Raldoron,’ it said, and its long, purple tongue flicked across his face. **‘Mine.’**

Raldoron’s body was entirely frozen now. From the corner of his eyes, he saw his men and the daemons melting together, like paired figures of soft wax pushed into one another.

Sinuous arms locked around Raldoron’s shoulders. The daemon pulled itself closer, so its long, hideous face was mere centimetres from his own.

Its teeth were greened bronze daggers. Its tongue became a cutting blade, its eyes the black craters of levelled cities.

It smiled at him possessively.

‘Revenant.’

Then it thrust its face into his in a soul-crawling perversion of a kiss. Its skin burned. Its breath reeked. Both were now his. His face, his stink.

His rage.

‘My lord! My lord Archein!’

A strangled voice. Something soft and wriggling was against him, dispensing feeble blows. Feeble kicks. His attacker was nearly dead. Good. He would crush the vile thing and be free of it.

‘My lord! I can’t... I can’t... breathe...’

The voice. He knew it. It was not that of an enemy.

Quincus.

Raldoron came into himself. The Thirst fought back. At first, his perceptions were blinded by an all-consuming anger. This was not the Thirst, or not entirely; there was something else behind it, something infinitely bigger. He bested it nevertheless, decades of mental training and self-deprivation pushing at the red edges of anger, compressing it, confining it, and shutting it away.

His vision cleared. Raldoron had his bare arm pressed against Quincus’ throat, pinning him against the wall of the chamber. The thrall’s feet were dangling helplessly beneath him. Raldoron could smell the blood in him, feel the panicked, jackhammer pulse of the man’s heart.

Raldoron stepped back. Quincus fell to the ground. The teeth in Raldoron’s mouth were sharp with need.

Quincus lay breathless, hand clutched at his throat. With fearful eyes he watched his master.

Raldoron extended his hand. His blood had an intolerable pressure. His veins bulged, the contents calling to the vitae in the thrall.

‘Quincus,’ he said.

The thrall shuffled away.

Raldoron closed his hand, and stepped back. ‘I am sorry.’ He looked down at his fists. His skin was flushed, red as the daemons in his nightmare.

Revenant.

‘I am sorry, Quincus. Warp dreams. I should not have slept.’

Quincus was calming, going from fearful to wary.

‘Come on, please, let me help you. I truly mean you no harm.’

This time, the blood-thrall accepted his hand. Raldoron hauled him up. Quincus weighed nothing, a reminder of how fragile the unaltered human body was, a reminder of how easily he could have killed him.

‘Why did you come in here?’

Quincus swallowed painfully. He massaged his throat. It was beginning to bruise.

‘My lord, you were shouting. I...’ He swallowed again. ‘I feared you were under attack. I came in, found you on the floor in the throes of a nightmare. When I tried to wake you...’ His eyes were wide and pale.

‘I grabbed you.’ Raldoron dropped his head. He was exhausted, as if he had not slept at all. He was suffering the heavy, spiritual tiredness brought on by rough warp travel. ‘I am weary. It has been a long time since I rested properly, but it was unwise of me to sleep. The enemy attack us from every direction, even in our dreams.’ He raised his head. His thrall looked at him with far less fear. He had a brave soul. ‘How long until we arrive?’

‘Forty-six hours.’

Raldoron nodded. ‘Get yourself to the infirmary. Have yourself thoroughly examined, my orders. Make them prioritise you.’

‘Yes, my lord Archein.’

‘And Quincus?’

‘Yes, my lord?’

‘I advise you not to enter my chambers again when I am at rest, no matter what you hear.’

CHAPTER TEN

ARRIVAL

The Geller field powered down, and the *Promissum Sanguinem* moaned as if it were a living thing relieved of an intolerable burden. Klaxons blared. Voxes shouted the shipmaster's voice into every compartment and way.

'Translation complete. Materium regained. Stand down immaterium transit procedures, all crew, all crew.'

Bells tolled, signalling a return to reality.

On the command deck, there followed a flurry of orders from Shipmaster Boise to the executive crew. Oculus shutters opened smoothly. Lights all over the command deck came on as dormant terminals reactivated. The primary hololith ignited with the businesslike buzz of warming ribbon projectors. Details painted themselves in as augury soaks returned their first readings.

Raldoron watched all this dispassionately. Translation was always fraught. Only the most talented Navigator had any hope of ensuring a ship emerged exactly where its commanders desired. Space was unimaginably big. The largest fleet was insignificantly small even on something so modest as the system scale, but given all that, it was not impossible for a fleet to emerge disordered and blind right in the path of their enemy. They waited for the master of sensoria to declare the fleet free of peril. His judgement came quickly and welcomingly.

'All clear, all clear, no visual sign of vessels, all clear.'

More klaxons sounded. Tension reduced. The detailed portions of the holo-display grew as initial scans were taken. In every section men and women got to work, forcing order onto the fleet lost in translation. On another, smaller holo-display, Raldoron watched light models of his ships manoeuvre, cutting across each other's paths to take their proper places, destroyers leaving the shelter of the capital vessels to fan out in screens, troop ships dropping back with their escorts, cruisers and battleships inching into a spearhead. Scout ships detached from the swarm of vessels and accelerated ahead. Generally speaking, the formation had held well during warp transit, but there was always some disruption, the worst of it the battle cruiser *Argosy* being out by several hundred thousand kilometres. It would take hours for it to make its way back into line.

Seeing this, Boise sent a warrant officer to Raldoron.

'The shipmaster asks, do we wait for the *Argosy* to fall into formation?'

'No,' said Raldoron, knowing full well that refusal would leave it exposed to attack. 'Send an escort group to shield her. Main flotilla to make full speed for the target. Surprise is our best ally.'

The warrant officer bowed and hurried away.

A few more men and women came to him with small pieces of information or minor requests. When they were done, and the atmosphere calmer, Raldoron activated his Legion vox and had his commanders report in. No news of disturbance among his legionaries. The same response was had from the Auxilia. Satisfied the translation had gone without incident, Raldoron sent orders to Vallis and the solar marshal to join him, then went back to watching the command deck in silence.

Charts were consulted, lines drawn. Dim shapes representing the supposed positions of the system's worlds flickered on. Hours would pass before augur results could be fully integrated.

Until then, they would be sailing half-blind.

The strategium was crowded again. Holo ghosts projected by servo-skulls mingled with the living, their light investing the room with a phantasmal air. The battle plate of projected Space Marines was washed out, hard lit on the edges, maroon in the shadow. Mortal men and women were pale and insubstantial. Raldoron, who was never a voluble man, had Faisal deliver the briefing.

‘My lords and ladies,’ Faisal said. ‘We are now in possession of full-detail augury sweeps of our vicinity, and have good long-range, lesser-resolution reports of the system worlds. As you all know, if we can see, so can they. We will have been detected.’ His expression became grave. ‘We are in receipt of troubling readings from our target.’

An image of 147-Gamma Minoris-Garmon coalesced on the central display. It was mostly green and blue, minimal deserts, small ice caps, large mountain ranges white and prominent across the two major land masses, the globe marbled with long streaks of cloud. ‘This is a pict captured by an Imperial survey team eight years ago when One-Four-Seven was in fine health, a grade-beta agri world. Alas, our initial readings suggest this is no longer the case.’

A second image appeared next to the first. Other than its identical size, it could have been a different planet. Black clouds shrouded the majority of the surface. Where the ground was visible, it was grey and sickly.

‘Spectral analysis shows high levels of methane, carbon dioxide and carbon monoxide suggestive of widespread decay conflagration. The planet has been subject to widespread bombardment. Blast patterns are consistent with indiscriminate usage of radiological weaponry. There are signs of phosphex use. One-Four-Seven-Gamma Minoris-Garmon is dead.’

A hush fell on the room. It would have been completely silent were it not for the insect whine of holo-projectors, and the deeper thrum of the servo-skulls’ contra-grav units hovering over the throng.

‘Nevertheless, it is the Archein’s command that we press on. Our objectives have changed. Firstly, we have relatively high confidence that the culprits of this act of desecration are still present. Secondly, although we are yet to receive any direct messages, vox-chatter on Imperial cypher frequencies indicates that a significant portion of the loyalist forces are still alive and fight on. Our objectives are thus twofold – to extract the men we came for and to deny the enemy escape. We strike them while they are evacuating their armies, and we strike them hard. We have them on the back foot and they will pay for what they have done. Hail the Emperor.’

‘Hail the Emperor,’ the crowd responded.

Raldoron’s eyes were fixed on the enemy battle group depicted in miniature graphics above the strategium chart desk: three capital ships and escorts

lingering so far at the edge of augury range that the sensorium had lost its lock upon them, and the light models flickered and jumped across the display. Since the news had broken, the three Sanguinary Guard Sanguinius had sent with him had shadowed him discreetly. They stood silently away from the map, ready for attack.

‘It looks like a trap,’ said Faisal. Hours had passed and the strategium was quiet.

‘Of course it is,’ said Vallis. ‘The question is, what do we do about it? If we do not rise to the bait, then that battle group will be free to harass us all the way to One-Four-Seven. If we delay to deal with them, then they will have more time to evacuate their ground forces. If we split the battle group to hit both planet and fleet at once, we weaken our formation, and put our landing forces at risk. Either way, we will inevitably lose ships and time.’

Raldoron only half listened to them. The enemy had appeared five hours ago, matching pace with the Imperial fleet. The ring of asteroids delineating the inner system from the outer loomed ahead. On real-view, it was a glinting band that attenuated at the edges, fading into the darkness of the void. On the holo-display every rock above fifty metres was depicted as an individual model, all of them in motion in the complex, gravitic dance that patches of such debris displayed the universe over. The asteroids ranged in size from specks of dust to uprooted mountains, with a few planetoids thrown in for good measure.

‘What are your orders, Archein?’ Faisal asked. ‘This is not my area of expertise.’

Still Raldoron did not speak. It was likely there were more ships waiting for them in the belt, so they could be caught in a pincer. Did they rise up over the plane of the ecliptic and avoid the possible ambush? That would add another three days’ journey, Raldoron roughly calculated.

‘What are you thinking, brother?’ Vallis asked.

‘This is the moment this battle will be decided,’ said Raldoron. ‘We must choose wisely. We are two days out from One-Four-Seven. On the direct course.’

‘Through the belt,’ said Vallis.

‘Through the belt.’

‘If I were in their position, I would have further forces waiting somewhere here, or maybe here.’ Vallis pointed at spots on the far side of the wall of

spinning rocks, one above and one below, echoing Raldoron's own conclusions. 'If they wait on minimal power, hidden in the lee of the belt, we will struggle to spot them until it is too late. We do not have an accurate idea of how many enemy ships there are in-system.'

'Fifty, the last astropathic message said fifty,' said Faisal.

'There may be more.'

'There may,' said Raldoron.

'Whether we go up or down, or split our fleet, they will be waiting for us. It is possible they could hit us from three directions at once,' said Vallis.

'They are challenging us. Demanding that we think. The truth of it is they want us to slow down,' said Raldoron. 'They want us to stop and start chasing them, or to divert, only to give them more time to evacuate the planet. If we drive through, they may instead attack from multiple vectors, and attempt to delay us more directly – or they may not. Either way, they want to cheat us of revenge by stalling.'

'Then what do we do?' asked Faisal.

'We are going to have to fight them, whatever course of action we choose,' said Raldoron. 'So we do it on our terms. We pick the battlefield. We go directly through. With the battlesphere crowded by debris, they will not be able to coordinate their attack efficiently. They will have to come at us piecemeal. If we hold our formation, we should be able to deal with them with minimal loss. The way I see it, if they do attack, then so be it. It will make them easier to kill if they are all in one place.'

'What about the rocks? The void shields will not be sufficient to deflect them all,' said Faisal. 'Our formation will be disrupted no matter how hard we try to hold together. And surely, if we bring our prow and spine batteries into play to blast our way through the asteroids, then we will reduce the effectiveness of our firepower.'

'They will suffer the same disadvantages. The Death Guard prefer direct confrontation. Their core doctrine is of attrition. In circumstances where their forces match their foe, they will attack directly, rely on their thicker armour, and sacrifice their vessels as readily as their men if they believe it will bring them victory. If they had enough ships to pursue that strategy, then they would be on us already. This is a clumsy ambush, set by men unaccustomed to guile yet too ill-equipped to follow another route. Their armour is an advantage in close-range fights, and any battle in the belt will

be at extreme close range, but it also makes their ships slower than ours. We will be quicker to react than they, and so we shall outmatch them. I am certain that our ships outnumber theirs, so do our warriors, and so in this factor we also have the advantage. They have played their hand too early. The choice is simple. Dominion, marshal, ready your men. Vallis, I want boarding parties ready. If we can take their ships and add them to our own, so much the better. Marshal, I would have your men form counter-boarding groups stationed at all major transit intersections and primary targets on all capital ships.'

'Yes, my lord,' said Faisal.

'We will set a trap of our own. Their aim will be decapitation. They will push their attack on this ship, and they will come for me. Let us make sure they have a warm welcome.'

CHAPTER ELEVEN

CAT AND MOUSE

The ship shuddered with the discharge of guns in a rhythm so steady it had lost all novelty and blended into the background rumble of the ship's systems.

Assan waited with his company on the Via Magna of the *Promissum Sanguinem*. To avoid conflict among themselves, the various companies of the 46th Saiphan Elevatii had drawn lots for the honour of defending the enemy's most likely targets: the enginarium, the fire control centres, principal gunnery decks, the command deck, void shield generatoria, life-support nexuses. All were possible battle zones when an enemy aimed to cripple and capture a ship, and the captains of the Elevatii coveted these places as postings. And yet the primary targets were buried deep. Access had to be forced, so the greater means of ingress and transit also had to be guarded, places such as the hangar bays, the broad dorsal corridors, the embarkation deck, for only by taking these locations could the enemy breach the vessel in numbers sufficient to attack the primary targets successfully.

Assan was pleased with his posting. The Via Magna was a good draw. Although not as valued as the ship's Via Principia, which ran through the heart of the vessel and carried the crew trains along the *Promissum Sanguinem*'s four-kilometre length at the core, the Magna was the spinal way, closer to the outer hull, therefore more likely to be assaulted. If it were

not, it was sufficiently well connected to allow rapid redeployment to wherever the conflict was. *Not a bad draw*, Assan thought. *Not bad at all*.

Fourteenth Company waited in neat blocks, shoulder lamps off, lenses dimly glowing with the light of their helm displays. The lenses were ruby, as were the emergency lumens, tinging grey void suits the same colour as their armour plates, which were red to honour their masters. They were ruddy shadows, waiting in the dark, two hundred and thirty-six of them.

‘You’re excited, cousin. I can tell.’ Qaziz, Assan’s master voxman spoke. All of them wore their helms, not just for protection but in case of depressurisation. There was air yet, and Assan heard Qaziz’s voice doubled, one tinny through his earpieces, the other muffled by their void suits.

‘How so?’ Assan felt a thrill of anxiety, worried now that his anticipation was visible through his thick plating and pressure suit, and that it was unbecoming. In the confines of his suit, his heart sounded loud. His eyes strayed to the medicae screed running across the bottom right of his helm plate. The display was less sophisticated than those integrated into the armour of the Astartes, but gave his power levels, systems and suit integrity, oxygen mix, and heart rate, among other things. To his relief, the jagged beat of his pulse was not too rapid.

‘Tapping your gun,’ said Qaziz. ‘You always do that before a fight, cousin.’

Qaziz was right. Assan stopped self-consciously.

‘Sir,’ he reminded.

‘All right. Sir.’

Faisal had selected Qaziz as bond-companion when he had taken Assan from Saiph to train him in the ways of war. He was a relative of a sort so distant the two of them had given up trying to work out the exact relationship long ago, but they were close as brothers, sharing memories of the wind-sculpted cliffs and tent encampments by the Great Oases, the long festivals of the winter equinox, when temperatures were kind, the colourful clothes, the smells of spices, tales of heroes long gone, and tales of kinsfolk yet living.

The *Promissum Sanguinem* shook with a hit, harder than before. The men murmured. Assan’s heart skipped a beat.

‘That was not a rock,’ said someone.

Focus, Assan told himself. My war is here, not out there. Await events calmly, as fate dictates.

‘A passing strafe from fast ships,’ Qaziz said. ‘Enemy escorts. The first wave.’

‘Put it from your thoughts. Let the gunnery crews deal with enemy vessels,’ Assan said. ‘There is nothing we can do about them.’

Qaziz shifted. ‘True. I mention it only because it means their boarding parties will be here soon.’

The others in the command squad remained silent, each man locked into his void armour with his thoughts. Mesen’s helm was underlit periodically as he tweaked the focal settings on his meltagun and the weapon’s screen flashed on and off. Porios, the only non-Saiphani in the group, tapped his index finger idly against the housing of his auspex array, much like Assan had been doing. The others had their own tics, other tells, little movements that spoke of nerves before combat.

The ship shivered again.

‘That was a rock,’ said Lazareen, the company standard bearer. He’d left the banner behind; the confines of the ship demanded that. They’d fight just as hard around him without the flag. Lazareen carried the company’s honour in his blood.

‘Quiet there. Void shield status, vox-operator,’ Assan asked, more to break the interminable wait than for any real need to know.

Qaziz deactivated his personal vox, tuned to the intervox system, sent his inquiry, then switched personal communications back on.

‘Shield control report seventy-eight per cent integrity.’

‘When they drop below fifty per cent, they might try to breach.’

‘Fifty? No. It’s a foolhardy man who attempts to penetrate an active void shield. You have to go too slow. Makes you an easy target, that’s if you make it through at all,’ said Lazareen.

‘We’re all voidsmen here, no need to state the bloody obvious,’ said Qaziz.

Lazareen shrugged. ‘Just saying.’

Assan looked at them all. Each of them wore the sash of a Saiphan desert fighter. Knots in the long fringes indicated how many foes they had bested, the patterns declaiming clan identity. Even so, none of them had been raised on Saiph, not really. There were those like Assan and Qaziz who remembered childhood there, but they were few and all had left home

before their tenth birthdays. The traditions were weakening even among those with Saiphani blood. Saiph had been part of the Imperium for a long time. The regiments had become self-sustaining, with some members born on campaign and many more recruited from other worlds. The ways of their ancestors were still practised out in the hot sands back home, their savage culture preserved to furnish the Legion and their Auxilia with recruits, but the link between raiding clans and void-hardened soldiers had been stressed by the rebellion. Like their Legion, the Elevatii had been forced to replenish themselves however they could, and so although the members of Assan's command squad were almost all Saiphani, there were fewer men of Saiph in the broader regiment, and all of them, wherever they were from, were more accustomed to the void than the desert.

Tradition is important, Assan thought. Tradition is what binds us together. Without it they could not build a sense of common feeling between the men. It worried him that it was slipping away.

A series of hard shudders ran up the ship, starting at the prow. They were uniform, all deflected – he could tell by the sickening tightness the void shields' reaction made somewhere deep inside him. Before the war, before they had seen strange gods crawling out from the dark between the stars, talk that souls withered under the influence of void shield technology was laughed at as superstition. Now, it did not seem so foolish.

The ship shook again. The sensation was different this time.

'Well that was a hit, and that one got through,' Lazareen said, and he looked up at the ceiling as if he could see through the layered hull into the fight in the vacuum beyond.

Raldoron looked out into a crowded battlesphere. There was a reason they called it space; the cosmos contained untold volumes of nothingness, yet just then it felt uncomfortably full.

A flight of enemy gunboats overflowed the bridge insolently close, strafing the crenellated spine of the *Promissum Sanguinem* with high-powered lascannons. They skimmed the void envelope, the impacts of their weapons making the shields flex and bulge. Patterns of oily purple raced around the strikes, complicating a view already thick with flashes of energy weapons, explosions, and spinning asteroids. Point-defence turrets slaved to servitor units tracked the ships, spitting long streams of tracer fire and plasma after

them. This caused the gunboats' own shields to react, and flares of interface discharge looped behind, reaching out to touch and merge with the *Promissum Sanguinem*'s shields.

The lance turrets ranged down either side of the ship's sloping flanks blasted thick columns of las light. These were directed not at the craft harrying the *Promissum Sanguinem*, but forward, atomising the larger rocks that threatened the ship, clearing its passage. Debris from shattered asteroids showered the prow shields, making them sparkle madly, and weakening them further.

The command deck was just as thick with activity. Humans moved in such a frantic dance it was as if they sought to reproduce the chaos of the void outside. In contrast to the confusion beyond the oculus, the holo-displays sketched out the developing battle with a glaring, ruthless clarity. Raldoron's task force surging forward, the heavier vessels of the enemy struggling to keep up, their lighter vessels swinging between the detritus of the system's birth, taking shots where they could, projecting threat where they could not. All the small fleet's forward guns were pounding at the asteroid belt, reducing stone billions of years old into expanding clouds of molten droplets.

'Clear target gain reported from spinal lance four,' shouted out one of the gunnery liaisons. 'Requesting permission to disregard standing orders and engage the enemy.'

Raldoron glanced at the nearest display. A box denoting a firm augury lock settled on one of the gunboats, now receding into the maelstrom of explosions ahead.

'Negative,' Shipmaster Boise responded. 'Maintain forward bombardment.'

Raldoron continued to watch in silence. He let the mortals do their work. They kept the formation tight. They kept the enemy back. He had no need to become involved in the labours of voidsmen. There would be much for him to do soon enough.

The ships were well furnished with weaponry. Though their prow weapons were occupied with clearing a path, their flank batteries and stern guns were free to wreak havoc on the foe. Careful broadsides kept the larger enemy back when they encroached too closely, or drove off the squadrons of destroyers and torpedo boats nosing around the perimeter with fiery bursts

of flak. There was a price to pay for this tactic. Hails of shrapnel peppered them, adding to the sparkling display of debris strikes and weapons hits on the voids, and allowing more and more hits to contact the hull, but the Blood Angels ships were durable. They weathered damage the smaller enemy vessels could not.

Raldoron's eyes narrowed. Ahead was an asteroid the size of a continent. Boise, who missed little, caught the tension in the giant at the side of his command throne.

'Do you see something, my lord?'

'It is what I do not see that troubles me,' said Raldoron. 'Augury section, sweep that large asteroid ahead, quadrant Epsilon-Nine-B.'

His orders were obeyed without question, the master augurum himself doing the work.

'The asteroid?' Boise said. 'It could be the ambush site. What readings?'

'Nothing, my lord,' the officer said. 'But the asteroid is largely iron. It is distorting signal returns.'

'They will hit us there,' Raldoron said.

'I don't know,' said Boise. 'Any gathering of significant force would be seen, my lord, iron or no. Attacking us here is a risk for them.'

'If they had a significant force, they would be on us already. But they are outnumbered. Because they are outnumbered they are going to try to board us here.' He said this only for Boise's ears. He would not undermine the shipmaster's authority by disagreeing with him in front of his men.

'Should we break away, try to avoid it?' Boise asked, equally quietly. 'I am sure we can take their fleet here quickly. We could come about, deny them their surprise.'

'We cannot afford the time. Drive forward – they are attempting to push us in that direction, let us go to them readily. If we break out of the belt and go around, then their pursuit force will catch us as we shift formation. We will prevail, but it will cost us hours.'

'Then we're walking right into their trap, my lord.'

'They wish to catch and kill me, I wish to catch them and annihilate them. Here is as good a place as any to test our relative mettle. A trap sprung by aware prey is no trap at all.'

'As you command, my lord,' said Boise. He cradled his chin, then nodded. 'This shall at least be interesting.'

As the shipmaster gave his orders, Raldoron put on his helm and gestured to his golden protectors. ‘When they come, stand away from me. They will not strike at guarded bait.’

The Death Guard attacked as Raldoron had predicted, a swarm of assault boats, landing claws and boarding torpedoes approaching at full velocity as soon as the shadow of the asteroid fell across the *Promissum Sanguinem*’s bow. They slewed around the ancient stone, thrusters hot, fighting to tighten the parabolas physics forced onto their movement. The little ships were vulnerable, but the range was short. Anti-fighter fire took only a tenth of them. The craft hit the guttering voids still at full speed, fast enough to trigger the strange effects of the shields even when they were weakened. Another tenth died in fire-flash impacts as the weary energy barrier flexed, pulling wreckage and screaming survivors into the warp.

The rest hurtled over the short distance between void envelope and ship. More of them were gunned down by point-defence fire. More of the ships hit the hull too hard and came apart, crumpling silently like models of wet paper thrown against stone.

The remainder fired up their melta arrays, extended cruel, hull-tearing claws, and bit into the *Promissum Sanguinem*’s skin.

CHAPTER TWELVE

BOARDERS

The last void collapsed with a tremendous rumble. The seismic shaking of stressed shield generators rocked the Elevatii on their feet. A gnawing, spiritual disturbance washed through them. There were physical effects that every man felt differently. For some it was the taste of aluminium on their teeth, and uncontrolled, bitter salivation. Others developed headaches, double vision, or strange flashes of far-off places and times. An unlucky few suffered nausea so fierce it required injections of antiemetics to quell.

There was a brief moment where enemy fire slammed into the unprotected vessel, then it ceased, the ship shivered one last time, and stilled. It was enough to tell Assan the boarders were coming. The big guns were still venting their hatred at the traitors, and rocks clattered off the ship like hail hitting a plasteel roof, but there were no further weapons impacts.

‘This is the moment,’ said Assan. ‘Company, weapons ready.’

The insect whine of charging lasrifles chased the brief calm away.

‘Orders coming in from the solar marshal,’ Qaziz said. ‘Prepare for combat. Central command reports multiple boarding craft inbound. Final estimates of impact zones coming through.’

‘I knew it. Give me a datafeed.’

‘As you command, sir.’

Assan accessed his vox-interlink’s widecast capability, patching himself into the company vox-network directly. ‘All men, stand ready, boarding

craft inbound. Repeat, boarding craft inbound.'

The chime of data inload from Qaziz brought his attention to the small cartograph on his helm display. The confused jumble of corridors, chambers and hidden spaces that comprised the ship's near interior made itself known.

Fresh tremors shook their position, different in quality to those that came before. They were hard, singular in their nature, not shells or energy beams nor the shattered stone of the disturbed asteroid belt, but solid objects directed with purpose. They were far too regular, far too penetrating, hard hits coming together in a chain of coordinated strikes.

Assan got to twenty before he lost count.

Orange circles like angry suns pulsed on the map. Five impacts, very close, boarding ships burrowing into the vessel like ticks on a beast's hide.

Assan voxed his reserves.

'Lieutenant Firal, take tercios Beta and Gamma. Form a line at the forty-first intersection. Cover our back against enemy envelopment, be ready if we need to fall back to you. The rest of you, on me.'

'Twenty plus known successful hull contacts,' a warrant officer relayed to Raldoron, shouting over the noise of the bridge crew. 'Enemy groups of Auxilia and legionaries forming into six main incursion groups throughout the ship.'

The report was accompanied by the shimmer-wash updating of a tactolith. Red markers moving through mazes of corridors. Blue markers denoting friendly forces moving to meet them.

Vallis had come to the command deck armoured for combat. He leaned close to Raldoron. 'Perhaps we should consider unleashing our legionaries now. There are no more assault craft inbound, and no more ships to carry further foes. They have invested their full strength.'

Raldoron shook his head the smallest amount. 'You are wrong. This is the prelude. We commit the Legion only when the main movement commences.'

'What do you anticipate?' Vallis said.

'I hear the doubt in your voice, Vallis. They have something more planned. The Fourteenth are gone into treachery, but they have not lost their wits. They are provoking us. They wound the *Promissum Sanguinem*. They want

us to react, and only when we are distracted will they deliver the killing thrust. It will fall here, I am sure. Keep your men ready. They will be needed.'

'You are probably right,' said Vallis. 'You usually are.' He gave a smile Raldoron did not return.

'Energy surge detected! Incoming enemy vessel! Medius scale, class unknown.'

'Give me a view,' Raldoron commanded.

A servo-skull dropped down from the high vaulted ceiling. The holo-projector jutting from its mouth shone an image into the air.

The edge of the holo was defined by the slowly turning mass of the continent-asteroid, its surface speckled with explosions as stray munitions slammed into it. Creeping out from its shadow came a wreck of a cruiser, something broken by war, its gun decks gaping empty, many sections of the hull open to the void. The cream livery of the Death Guard was blackened and scarred. The thing was virtually dead, but it was coming right at them, newly lit engines burning hard. Upon its prow were jury-rigged cannons.

'What are they trying?' Vallis said. 'A ramming manoeuvre?'

'Take evasive action!' Boise shouted. Klaxons wailed. The ship throbbed, then groaned, as thrusters pushed hard at its nose, bringing it up. 'Full speed, get us out of its path!'

A rock corkscrewed down from above, crashing hard into the oculus. The armaglass held, and the asteroid bounced away, sent off on a random course into the mayhem of war.

Steel moaned. Integrity field monitors wailed. The *Promissum Sanguinem* nosed painfully upwards. Gravitic forces tugged at the crew, causing them to grab at their consoles. A servitor fell with a crash.

The guns upon the prow of the hulk opened up, their void-silenced shout seen as a series of flashes.

'Incoming mass barrage!'

'Distance to enemy vessel?' Boise demanded.

A flight of enemy bombers sped by, missiles pushed on columns of gas firing down and at the *Promissum Sanguinem's* superstructure. The bombers accelerated away, chased by Xiphon interceptors. One came apart under a barrage of rotary rocket fire.

‘Distance thirty-six kilometres. If we don’t get clear, they’ll ram us in less than twenty seconds,’ the master augurum reported.

The cannon shells slammed into the flank of the *Promissum Sanguinem*, followed closely by the missiles. One crashed into the forward spire. More alarms wailed. A statue fell from its perch and shattered on the deck. A man was crushed by a stone fist the size of a tank hatch.

‘Enemy vessels moving in from behind,’ an officer shouted.

Raldoron’s eyes flicked to the relevant display. Both fleets were strung out, in bad order, their formations entirely spoiled by the rough battlesphere, but the Blood Angels’ numbers were telling. The display flashed as an enemy cruiser’s reactor went critical. The glare of it washed from behind the ship. The command spires cast momentary, harsh shadows down the length of the prow. Fleet coordinators shouted orders. Another enemy vessel was boxed in, and pounded from three sides. Another attempted to turn, and hit an asteroid, scraping its flank all along the stone.

A shout went up from one of the sensorium pits.

‘Energy surge detected! Energy surge detected! Readings commensurate with imminent teleport attack.’

‘This is it then, the enemy’s gambit. What has befallen them, that they take so costly a route to our throats?’ Raldoron said.

‘Madness,’ said Vallis. ‘It is nothing but madness.’

There must have been fewer ships than Raldoron had suspected, else the Death Guard would not have sacrificed a vessel of that class, even one so battered. They were falling back on their habitual ways – they wanted a close fight, and yet at such uneven odds it made him wonder where their discipline of old was.

‘The crux approaches,’ said Raldoron. ‘If we win here, we win this system.’ He drew the *Encarmine Warblade* and pressed the activation rune. The sword gleamed with disruption fire. ‘First Company!’ Raldoron roared. ‘Stand by to repel boarders!’

Blood Angels took position at the edges of the galleries overlooking the pits housing the command deck officers. Twinned lascannons and heavy bolters descended on oiled steel pistons, swivelling gun barrels down into active position as their targeting lenses flared on. Naval armsmen prepared, relegated to the second line in this war of legionaries, all while the shipmaster and his officers tried as best they could to continue directing the

void battle. The *Promissum Sanguinem* laboured upwards. The hulk coasted beneath them, veering from its straight course, engines dead. It did not matter. It had achieved its goal.

Raldoron felt the teeth-itching, skin-crawling sensation of imminent teleportation. An orb of blue corpusant flickered some twenty metres from him, and vanished. It reappeared a couple of metres to the right of its initial position, skittering to and fro before halting. Limbs of harsh lightning sprouted from the teleport nexus to crawl over the deck plates. In the highest parts of the deck, cyber-constructs fled for their roosts.

Thirty boltguns swivelled to cover the position.

A second blue orb moved coyly across the deck, sidling around, gradually coasting to a stop in the subsidiary augury pit, where it fastened itself with roots of uncanny foxfire. Men and women scrambled out of the way. A hum more felt than heard built. The lights strobed. The teleport nexuses bloomed large and round, lightning-coloured holes in reality. Silhouettes appeared in them, huge, hulking, and black.

The pulsing hit a maddening beat. The orbs burst, there was a bang of displaced air.

Twenty Death Guard veterans clad in Cataphractii Terminator armour materialised on the bridge. One was melded with the deck, the result of malteleportation. His dying hands twitched. The rest came out firing.

‘For Sanguinius! Protect the Archein!’ The call was clear, melodic, spoken from the golden mask of the Sanguinary Guard as they jetted down from an observation platform fifteen metres above the command deck floor. They slammed into the edges of the enemy formation, power spears cracking into ceramite plating.

The cry was taken up by the rest of Raldoron’s veterans, then lost to the enemy’s answer, an expanding cone of fire which roared out from a heavy flamer, turning a command pit into a lake of burning death. Black smoke flooded out, thick with screams. Half the Death Guard turned their guns on the humans. Slaughter the officers, cripple the flagship.

Raldoron was not going to allow that.

‘Slay them all!’ Raldoron cried, and the command deck became a killing zone.

Two Traitor Auxilia crashed down. The last of the enemy las fire flickered, then went out. Assan held up his fist.

‘Hold fire! Hold fire! Hold fire!’

The cry was carried back down the line. Smoke swirled unevenly in the recyc currents. Fire blurred orange through it. Sparks fizzed and cracked from ruptured power lines.

A pair of the boarding torpedoes had come in close together. Their battered snouts rested on runs of cooling slag bored through the hull by their melta arrays. One protruded at a difficult angle from the ceiling. An enemy auxiliary hung from his restraint web, dead on impact, arms dangling past the assault ramp.

Assan’s men had been waiting for them when they arrived.

Bulbous, coral-like fans of foam swelled around the crafts’ prows, plugging the hull breaches. The stink of it, chemical and charred, was hotly unpleasant through Assan’s air filter. From somewhere, he caught the whistle of air mix escaping imperfect seals. He waited. Someone moaned in the murk. Nothing moved.

‘Augury scan,’ he commanded.

The machine strapped to the arm of his augurer, Porios, gave a cautious whoop.

‘Nothing living.’

‘Break cover. Make sure they’re all dead.’ Assan stepped out into the corridor. His men went past and set to their grisly work.

Assan stopped by the nearest boarder, killed less than a dozen steps onto the ship. He had twisted as he had fallen, and lay on his back, face up, his gun lying a metre from his out-flung hand, his other arm resting on his chest. Las beams had punched through him, three small black holes that gave up curls of smoke. The light was still on in his helm, showing staring, dead eyes. He looked surprised. The dead always looked surprised.

He was a man, Assan thought. A man like him, a member of the proud Solar Auxilia. The badges on his shoulders proclaimed full Legion bonding to the XIV. That made him Elevatii too. The patterns of wargear were largely the same. His blood was the same. His death was like all other deaths: unwanted, lonely, and painful. Assan expected no less for himself.

He wondered what path had brought this man here, to fight against his old comrades.

A lasrifle gave out a coughing snap, finishing an injured enemy. The noise of the world intruded once more. There was no quarter in this war. Armour clanked as bodies were turned over. His men looted gently, almost apologetically, taking ammunition and equipment. They'd come back later to scavenge their armour. He took a few more steps, looking up into the maw of the boarding torpedo. His stablight glanced off the dangling corpse.

There was an urgent peeping. Fresh orders.

‘Qaziz?’

‘Second group of boarders are inbound from lower decks. Penetration effected on twenty-second deck. Hostile units ascending quickly. Deck ten, deck nine...’ There was a pause. ‘Suspected Astartes. Repeat, internal ship’s augury suggests power-armoured foes.’

Assan sequestered a feed from Porios and played it from the holo-unit mounted on his forearm. Wireframe view only, the internal tangle of the ship drawn in hard whites, enemy units in red, his own in solid blue. He watched a moment. The view flared as smoke floated through it. ‘Command squad, on me. Veletarii to the fore.’

‘Veletaris section one present!’ Adjutant Suban responded. Adjutant Phaazid was not far after.

‘Tercio Alpha, shadow us, close support. Check your firing lines. Qaziz, signal command. Tell them we’ll take these ourselves.’

More voxed confirmation came.

Assan’s elites jogged by into the haze of emergency lumen light. Though Assan had argued with his father about the squads, he was glad of the Veletarii now. He checked his augur feed, seeing the heavily armoured figures of enemy legionaries – only a few, but a few would be enough to kill them all. The Veletarii’s volkites would at least give them a chance.

He shut off the holo.

The Auxilia had been a warm-up. This time, they would be facing the Death Guard themselves.

Veletaris section one ranged ahead. Assan’s command squad came right after, Tercio Alpha close behind. He had to lead from the front. He had to prove his worth. Let his men see he had earned his father’s gift honestly, as a soldier, not a son, then maybe he could rest easy about the favours he had been given.

They took a branching corridor. The generous fifty-metre width of the Via Magna narrowed to ten. The foe were two hundred metres away. Bolter fire crackled ahead. There was shouting. There was no signum mark on his cartolith to show who was under attack, so he suspected the enemy had encountered some of the crew. The firing didn't last long. The blurry, nondescript icons denoting the enemy continued towards them. They were close now, only two bulkheads between the Death Guard and his men.

‘Enemy advancing, halt. Cover the door!’

They took up position sixty metres up from a bulkhead. A door, slightly larger than man-sized, pierced the centre, sealed by an automated lock wheel. This would be the second door the enemy would have to penetrate. The first would slow them, nothing more than that. There were no more soldiers between Assan and the legionaries of the boarding party. His men took whatever cover they could find. There wasn't much – a handful of buttresses supporting the weight of the deck above, a few doorways into side rooms.

‘These doors won't hold them long,’ Assan ordered. ‘Use the time. Anything in the compartments, bring it out. Barricade!’

The men explored the side rooms. Some found spare deck plating, which they dragged out and propped against the buttresses. Each squad had a set of plasma torches assigned to them, and their bearers set to work welding the makeshift barricades into place. All was practised. The sons of the desert had become masters of the void.

‘Qaziz, give me a line to access command.’

‘You are through, cousin.’

The harsh buzz of disrupted vox half-deafened him.

‘Access command, deck six.’ He could barely hear the woman on the other end of the vox. Her voice broke apart, interrupted by the electromagnetic backwash of energy weapons fire and void shield generators struggling to reignite.

‘Shut down all bulkhead portals, corridor nine-four-seven-alpha, port side.’

‘Code confirmed. Actualising. Door locks engaging.’

He heard the farther door slam closed. A second after, the lock wheels on the bulkhead spun at the command of the distant operator, flinging four bolts into their hasps. The heavy clacking of them snapped up the corridor.

He accessed the ship's internal sensorium array. The vid-view of the far side showed the first door another hundred metres down the corridor. There was a flash, bright enough to overwhelm the feed. When it came back on, the sensor was damaged, but the door was gone. Fuzzy shapes approached the second door, the one his men were covering, with haste.

Assan drew his blast pistol. He remembered the day he had received it, presented to him by his father when he attained the rank of captain. Then he had been proud. Then he had not fretted about nepotism or unwon favours. The memory suddenly seemed bizarre, as if it had happened in another life, to another man.

A pounding set up on the door, seven strikes, sonorous and severe, like something from a ritual, he thought, the sounding of a temple bell. Then a heavier blow struck the metal, and he heard the muffled crack-bang of a disruptor field. A blurred helm looked into the door's vid-capter, a hand raised, and the image went out.

His men were arranged with the Veletaris squad closest to the door, where the phenomenal fire rate of their volkite chargers would prove most telling. There wasn't much room – fifty metres between the lead squad and the door – but that was counter-boarding actions for you. Behind the Veletarii was his own command group, then the two rifle and line command sections of Tercio Alpha. Seventy-three men all told. The squads ranged themselves carefully, their guns clear of one another and pointed at the door. He had the maximum amount of firepower deployed given the limited space.

The ship shuddered. Solid rounds were striking the hull again, hard, their impacts rumbling through the structure. In this part of the ship the return fire was almost as noisy. Broad-sides were infrequent but violent, a roar like chained, distant avalanches. The spine turrets were more constant, the grumble of the giant motors rotating them audible six decks below. All power was diverted to the weapons and the shields. The lances were so power hungry that when they charged to fire, they did so with an invidious hum of stressed capacitors and the flicker of emergency lumens.

Assan checked his augury feed. Confused signals of energy and movement.

'Porios, can you get me a clearer reading from the far side of the door?'

'Yes, sir,' Porios responded. He knelt down, and adjusted the complex array of buttons on his master auspex. 'Ready now, sir!'

Assan checked his helm view again. The information fed to him cleared. On the augury view now, Space Marine reactor packs were bright orbs. The power conduits of their armour were lines of light, like nets of exposed nerves. The sharpened scan confirmed that one of the legionaries had a power fist, its field blazing painfully through the augur.

The three shapes on the far side of the door had become five, two more coming up the corridor to join the initial three.

‘They’ll be through in a moment. Prepare weapons.’

A plate clanged to the deck as a specialist abandoned his weld and stowed his plasma torch, his hands moving expertly to activate his gun. Sharp, rapid movements rippled through the Veletaris squad as they started charging processes and disengaged safety catches on their volkites. Such caution was warranted aboard a ship. A volkite emitted a powerful energy ray that if used indiscriminately could do a great deal of damage. They were left inactive till the last possible moment.

The other two traitors had reached the door. The clatter of the power fist hitting the steel ceased. There was a clang of something heavy mag-locking to the bulkhead. A spike of energy jagged off the display in Assan’s helmet, too extreme for the narrow box of the temperature gauge to contain. The air took on the rough feel of spilled electrons. Heat indicators in Assan’s helm spiked. The narrow corridor became stifling.

A red spot appeared in the centre of the door.

‘Melta charge!’ he yelled. ‘They’re coming through!’

Heat flashed across the metal, brightening to a blazing white. The wheel lock glowed, sagged, then fell down, the superheated handles deforming under their own weight. Within a couple of seconds, the door had collapsed in a spray of sparks. Metal vapours poured upwards, crawling along the ceiling and into the atmospheric exchange vents.

Assan saw a power-armoured figure on the far side, silhouetted by the glare of molten metal. His mind went blank. No matter how many times he fought Space Marines, transhuman dread could never be conquered. He had never experienced anything other than a mild disquiet around the Blood Angels. Facing a legionary in combat was a different matter altogether; they were so big, so heavily armoured, so indomitable. These were men changed by Dark Age sciences, the conquerors of the galaxy.

The Death Guard's bolters raked the remains of the door to shreds. Gobbets of molten metal sprayed into the corridor.

The howl of volkites met the foe. Beams of searingly bright energy cut down the corridor, their edges jagged with hard spikes, like a hundred lightning bolts laid one atop the other. They banished the feeble illumination of the emergency lumens, showing him the enemy in horrible clarity. Streams of energy washed against impenetrable battle plate.

The first of Assan's men died. Bolt rounds cut him to pieces, blasting his ribcage out of his back and showering his companions with gore. His armour barely held his shattered corpse together. Already the first of the Death Guard was pushing his way through the cooling door, armour smoking where it touched the metal. Even in the hell-glow of molten metal and dim emergency light, Assan could see his armour was poorly maintained, and pitted with damage.

'Death to the false Emperor,' the legionary growled, his voxmitter on maximum volume.

Then he was firing on full-automatic, driving the Veletarii back into their meagre cover. Another man fell, and another.

The Death Guard were filthy, their armour so caked with dirt and rust that the green and white of their livery was almost indistinguishable. Their insignia was scratched to illegibility. They wore rusty skirts of chainmail that could have served only an aesthetic purpose. They were huge, as all Astartes were, but somehow they seemed even larger, swollen almost, as if something foul lent them bulk. An illusion, but a potent one. There was only space in the corridor for them to fight three abreast. The other pair jostled behind. True to their Legion's nature, they walked into the auxiliaries' attack, taking the searing rays as if they were rain, eschewing a charge in order to fire their own guns. The plate they bore was a modified variant of Mark III, its already significant armour bolstered by additional layers of segmented plate. A volkite beam would evaporate bare flesh, but could be stopped by armour like that, and although the volley carved burning grooves into the legionaries' armour, they continued to move implacably forward. They were dazzled by the volkite beams, but fired with discipline, and their bolts found their marks. Men to the left and right of Assan went down, their heads and chests hollowed out.

Time slowed. Assan saw the links of the traitors' mail blasted apart by magnesium-bright bursts. The Death Guard advanced into the volkite storm, the beams so closely interlocked they formed a sparkling wall. It was only when the leading Space Marine fell to his knees and clanged down that Assan realised they had managed to fell one. There was an almighty bang, and a ragged cheer.

Their triumph was short-lived. The traitor with the power fist stepped over the corpse of his brother, and broke into a lumbering run. For a moment he was wreathed in vapours from his evaporating ceramite, scorched up by the volkites. Then he was among them, his fist blazing with crawling blue lightning. It was a slow weapon, hard to use, and he swung clumsily. Yet when the fist connected with a human body, then there was no human body left.

If the power field did the damage, shattering atoms to nothing, the follow-up from the weight of the gauntlet was cruel overkill. The first man exploded, half of his corpus transmitted to crackling motes of energy, half smoking meat that flew in every direction, coating them all in shocking wetness. One of the dead man's comrades fired at point-blank range, the beam spreading across the Death Guard's armour harmlessly. His body was obliterated by the Space Marine's backswing. With his unpowered gauntlet, the Death Guard grabbed another Veletarii by the throat and dashed his brains out on the corridor wall.

'Kill him! Kill him! Bring him down!' Assan loosed off a shot from his blast pistol. The ancient gun punched a brightly lined hole in the Space Marine's armour. That got his attention. The single-slot lens of his visor swivelled to regard the captain. Volkites beating against him, he came forward to claim Assan as his own.

'Get down, sir,' Mesen said.

Assan turned. The large, slotted barrel of a meltagun nosed past him. Assan shielded his face in the crook of his elbow.

The air shimmered, then roared. A beam of powerful microwaves connected with the Space Marine, slagging his breastplate and drilling a hole right through him. His power pack cooked off, exploding backwards, causing the man behind him to stagger into another, and the enemy's bolter fire slackened. The Saiphani took advantage of it, a few standing to draw a better bead from the back ranks.

A request came through from the sergeant of his second section, Tercio Alpha, asking for permission to fire.

‘Negative,’ Assan voxed. Despite their careful positioning, volleys coming from the back would likely hit his own men. ‘Forward squads only. Concentrate fire, one at a time, dammit! Concentrate fire!’

The fourth legionary fell. His amplified howl of rage turned into a scream as he burned from the inside out.

Assan risked his head to look into the corridor. The thunder of boltguns had diminished to single, repetitive barks. A bolt stuttered past Assan’s face, the rocket motor a lho-stick glow. It careened off a stanchion, exploding with a firecracker snap close by. Micro-shrapnel pinged off Assan’s helmet. The final legionary retreated into the vestibule between the two bulkheads.

Volkites screeched at him. He fired back.

Neither side gained advantage. It gave Assan time to think.

‘Porios, give me a broad battlesphere view. Qaziz, what news?’

‘More boarders inbound. They’re everywhere.’

‘Command orders us to redeploy,’ Qaziz relayed.

Assan looked again. Beams and bolts traded back and forth. The legionary was still falling back, step by methodical step. Volkite rays hissed into his war plate.

‘The marshal says fall back now,’ Qaziz said. ‘Muster point, the Crossing of Praxis. Hold at all costs.’

‘We can kill this one.’

Something potent struck the ship. Alarms blared.

‘More Astartes are moving on our position,’ said Porios. ‘Two hundred metres and closing.’

Assan watched the legionary diminish down the corridor. Bolts buzzed past his men, discouraging pursuit.

‘Assan.’ Qaziz grabbed his arm. ‘Sir! The marshal commands that we redeploy.’

Assan swallowed, then nodded. ‘Spread the order,’ he said. ‘Alpha sections, give covering fire. All fall back to Praxis.’

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

THE CROSSING OF PRAXIS

They were slaughtering men by the dozen when Simeon's squad arrived at the Crossing of Praxis. Six of the Death Guard's elite waded into hails of lasrifle fire with little care. The ruby beams were stopped at the outermost plating of their Terminator armour, harming them not at all. They went into the firing lines of Elevatii, each of them wielding huge powered maces. The Death Guard struck with an air of bored efficiency, up, down, up, down, killing men as monotonously as farmers thresh wheat. Each hit shattered a human body. Limbs and wrecked armour flew from them in red clouds of atomised blood.

Simeon did not think. The roaring of his pulse precluded that. His vision was coloured crimson. He heeded the words of the Archein, to embrace the Thirst. He welcomed the strength it gave him, the simplicity of purpose.

'Power, what are your orders?' Asmodian yelled after him. The young Afrikan was panting – excitement, not exertion, the cause.

'There is a corridor. The enemy are at the end of it. We run at them, we slay them, we try not to die. Does anyone else have any questions?'

A wild laughter responded. There was no disadvantage to the Thirst here, no need for careful strategy or appraisal of the ground.

'Then charge. Charge for the Emperor, for Sanguinius. Charge for blood and for ruin!'

The Angforia surged forward.

The Death Guard were busy with their own red work, eating through the Elevatii as surely as hot metal through ice. Simeon was surprised his squad was not detected – surely the traitors' sensoria would alert them? – but they did not turn, only struck, slew, stepped, struck, slew. That was to his advantage. Far better to assault Cataphractii from the rear. The Thirst pulsed in anticipation.

The noise of battle made itself known. The screams, the desperate shouts under the booming explosions of power mauls, the feeble snap of lasweapons striking at the wall of ceramite, adamantine and engineered flesh, the yelled orders, the crunch of bodies shattering underfoot.

The Angforia announced themselves with a volley of bolt pistol fire before hitting the enemy hard. One of the six turned halfway around in the ponderous, inexorable way of Terminator-armoured warriors. He brought his mace around, the head fizzling with boiling blood. Simeon leapt and struck him before he completed the movement.

Simeon's chainsword pushed through the power field enveloping the heavy legionary, and slashed into the square cowling that covered his shoulders. Teeth jumped as the weapon skipped down the armour and dragged out chunks of ceramite, taking off the dull white paint and exposing the leaden grey of the alloy beneath.

Simeon followed his blade through. Ceramite clashed off ceramite as he hit his foe full-on. The Terminator was heavier, his centre of gravity lower; still Simeon's leap staggered him. He took two unsteady steps with Simeon clinging to his arm before he planted his feet, regained his balance, and pushed back. Simeon remained clamped to the warrior, robbing him of the use of his maul, so the Death Guard brought his combi-bolter down sharply on Simeon's head twice, each blow making the helm plate of his armour jump. Simeon jammed the muzzle of his own pistol into the small gap between the Death Guard's head and high-cowled back. He emptied it into the space, dazzling them both with rapid explosions. The armour held, though the helm cracked, the lens broke inwards, and for a moment the foe showed him a reddened, bloodied eye as he turned, dropping his gun, and punched hard.

Simeon hardly felt it. The Thirst was on him. Blood roared in his helm, louder than the screams and the gunfire. It urged him to surrender himself, to rake and claw at his foe, but the words of Raldoron came to him again –

to use the Thirst, not to let it use him. Simeon drew on it, turning a portion of his focus inwards and using the Thirst to sharpen his senses and strengthen his arm. He clung on, fishing at his belt for a krak grenade. He found it, deflected another punch to his head, thumbing on the grenade and jammed it into the splintered gap between helm and cowl.

He let go. The Death Guard raised his maul. The grenade exploded with a hollow *crunk*.

The Terminator stood a moment, the void his head had so recently occupied fountaining blood, then his knees folded. Simeon threw himself to one side as the traitor legionary crashed to the ground.

Simeon sprang to his feet, ready to fight again. His mind was red, his vision redder. The need to kill and drink salt vitae swelled in him. The restraint he had imposed upon himself trembled. The Thirst was in danger of pushing out all thought, all consideration.

Five of his men were dead, armour shattered. Only one other Terminator had fallen, brought down by so many chainsword blows his armour had become a sculpture of chewed metallo-ceramic. A group of the Angforia had cornered a third Death Guard, and were baiting him like dogs at a cornered bear. The other three still ran amok, smiting both Blood Angels neophytes and Auxilia with equal, stolid impunity.

Maybe half a second passed, maybe less, an eternity of blood-greed encapsulated within. The smell of spilled vitae filled his nose, threatening to drown him in a sea of red.

One of Simeon's squad was hurled towards him, his innards a smoking, gory girdle about his waist. Simeon dodged the corpse, and found himself facing his brother's killer.

'You next, whelp,' the Death Guard said, and levelled his mace.

Simeon braced for an attack that never came.

The Terminator began what would have been an unstoppable charge, had he not been caught in the side by the telltale column of shimmering air of a melta beam, his armour broken into molten wreckage by the hit. He bent towards the heat, as much as his rigid battle plate would allow. A score of las beams followed, targeting the breach, and though his power field spat and shrieked, he fell dead. Then the blinding sear of volkite beams lit up the crossroads.

More Elevatii were coming, and these were far better armed.

After that, it was over in seconds. The final Terminator to die was the one cornered by Simeon's men, the thickness of his armour overwhelmed by hundreds and hundreds of bolt and las impacts.

The Elevatii drew up cautiously. Their leader seemed to sense something amiss. Simeon's men gathered opposite, a sea of corpses between. The thunder of Simeon's pulse was louder than ever. He could smell blood, blood everywhere.

Their leader took a step forward, small before the Space Marines, but proud enough not to give in to his obvious fear. He saluted.

'My lord, I am Captain Assan Faisal-Almazi. We are here to...'

Simeon could see the tremor of the man's heartbeat in the skin around his eyes, even behind the visor, even through the suit. He could practically taste his blood.

'Leave,' Simeon said thickly. His men shifted around him, high-strung on combat. He felt their desire to feast. It was as powerful as his own. 'Leave now.'

'Power, if I may—'

'Order,' Simeon grunted. The power of speech was slipping away. 'That is an order. We shall hold the crossing. We shall hold... here.'

The captain looked dubiously at Simeon's arms, no doubt noting the black patterning of the inductii that clad his upper body, as if he had been dipped in shame.

'Of course, my lord,' he said. 'Of course.'

Very wary now, Assan's men retreated.

'Hold,' Simeon told his warriors. 'Hold.' He felt their Thirst rising. When he was sure the humans were away, he took off his helm. The faecal stink of ruptured guts hit him like a physical blow. He cared not. Beneath, pervasive, alluring, was the unfiltered copper tang of blood, strong and undeniable.

He moved towards the fallen Terminators, already salivating. A hand grabbed his arm, and he spun towards the owner, ready to fight.

'Ismael?' he said. 'You live.'

'Breathe deeper,' the legionary said thickly. 'This blood is tainted.' He released the Power.

Simeon pulled his arm free, and dropped by the cooling corpse of the Death Guard. He bent his head, fangs exposed, then recoiled. 'Bad blood.'

But Ismael was not listening. He looked beyond Simeon, over his back, to where the piles of dead Elevatii clogged the crossing invitingly, leaking crimson. A far more palatable feast.

Simeon stood.

They would not go hungry after all.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

ENCARMINE WARBLADE

Raldoron's power sword came around in a thrumming arc.

The Thirst tugged at him, bringing echoes of past atrocity. He checked it, held it back. *Calm*, he thought. *I am the calm in the storm. I am the silence before the thunder.*

The Death Guard moved to counter, meaning to catch Raldoron's sword between his crackling lightning claws, where a swift twist of the wrist would break the blade. Raldoron changed the sword's angle. Bringing it up and into a thrust, he jabbed with sudden violence at his opponent's visor, forcing his foe to cover his face, claws crossed. The Death Guard dropped his weight to deflect the strike, and his leg went outwards, exposing for an instant the vulnerable hinge of his knee.

Calm, Raldoron thought. He felt the Thirst in him, pushed it down far, far below the infinitesimally thin skin of consciousness. There it swam and snapped, begging for release. Raldoron ruthlessly plundered it for strength.

An instant was all the Archein needed. His gun was ready, the bolt already flying before Raldoron had finished thinking about pulling the trigger. It lodged in the joint and exploded.

Calm, he thought. *I am the calm. My fury is the fury of stone, of ice, of the ages. I am Sanguinius' son. My fury is pure. It is not the fury of fire. It is not the fury of beasts. It is the fury of vengeance.*

The Death Guard shouted something that might have been a curse, might have been an indignant, wordless roar as the full weight of his armour suddenly, mercilessly bore down on his shattered knee. Raldoron sidestepped the man's last, flailed strike, angled his blade tip down, and as the Death Guard fell, thrust the point surely past the top of his helm and deep into the heavy cowl. Sparks flew from the ceramite. The blade encountered the suit's reactor, destroying it. The explosion was contained by the armour as a muffled thump, all its force directed into the wearer.

Raldoron withdrew his sword from the falling corpse, and moved on.

Calm, he thought. *Rage has no hold on me.*

The Death Guard with the heavy flamer had at last been contained, a ring of Blood Angels just outside the range of the washes of flame driving him back by weight of fire against the richly painted rear wall of the command deck, where grim angels dealt judgement upon xenos oppressors. Before he retreated, the flamer bearer had plied his weapon over a large section of the deck, and left behind a sea of fires that filled the air with the thick fumes of burning plastek and flesh. The crew had fled. The situation was altogether confused, the smoke and fire obscuring vision, the energy pulses put out by dying machines making a nonsense of sensorium input and the vox. Raldoron was half-blind and deaf to anything beyond his immediate reach. He moved through the smoke towards the hulking shapes of armoured men, unsure who was friend and who was foe, each parting of fumes revealing scenes of fresh carnage.

Human armsmen fired upon the Death Guard from concealed positions. Boltguns boomed from the upper galleries. Dead crew lay everywhere. Boise had ordered an evacuation once the scale of the threat was clear, and now the ship was being directed from the secondary bridge, deep within the vessel, adequate in calmer space, but no better in the cramped circumstances of the asteroid field than flying blind. The only officers left were dead, broken apart by bolt fire and power weapons, or simply crushed by the weight of the enemy. Freshets of blood raced over the lips of the command pits, filling them with ankle-deep pools of vitae. The smell was distracting. Raldoron saw a figure move, ran at it, halted his blow. A Blood Angel, hunting for targets.

Raldoron had been only partly right about the enemy's goal. Killing him was but one element of their plan, and he rebuked himself for his arrogance.

The enemy had divided into two squads of ten the instant they arrived, half of them with simple havoc on their minds. Five of this ten covered the rampage of their fellows. The rest ignored the Blood Angels unless directly confronted, smashing consoles, slaying servitors and the ship's officers in an attempt to cripple the *Promissum Sanguinem*.

Sanguinius' guardian angels had done much to distract them. One lay dead in a heap of bloodied gold. Raldoron did not know his true name. The warriors of the First Sphere Orders gave up their identities when they assumed their roles, as he, in the past, had done himself. The smoke parted, and he saw the other two moving around a group of the enemy, their leaps boosted by jets from their winged jump packs. Heavy power axes struck ruthlessly. The roar of perdition pistols punctuated their battle cries. They had three of the enemy occupied. Raldoron moved on.

He fired when he could be sure of his target. Flames were burning higher, fed by insulation, grease, dust accumulated over decades of war below deck spaces, licking up to consume fibreboard, baffles, bodies. Glass shattered in the heat. Tongues of fire licked voraciously at priceless tapestries. Half the deck was ablaze, the flames beating against the huge panes of armaglass that made up the oculus. Paint curled from images made by long-dead heroes.

He saw a Death Guard Terminator isolated in the fire. The energy field his armour projected was so overloaded by the heat it was visible as a shimmering dome. Dozens of bolt rounds smashed into it and the armour beneath. One got through to something vital, and he toppled to be cooked in his battle plate.

'Blood Angel.' The voice was deep, sonorous, unfamiliar. 'Blood Angel.'

Raldoron turned. A huge figure strode from the smoke and wavering air. His Cataphractii armour was heavily modified, but there was little decoration, in keeping with the Death Guard's dour character, and ironically similar to Raldoron's own preferences. Its adaptations were purely practical, its already formidable protection reinforced with additional plating. A gorget, higher than the usual, and a dropped peak to his cowl left only his helm's eyes visible. Extra armour covered his knees and elbows and his waist, the few vulnerable spots in that mark of war plate.

Raldoron evaluated the traitor as he approached. The stress the modifications put on the suit's reactor must have been immense, but the

man swaggered, sure of himself. He carried a huge flail, a long metal staff with seven chains, each weighted with a grinning skull. They were powered, Raldoron was certain; it would be a pointless weapon without a disruption field. He thought it a pointless weapon anyway, slow, slow, slow...

‘The famous First Captain of the Blood Angels,’ the warrior said. He sounded amused. ‘I feel honoured.’

‘There is no honour in treachery,’ said Raldoron. ‘Not of any kind.’

‘I am Captain—’

‘I do not care,’ Raldoron said, cutting him off. ‘Your name and rank are meaningless to me. All I see is another traitor to kill. The basest enemy is one that used to be a friend. You are beneath my contempt.’

The warrior stepped aside and lifted his arm, gesturing behind him.

‘Are the contemptible capable of this?’

There was a body on the ground, a broken sword beside it. Vallis. Raldoron did not react, did not show this traitor his dismay.

‘Your lieutenant fared poorly against me,’ the traitor gloated. ‘I wonder if you shall do any better? I have heard many tales of your lineage’s prowess besides your own.’ He shook out the chains of his weapon. ‘I have to say I am disappointed.’

The skulls’ eyes flashed with the activation of an energy field, turning them from ornaments to a genuine threat. The length of each chain and the upper quarter of the staff were energised, up to the top grip. The rest of the haft was not.

Raldoron brought the *Encarmine Warblade* into the guard position.

‘Not too proud to face me, then, if I am so far beneath you?’ The Death Guard began to whirl his chains around.

‘I do my duty in slaying you. That is all,’ said Raldoron.

‘You’re trying too hard, Blood Angel,’ said the Death Guard, and with a grace that took Raldoron a little by surprise, spun his flail up and around.

Raldoron stepped aside. The skulls crashed down, each one voicing a thunderclap roar as it struck the deck. The plating was obliterated, punched through with seven individual, smoking holes that exposed the pipes and wires crowding the spaces beneath. The Death Guard whipped them back, and up, setting them smoothly into spinning motion. They passed through

the air with a crackling thrum, shrouded by the sparkle of annihilated atmosphere.

Again he attacked, again Raldoron stepped aside. The man was skilled, but his choice of weapon was a poor one, requiring effort to get up to useful speed. The tempo was steady, and the movements he made were therefore predictable, though he tried his best to deceive.

Raldoron dodged once, then again, his feet sure even on the broken deck.

‘Is that all you’re going to do, dance around me like one of Fulgrim’s dandies?’

‘No,’ said Raldoron.

On the fifth strike, Raldoron made his move. He stepped in, avoided the flail’s predictable swing, took a hit from three of the lengths of chain to his left arm so he could get closer, allowing them to wrap about his gauntlet. His opponent shouted with premature triumph. The electric jolt of the energy field was unpleasant, and the outer layer of ceramite began to fritter away, but he could take that. The mass of the chains was not significant enough to cause real damage, even powered.

The traitor yanked at his weapon, seeking to draw Raldoron in, to unbalance, trip and floor him, where he would finish the Archein with a full strike of the skulls, or a blow from the spike on the haft. Raldoron was ready. He dropped his sword point so his wrist was reversed, allowed himself to be pulled, and slammed into the Terminator’s breastplate, momentarily trapping the flail between them. The Terminator grunted, drew back. Raldoron pulled his sword up, as if drawing it from its scabbard, while pushing forward. The sword caught on the flail’s power field a moment, then slid off, and into the unprotected metal of the haft.

It cut clean through. The machineries in the flail haft failed with a loud, whipcrack snap. Power earthed into both the Space Marines. The skulls and chains dropped. Raldoron pivoted and slashed down, sliding his sword along the line of the flail’s headless haft, taking the man’s right hand off at the wrist, and slicing deep into the armour of the left.

The Death Guard bellowed. The remains of his flail came upright, his right hand still clamped around it. He slammed it hard against Raldoron, who dipped his pauldron, caught the blow, then grabbed the haft.

His sword was already against the man’s chest.

With his right hand he pushed as his left hand pulled, forcing the blazing tip of the *Encarmine Warblade* through the many layers of his foe's armour, into the chest, through his heart and into the power unit behind. The sword shook as its disruption field broke atomic bonds and shattered his foe's body.

Raldoron stepped back smoothly, pulling out the weapon as he did so. The hole in the Terminator's chest yawned wide. The flesh beneath smouldered.

The mortally wounded Death Guard crashed to Raldoron's feet.

With dispassionate anger he looked down at the corpse. 'I trust you do not find me disappointing,' he said.

Raldoron left the man to die nameless and alone, and went to the side of his fallen comrade.

Vallis was clearly dead. He didn't need telemetry to tell him that. His helm instruments finally snagged onto the Legion noospheric frequency, and showed him the flatline profile of Vallis' vital signs, confirming the obvious. The champion had caught him squarely on the side with his flail. Three closely spaced impact sites had annihilated his left arm, pauldron and the left stabilising jet of his power pack. None of this damage had been visible from Raldoron's previous position, but up close it was impossible to miss. Nearly a third of his friend's body was missing, gone into the smoke of the command deck.

He rested his hand upon Vallis' untouched shoulder, reached for the hilt of his broken sword, and wordlessly placed it back in Vallis' hand. Then he stood. The gunfire was dying off.

His helm display jagged, buzzed, then stabilised. He brought up the Legion tactical screed. Too many were dead. But no threat indicators remained, except that of the flamer-bearing veteran. He turned to the back wall in time to see this Terminator finally contained by his warriors. The Death Guard raised his heavy weapon, but its twin nozzles sputtered empty.

Raldoron saw robed figures. There was a flicker of blue light, and the thunderous crack of electromagnetic discharge, a high-energy arc weapon the Mechanicum employed to shut down enemy automata, rare enough to be unusual to him. The warrior's suit locked up, imprisoning its occupant.

'Archein, we have a prisoner!' Power Genaris of the attacking squad voxed him exultantly. Then roaring curtains of pure white fire suppressant blasted

down from emitters above, cutting the smoke in half like a knife, and sealing off the captive from view.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

THE RITE OF FLESH

Raldoron was on his way to the ship's detention level when Forgemaster Arnovael found him. He acknowledged the Techmarine curtly as he fell into step beside him. Both of them had many tasks to attend to. There was no time to stop and talk.

'I assume you have bad news for me if you've sought me out yourself?'

Arnovael's armour was blackened with smoke damage. One gauntlet had lost its paint and the ceramite beneath had a yellow-ish heat bloom. Raldoron wondered what damaged machine had been so valuable for Arnovael to risk his hand to save. The blunt snout of his servo-arm's claw bore fresh, bright silver scratches.

'Not so very bad, though not so good either. I would have delivered it sooner. You are hard to find.'

'I have much to do,' Raldoron said.

They walked on. It was dark in those quarters, the lumens spread by a miser's hand, and the few doors strongly reinforced.

'I appreciate you not announcing our difficulties over the vox-net.'

Arnovael laughed briefly. It had a mechanical quality put out through his voxmitters. His helm was of a rare flat-faced sort, and with all the equipment he carried, it gave him the look of a machine.

'I just wanted to speak to you myself. It's not a question of morale.'

'And you said your news was not good...'

‘The impact of my tidings will have an effect on a mind relative to their understanding of the difficulties we face.’

‘Somehow, I am not reassured.’

‘You are going to interrogate the prisoners?’

‘I am. It is a priority. Give me your report.’

‘Mechanicum damage teams are at work on the command deck as we speak. We suffered a twenty-two per cent loss of bridge crew. Several critical stations are unusable, and sections of the deck are unstable where the fires were fiercest.’

‘I am hoping that is the worst of it.’

‘We have taken harder blows and returned to the fray before, Archein. We have the secondary command deck, meaning the ship is not dead in the void, and other damage is superficial. Archmagos Bruqu is personally uprating capabilities in the secondary deck to take on some of the command and control functions of the main bridge, so we will be able to defend ourselves.’

‘How long will that take?’

‘Working without pause, we should have power diverted and all the undamaged sections running within eighty-four hours. The sections that suffered the gravest damage will take much longer. Some of them require complete dismantling and fabrication.’

‘Name them.’

‘Astrocartography, shield control, life-systems management, long-range communications, and the astrotelepathic liaison post. We have also lost half of gunnery control – the Death Guard were not stupid, they made a priority of that.’

‘We were fortunate our fleet kept back their cruisers, or we would have been defenceless,’ said Raldoron. ‘Still, I call their actions reckless. They had no chance of breaking through.’

‘That is so, but damaging to us nevertheless. We can transfer most of the functions of the damaged sections to the secondary bridge, though splitting operation of our guns across two separate locations will compromise their effectiveness.’

‘Then what is your advice?’

‘I recommend you refrain from committing the *Promissum Sanguinem* to direct combat, at least until the main bridge is back online. I advise that

efficiency across all sectors will be compromised by a non-trivial degree, so if possible, Archein, keep her out of battle altogether.'

'That is difficult advice to follow, given the circumstances.'

'I give you only my opinion. You are our lord. You must do with my counsel as you will.'

'How long until full repairs can be effected?'

'To regain full functionality, two weeks, at least,' said Arnovael. 'Complete repairs require a dry dock, of course, but then...' He trailed away.

'There is hardly a fully functional ship in any fleet. If I request the same information from the Mechanicum priests, what will they say?'

'Stop the ship now. Repairs must be made immediately.' Arnovael laughed grimly again. 'Our priorities are a little different to theirs. But maybe they have a point. We lost half our shield generators to burn-out. Dealing with the asteroid field overtaxed them. They too will take time to refurbish.'

'Is that a rebuke?'

'I am not a tech-priest, my lord Archein, chastising you for misusing my charges. I am a simple stater of fact. Logic is my master, not prayer.'

They reached the final barrier to the detention level, a massive armoured door. This was not decorated in the typical gold-heavy Blood Angels style, but sternly plain.

'You have given me much to think about.'

'I doubt you enjoy many days where there is little to think about, Archein Raldoron.' Arnovael dipped his head. 'We shall pursue all efforts to put this weapon back into your hand as soon as possible.' He left Raldoron facing the doors to the detention level.

It was a deliberately misleading title. The sort of prisoner kept there was not merely detained, but taken there to be forgotten, spirited away back to Baal when time allowed to live out their days as sacred monsters in the Arx Angelicum. There was no door activation panel on the door exterior, no vox, no capter. A cowed skeleton holding an hourglass in one hand and a flower in the other stared from an alcove to the left of the door. Raldoron stood in front of it. The head rose on clicking gears, bringing eyes of Baalian Bloodstone up to look into Raldoron's own.

'Who petitions for entrance? State your name, your rank, and your business.'

‘Raldoron, Archein, First Company of the Blood Angels Legion. I am here to interrogate our prisoners.’ Even with Arnovael’s heavy footsteps still booming back up the corridor, his voice seemed far too loud.

The skull’s head lowered once more.

The locks disengaged and the door swung silently inwards. The pressure differential between the two sections popped audibly and freezing air whistled around the door’s edges.

A single Space Marine stood on the far side. His armour was a glossy black. A fanged skull was painted around the eyes and snout of his helmet. In that mask his glowing red lenses made him otherworldly. He was a member of the Solavim, a secret Order of the First Sphere. Their skills were usually, and always had been, reserved for Blood Angels lost to the Thirst.

They made an exception in the case of the traitors.

‘Welcome, Archein, to the Precincts of Amareo.’

The prisoners were held in a single, long corridor, eight metres in width, dimly lit, the sides lined with heavy cell doors, a hundred and twelve in number. A scream, deadened by thick plasteel and thin air, haunted the way.

The guardian did not give his name, nor say anything else, as he escorted the Archein. Raldoron did not address him either. The Solavim were beyond the command of any, even Raldoron, who stood below only Sanguinius in authority. His duties were secret. His calling higher than war.

Raldoron saw that Laertes awaited him. The primus medicae remained as silent as the guardian, speaking only when he and Raldoron were face to face.

‘How goes the interrogation?’ Raldoron asked.

‘He will not talk,’ Laertes said. ‘I have applied the usual inducements.’

‘The traitors never talk,’ said Raldoron.

‘I have his name, at least,’ said Laertes. ‘Curdoth of the Fifth Great Company.’

‘From his wargear, I assume.’

Laertes nodded. ‘A name is something.’

‘What of the other captives?’

‘As resistant, and lower-ranking. If we are to learn anything, it will be from this one.’

‘Then let us be about it,’ said Raldoron.

‘Curdoth of the Fourteenth, welcome to the *Promissum Sanguinem*,’ Raldoron said.

The prisoner was chained to the wall, hands held wide apart and slightly higher than his shoulders. His plate had been stripped away, and though the Blood Angels had allowed him to retain the dignity of his bodyglove, it was torn from the removal of his armour and the subsequent struggle. His face was battered, one eye swollen shut, and the several cuts about his mouth and shoulders, already sealed with the thick scabbing of Larraman cells, were surrounded by extensive bruising.

‘Ah, the famed Raldoron,’ Curdoth replied. Lips puffed up by punches let out a string of drool tinged pink with blood. ‘I am honoured.’ He pulled a falsely puzzled expression. ‘Though I cannot tell if your welcome is sincere, or if you are mocking me. They say you have great skill with a blade, but little of wit. No sense of humour at all, as I heard it. On the other hand’ – he looked around his accommodation pointedly – ‘surely you cannot mean to be sincere.’

Raldoron stepped in front of him, and folded his arms. The weight of the war, the disappointment and the horror of it, the burden of command, all contrived to flock around him on dark, depressive wings. He hid his weariness under a mien of contempt.

‘Sincere or not, you will not be given the opportunity to report back to confirm or deny my supposed gifts with words,’ said Raldoron. ‘Tell me what I wish to know, and I shall at least offer you a clean death.’

Curdoth nodded. He understood he was going to die. They all expected no quarter, everyone who fought in that war. There are two great hates in the human heart: that spawned by broken love, and that spawned by broken loyalty.

‘I do not know why you have bothered to come here, or why you are keeping me alive. You know I will not tell you anything.’

‘I suppose you will not,’ said Raldoron.

‘And you will not convince me Horus is wrong, or that the Emperor is not a liar, if that is also your intention.’

‘No. But I would say there is a difference between withholding the whole of the truth and outright lying.’

‘Not from my point of view.’

‘I would have done the same in His position,’ said Raldoron. ‘I have seen what He was trying to protect us from. I have fought it. You are a fool to follow anyone who would court such powers.’

Curdoth looked aside a second. The amused expression dropped briefly, showing a tired man. ‘Maybe I would have hidden it too. That does not contradict the fact of his lying, nor does it excuse it. He should have told us.’

‘Horus is worse.’

‘He is certainly no better.’

‘Then why fight for Horus?’

‘You might as well ask me why not.’

There was something off about Curdoth. It took Raldoron a moment to place the familiar, yet elusive, sensation he got when he looked at the man, and then he realised with slight shock that Curdoth was ill. Only very seldom had he seen Space Marines afflicted by any kind of disease. Curdoth was not desperately sick, but he was unhealthy. He reminded Raldoron of one of the warriors from the Destroyer clades, exposed too often to the effects of the abhorrent weapons they bore. Rad-ravaged, or their constitutions worn down by virulent biologics. The Blood Angels tended to rotate their brethren through such duties. A lot of Legions did not, and the Death Guard were overly fond of such toxins. However, he did not think they were the cause of Curdoth’s ailments. He was simply ill. His milk-pale Barbaran skin was tinged red round his nostrils, his neural-input plugs and eyes, which were also shaded by purplish rings. There was a greenish pallor to his throat.

‘Then you will not talk.’

‘No.’

‘Not even if I offer to let you live?’

‘For what purpose? We are weapons, you and I. If you cannot turn a weapon to your use, then you destroy it in case it serves others. If I am not liberated by my comrades, the best I can hope for is a trial in some distant court, where I will be condemned to death anyway. I prefer not to wait.’

‘Then you have little faith in your brothers.’

‘They cannot take this ship. Even if they tried, you would kill me before they reached me.’

‘Your attack seems foolhardy,’ said Raldoron. ‘But it was not. You were trying to delay us, cripple this vessel, and hopefully kill me, and you were trying to do that because you have done your work upon One-Four-Seven-Gamma Minoris-Garmon. Your brothers are evacuating.’

Curdoth looked off to the side. ‘If that is your judgement of the situation, then so it must be. I bow before your superior wisdom.’

‘I will not allow them to escape.’

‘It is too late. We achieved our goal.’ Curdoth grinned, showing teeth browning with incipient decay. ‘Did you not see me burn your thralls, burn them up like tufts of dry grass? They screamed nicely, and though you live, your ship is crippled. You have lost this fight. We have destroyed this world. My brothers will escape, thanks to me.’

‘You will not escape.’

Curdoth shrugged disinterestedly. ‘I do not care. I came here to die. I have had it with this war. I made my oath of moment, and I fulfilled my mission.’

‘Your brothers will die. I will fall upon them with righteous fury. I give you my own oath of moment on that.’

Curdoth swung his head around to look Raldoron in the eyes.

‘You always were a tediously pompous Legion. All that art. All that angst. You think you are better than the rest of us. You are not. If you were, then Sanguinius would be the Warmaster, not Horus. Now, if you are done, why do you not kill me, and spare me more of your sanctimony?’

Raldoron nodded. ‘Very well. Laertes, leave us.’

Laertes bowed and left. The cell door shut. Raldoron approached Curdoth.

‘I do not fear death,’ the Death Guard said.

‘Even though you know what awaits you?’

The Death Guard sneered. ‘I embrace what awaits me.’

Raldoron drew back his hand.

‘Death to the false—’

The first blow hit Curdoth hard, snapping his head around. A few of his brown teeth flew free and clattered against the wall. Raldoron’s other fist descended, then the first again.

Methodically, brutally, Raldoron did not stop hitting Curdoth until he was dead.

By the time Raldoron was finished, Curdoth’s face was an oozing mess. The thick skull behind was cracked, though not sufficiently for Raldoron to

get at the brain, and he was obliged to draw his knife to open the man's head properly.

He sawed the bone, took the top off the skull, threw the removed crown upon the floor, and dug his fingers into the exposed meat.

The organ had a buttery, fatty texture. Such softness should not be able to hold the convoluted complexity of a man. The folds and valleys trapping the mind were so complex that Raldoron thought something so formed should have some give, but not so much. The appearance of the human brain made him imagine it, if he permitted himself the small indulgence of imagination, to feel upholstered. It should be smooth, but firm. It was not. He pushed his fingers into its mass easily, and the folds came apart. The seat of a man's soul, easily sundered with the scoop of one's fingers, and the marvels of the universe extracted from its casing as easily as the pulp of soft fruit.

He hesitated before he pushed the flesh past his lips. The meat smelled strange, the hint of a distant rot approaching. It was a distinct odour, and it evoked a peculiar feeling, reinforcing his earlier suspicion of sickness. The meat itself was not turning; it was more like he could smell corruption in some other place connected, somehow, to the organ. He sniffed at the brain more closely. He was right. The smell emanated not from it, but from somewhere else. It was definitely there in the room, like the smell of a spoiling corpse outside the window of a building. He scented the air. The taint was everywhere. Once more he sniffed the man's brain, but again, the smell did not come from there. Even so, he hesitated before he took his first bite.

He curled his lip and ate.

Back in the days of blood, he had consumed the flesh of his foes when needed, and had never minded the taste, yet nor had it excited him. There were those who had relished human meat, and they were the ones who fought the most like beasts. There were those who had been disgusted by the idea, even as the Thirst made them force more flesh, more blood, into their mouths. To Raldoron, the Rite of Flesh was neither a pleasure nor a sin, simply a tool, another way to achieve his objectives, another aspect of the Emperor's many gifts to the Legions. He had been mocked for his lack of emotion in the past. But in circumstances like these he found it useful to feel little. When the pyre of the Imperium burned hot, those who relished

flesh went mad. Those who despised it fell into despair. Calmness precluded both.

He felt the stirrings of the Thirst. The Thirst called for blood. Flesh would do to excite it. It wriggled around in his gut, a yearning thing.

He crushed it dispassionately.

Best to be neutral in all things. Best to be calm. The tranquil angel had earned his name by his restraint.

Raldoron chewed. The brain matter melted in his mouth. He swallowed. He felt his omophagea awaken as a growing warmth between stomach and spine.

Memory is a slippery thing. Raldoron had no idea how the omophagea functioned, but it did work.

The first flashes were unsure, little flickers of the civil war, but if recent or from the trauma of the beginning he could not say. This legionary, this Curdoth, marched boltgun blazing, one man in a line of men massacring what appeared to be civilians. Curdoth's mind was blank. Raldoron felt what Curdoth had felt, and that was precisely nothing. He had been told to kill, and so he killed.

The memory faded. He licked more of the matter from his fingers.

Another memory. Curdoth was angry; he argued with his brothers. They wore armour battered by heavy campaigning, mud in every seam, dents and scratches all over their livery. Although the argument was conducted in Barbaran, thanks to his intimate connection with Curdoth, Raldoron understood.

This was the conversation that had led to treachery.

It interested him that Curdoth was opposed to the war to begin with. He wondered what had changed.

He licked his fingers clean of every last iota of experience. In the cold air, the brains had already chilled. Comprehension eluded him. Raldoron experienced a jumble of images and noises, most so fragmentary he could not comprehend them before they were gone. Only one, of Curdoth laughing with his comrades, all of whom appeared haler and healthier than they did now, was clear at all, and that faded quickly into melancholy.

Stolidly, still all too aware of the pervasive but untraceable smell, he scooped out more of Curdoth's brain. The bowl of his emptying skull showed pinkly white. Memory did not reside solely in the brain but

permeated the body in some mysterious way, and so he would devour Curdoth's entire head, and keep going if he must, until he learned what he needed to know.

He endured this grim feast for two hours. When he stood, heavy with his gorging, Curdoth's bloodied skull rested on the floor, and he hung from the left wrist alone. Raldoron had consumed most of the traitor's right shoulder and arm.

'Laertes,' he said. His voice was dulled by gluttony, his mouth ripe with blood, his breath iron-tainted. When the primus medicae did not respond, he roused himself to greater volume. 'Laertes!'

The door to the cell hissed into the ceiling. Laertes entered. He spared no more than a glance at the decapitated, gnawed Space Marine. His gaze travelled the fleshless, gory arm, paused on the curled talons of Curdoth's finger bones, still held in place by tattered ligaments, before coming to rest upon Raldoron's blood-smeared face.

'You learned what you needed, my lord Archein?'

'There are no more than three companies of the Death Guard on the planet. Their Auxilia are the real fighting force. It is as we thought. We outnumber them absolutely. This attack was designed to delay us so they might evacuate. I shall call a war council immediately. If we are swift, we shall annihilate them completely, human and transhuman.'

'What of the rest of the prisoners?'

Raldoron pushed past the Apothecary, trying to stay steady. He was blood drunk, and did not wish to show it. 'We have no more need of them. Deal with them as you will.'

Laertes' expression remained entirely collected as he spoke.

'Then we shall push the treacherous scum out of an airlock. Let us see how well the legendary resilience of the Fourteenth Legion serves them against hard vacuum.'

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

TORTURED SKIES

‘Time to target?’ Raldoron asked the Stormbird pilot.

‘Four hours under predicted conditions, Archein.’

‘Understood. Second task force?’

‘On schedule to begin their landing.’

Raldoron stood in the cockpit, looking out into space. The Stormbird winged its way arrow-swift, a raptor of the void, as 147-Gamma Minoris-Garmon swelled fast before them. With his flagship damaged and the fleet’s advance slowed by the hours of battle, he had ordered his warriors into their lightest and fastest craft. Two groups, the Saiphani ahead, legionaries twenty minutes behind. Flights of gunships, interceptors and destroyers held tight formation with drop-ships. They approached from the far side of the world, away from its warzones and evacuation point. Though whether they had already been detected mattered little. They would be, eventually. It was a risky gambit, sending such fragile vessels out alone, but Raldoron saw no enemy ships.

He looked to the small chart table at the back of the cockpit and examined his goal. Three light cruisers were all that remained to the Death Guard over the planet – enough, he guessed, for them to extract their men, and quick enough to allow them to make their escape before the Blood Angels warships could catch them. The vessels that had survived the attack on the *Promissum Sanguinem* had scattered, and the rest of their fleet was

doubtless already fleeing, but they had sacrificed much to slow him down. There was satisfaction to be had in that.

Raldoron's goals were therefore pleasantly simple. The Auxilia would trap the Death Guard on the surface, his attack craft would harass the cruisers and shoot down their shuttlecraft and landers. The enemy ships would not hold position long enough for the Blood Angels' capital ships to arrive. So, if he could prevent the Death Guard from getting their men into orbit, he would force the cruisers to abandon them, then destroy them on the ground.

To effect their escape, the Death Guard were doing what he expected. They had concentrated their forces in one area for the most rapid extraction. If he were in their place, he would ring the extraction zone with Auxilia, sacrificing enough men to slow the Blood Angels' assault. His response to that was sending the 46th in to engage, thus pinning the defence forces in place. Once battle commenced, he planned to land the Blood Angels in the centre of the extraction zone, catching the Death Guard in disarray, leaving the auxiliaries supporting them in battle with the Saiphan Elevatii and unable to turn inwards in support.

The savagery of the Angforia would serve well in that regard. For their landing zone he had earmarked a place right in the middle.

He watched the globe. Storms roiled around it from top to bottom, spirals of agonised, dark, discoloured cloud lit by spreads of lightning. The living world of blues and gentle greens was gone; neither mountain, icecap nor ocean could be seen. He had been surprised in the past when, after particularly bloody compliances, Imperial surveyors had told him a planet would recover. He expressed his doubts once, and had been given a short lesson by an animated planetologist on the resilience of living worlds, and the reassurance that even badly wounded examples would heal given time.

Raldoron did not think 147-Gamma Minoris-Garmon fit into that category.

'They have killed this planet,' he said to himself.

The waste of it disgusted him. There was no strategic reason for such blatant overkill. Horus' warriors had denied the Imperium... what? A few hundred shiploads of grain a year? It was nothing. Evidence that Horus did not truly wish to rule in the stead of his father, but had far darker motives.

'He will have nought but an empire of ashes.'

His murmurs caught the pilot's attention. 'My lord?'

‘Nothing. Signal me fifteen minutes ahead of Almazi’s landing. I am going below.’

‘Yes, Archein.’

Raldoron turned his back upon the planet’s corpse, and went to join his men.

In the second task force, Assan tried and failed to rest in the restraint cradle of the lander. Every battle was preceded by fear that filled him with a terrible, nervous energy. He could not sleep or eat in those hours, but sat jittery and unfocused, caught between the terror of death on the one hand and dishonour on the other.

The engines were running hot, the noise of overtaxed machinery making conversation all but impossible. The Saiphan Elevatii pushed ahead of the Space Marines to make their attack. At the beginning of the flight he and his command cadre had swapped stories and jibes over their vox-net, but the engine noise had become so great, and the discomfort of constant acceleration, though deliberately gradual, had pushed at them so mercilessly, that even the clipped conversation they shared had become laborious, and one by one his men became silent. Several slept, Qaziz included.

The mission ahead would be hard. They had lost many men already, and without the camaraderie of his troops to distract him, his mind wandered into dark places.

He tried not to think of the scant escort the landing force had.

He tried not to think of Raldoron’s chilling, merciless pragmatism.

‘I was given a choice,’ the Archein had told the officers picked to lead the attack. ‘It was not an easy one, and both decisions offer the certainty of loss. We either risk ourselves, grabbing with both hands the opportunity to slaughter the foe, or we hang back, lose the men on this world we have come to save, and allow our enemy to escape.’

Raldoron was not himself. The Archein seemed as collected as always, Assan thought, but the Space Marine was coldly furious where usually he was calm. Assan was not alone in noticing it.

‘I have chosen the path of vengeance. We shall bring a day of revelation upon the heads of our foe, and show them the errors of treachery.’

The 46th flew in their landers directly for the fight. A voyage of that length in landing craft was unusual. The landers were not designed for combat, and usually entered a warzone protected by cruisers. Raldoron was gambling on the enemy being too occupied with extracting their forces from the world to move in to intercept them.

Raldoron was rarely wrong. But it was a genuine gamble. One capital ship could pick off the fleet of light craft at its leisure.

The quieter hiss of manoeuvring jets crept under the racket. The main engines cut out. Assan felt the lander rotating, presenting its rear to the planet. The vessel rattled.

A green light blinked in his helm.

‘That’s it, we’re close,’ he told the others.

‘Prepare for a little lover’s squeeze, my boys,’ Lazareen said breezily. A couple of the others laughed.

Qaziz woke up with a start. ‘Already?’

‘Nearly there, cousin,’ Assan said, clapping him on the shoulder. ‘Hard deceleration, then we’ll finish braking round the planet.’

‘These lightning combat insertions don’t agree with me.’

‘Think of it as a desert raid, riders striking from the night.’

‘I wish I could take a proper piss, I’ve been in this suit for a day and a half.’

‘We all have, Qaziz,’ Mesen said, no less irritable than the voxman. ‘Shut your whining.’

The green light blinked fast in Assan’s helmet. A counter ticked down next to his face.

‘Hard burn in five... four... three...’

‘They don’t like to warn us, do they?’ said Mesen.

‘Who’s whining now?’ Qaziz responded.

The thunder of the main drive cut off any reply Mesen might have made.

The deceleration was as rapid as the acceleration had been slow. Gravitic forces shoved at each man, cruel as a heavy fist grinding an insect into a stone. The weight of it was something Assan could never get used to; it seemed to go on forever, and it pushed him to the brink of unconsciousness. The vox was full of the grunts of men struggling to breathe.

As soon as it began, it ceased. The main engines cut out, and the thrusters fired to reorient the vessel. The rotation of the craft was barely felt against

the pull of grav-plating. Then silence. They coasted in the frictionless void. The main engines would not burn again until they were coming in to land.

‘All ready, sound off!’ Assan said, trying to bully the words out of his croaking voice. Black spots pulsed in his vision, dying now, but taunting him that next time they would be waiting to pull him into unconsciousness and shame him in front of his men.

His men shouted out their names. Those who had been rendered insensible were awoken with quick jabs from disposable stimm-sticks, the needles poked through medical grommets in their void suits.

Together, whether grumbling, groggy, light-hearted or afraid, the men of the 46th Saiphan Elevatii prepared to fight.

Assan enjoyed fifteen minutes of quiet, during which time he thought mostly that he agreed with Qaziz – he would really like to be able to piss somewhere other than in his suit’s waste pocket.

He felt the first bump of atmosphere moments before the primary pilot signalled him with a dry message.

‘Captain, we are going in. Enemy presence low. Atmospheric conditions decidedly poor. This is going to be uncomfortable.’

The pilot severed the connection. The ship vibrated. They were entering the outermost layers of the planet’s gas envelope.

‘Hold tight, warriors of Saiph!’ Assan voxed. ‘I am advised by our pilots that this will be unpleasant.’

‘Aye, and with a fight at the end of it!’ Qaziz shouted.

‘I’d rather have the fight than the re-entry,’ Porios grumbled.

‘The sky will bounce you, sure enough, but the enemy has guns, my friend,’ Lazareen said.

‘Yeah, but I’ve got a gun too. Down there I can fire back. I’ve no control over my fate in this box. I hate it.’

The others laughed at Porios’ surliness, but held tight just the same. And although they began to sing the *Fall of Antropaz*, that much-famed ballad of Saiph, the first hard jounce choked it off. They took up the song again hesitantly, then a second plummet silenced them. Another bounce, then another, coming close together. As a child, Assan had been told the motion of a ship coming into an atmosphere was comparable to that of a stone skipped across still waters. It was a tried-and-tested method of safe

deceleration, millennia old, only his tutors had been glossing over the truth a little – the waters were not still, and it felt far from safe.

Another bounce. Someone, somewhere, was praying to the old gods.

Conversation became impossible after that. The last skip was subdued; like the analogous stone, they were sinking. Calm, then a sudden plummet as the unforgiving skips of atmospheric penetration gave way to worse turbulence. Screaming winds gripped the lander. The craft bucked like a wild thing to escape their claws. Pockets of less dense air opened like pits before the ship, causing it to plunge with gut-dropping suddenness. Alarms wailed in panicked competition with the howl of the engines. Men were moaning. Assan screwed his eyes shut. Every jerk and bump slammed him into the restraints. He would be bruised, come the evening.

If he survived.

Ordinarily, the harsh treatment meted out by the upper atmosphere diminished once they were into the lower layers, the lander's atmospheric jets engaged, and the flight path smoothed out. Not this time. The ship was lashed by a frenzy of winds so fierce Assan could not tell if they were targeted by the enemy or not. If they were, any hits they scored on the craft's armour were indistinguishable from the pummelling of the storms. At one point the lander veered sharply to the left and dived, an action of the pilots, he thought, and not the weather. He could not tell if it was to avoid flak bursts or simply to course correct.

Shortly after that, ready lights pulsed on the ceiling, illuminating the six rows of men in the transit compartment with bloody urgency.

'Combat landing in two minutes. Advisory, captain, it's rough down there.'

The ship stabilised enough that he might risk standing. With his thumbs, he depressed the two buttons that released the padded cradle, shoved it up, and got to his feet.

'Fourteenth Company tercios!' he yelled. 'Ready, ready, ready!'

A klaxon blatted.

The craft swerved, definitely a deliberate roll this time. There was an intermittent rattling on the hull, and the muffled sound of explosions. Hard-shot flak. He prayed their foe lacked more sophisticated anti-air weaponry.

'Landing, one minute thirty.'

The tempo of the klaxon and the lights changed.

‘Up! Up!’ Sergeants and primes moved down the lines of men, slapping shoulders. ‘Up! Up, for the Emperor, for Sanguinius, get up!’

Men swayed against the movement of the drop-ship. They steadied themselves by gripping the tubing of the restraint cradles.

‘Thirty seconds.’

Engines roared. The ship slowed. There were impacts on the hull.

The ready lights burned steady. Green lights came on alongside the red. The red lights went out. Men braced.

The 46th Saiphan did not, as a rule, drop directly into a combat zone, but deployed from beachheads and travelled overland to the front. Seizing and securing landing sites was the role of more specialised Auxilia drop regiments, or the Legiones Astartes themselves. They had the speed and the resilience the 46th lacked.

When they did deploy directly into combat, doctrine stated all troops should remain in their cradles until they landed. Doctrine had seen too many dead. As soon as they touched down, the ships were sitting targets. The longer they were on the ground, the more likely they would burn. Nobody wanted that. So they stood, dropping their weight into their knees, slinging their rifles over their left arms, and steadied the man to the front with their right hands. In each of the three aisles of the drop-ship, files of men braced.

The landing came abruptly. A roar of engines, a sudden slowing that pushed the lines of men forward, a soft slam of landing claws into yielding earth that rocked them back, a short skid, and then the ship’s ramp slammed down, giving the transit hold a wide smile of daylight. The first thing Assan thought was that it was dim, even though they should be on the planet’s dayside, close to noon.

‘Go! Go! Go! Go!’

Men ran. At first it was quiet outside. Explosions found the drop-ship soon enough.

When Assan’s turn came to run down the ramp, flanked by his command and guardian squads, he was greeted by clods of flying earth. A hard lump of it clipped his shoulder, smearing his void suit.

There was an explosion nearby, and another, then another, throwing up geysers of soil.

The enemy were shelling the landing zone. The barrage was poorly targeted, and loosely spread, but zeroing in.

‘Forward, men!’ he yelled.

‘Go! Go! Go!’ the squad sergeants yelled behind him. Gunfire crackled distantly.

His men fanned out rapidly into a ruined landscape.

They had been deposited in a wasteland. Broken earth stretched in every direction. There were hedges, but every tree was dead. The few leaves that clung to their branches were a withered brown. There was precious little sign of other life. Where the land was not churned up, it was coated in a thickish ooze. Some form of life-eater virus had been deployed here, he thought. Not one of the potent ones, or maybe not in volume, because in those circumstances the atmosphere became so filled with methane it was apt to ignite. Even so, whatever had been used here was enough to ensure everything was dead.

The sky was in torment, a boiling lid of black-and-purple clouds veined with lightning. It was not raining, but the ground was sodden. The clays of it, surely fertile soil before, sucked at their feet. A thick and sickly mist clung to the ground.

Their empty lander cycled up its engines and lifted off in haste. The exhaust plumes of its jets lengthened into spikes of orange fire that faded into blue. They cut into a tree, setting it on fire. It burned with strange colours, the residues of the chemicals that had killed it.

Ships came screaming down and lifted off in a hurry. He checked his cartolith. Other elements of the regiment were landing as intended across a sickle-shaped front ten kilometres wide. The enemy were a couple of kilometres away. The large shapes of the enemy’s light cruisers hung above the horizon.

‘Status?’ he commanded. The vox-net functioned well enough, though the pain of the world’s magnetosphere made itself known in shushing interference and sinister whoops.

‘All our tercios are down,’ Qaziz said.

‘Then let’s find some cover, get the company organised, and advance. Porios, find me a—’

Four Xiphon interceptors screamed overhead, drowning out Assan’s voice. He started again.

‘Find me some cover.’

‘There’s an agricola complex two hundred metres out,’ Porios informed him. ‘Hard to see in this shit, but it’s there.’

‘Then let’s go,’ Assan shouted over the growl of tank engines as a squadron of Leman Russes rolled down a landing craft’s debarkation ramp. Churning mud and venting grey exhaust, the tanks pulled away into the confusion of hedges, explosions and fog, where they lost themselves quickly.

Assan motioned his squad forward. ‘Send rendezvous coordinates, and spread the word.’

A shell hit one of the drop-ships labouring into the sky. The energy sheath around it flared and spat, and though the ship took enough kinetic overspill to jolt it, and its wing touched the ground and carved a slow trench in the earth, it recovered, righted itself with a jet burn so loud it made Assan’s ears hurt, and crawled back up into the boiling heavens to make its escape.

‘Come on! Move out!’ he yelled, slapping Qaziz’s back as if he alone were responsible for the speed of their advance.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

BROTHERS IN ARMS

Assan's Tercio Beta approached the barns of the agricola complex. First, groups took positions to watch the major doorways. Then others entered the buildings in groups of two and three, covering each other. They ghosted between rusting farm vehicles, their tyres flat and bodywork punctured with bullet holes.

He listened to the clipped calls of his men as they entered outbuilding after outbuilding. The complex was big – over three hectares of barns, silos and machine sheds. But the buildings were large and, as far as they could tell, largely empty, so he expected his men to be through quickly.

'First waymark reached, captain.' Trinas Nin, the troopmaster of Tercio Beta, reported in. Reception was good at that range, boosted by the electronic gain of Qaziz's vox interlock.

'Tercio Alpha, proceed to second waymark. Tercio Gamma, secure perimeter.'

Acknowledgement of his orders came in. A few minutes passed. Nothing happened. His men were far into the complex now, and vox interference grew.

There was a sudden las shot, then shouting over the vox.

'Report,' Assan asked.

Nothing.

'Qaziz, who was that?'

‘First rifle section, Tercio Alpha.’

‘Get them on the vox.’

‘I’m trying, sir,’ said his cousin.

The vox blared, then Sergeant Mufazzak was speaking into his ears.

‘Friendlies, sir, we have friendly units. Please advise.’

‘Give position, hold. I’m coming in,’ Assan said. ‘Command tercio, on me.’

The Gallian Irregulars weren’t much to look at. They were dirty for a start, and their equipment so thoroughly abused that each one of them looked like they’d been roughed up by a mob armed with hammers. The name, too, hardly evoked a glorious roll of honour. But as their leader explained to Assan, they were all that was left. A scratch force comprised of surviving Imperial Army, planetary militia, even armed civilians, with a few members of the Solar Auxilia mixed in for good measure.

‘We scavenge what we can, and we use what works,’ Captain Bardovar explained on the way up the silo. ‘So we don’t look pretty, but we’re like mountains worn by the rain – only the toughest rocks are left.’ He grinned. Several of his teeth were broken, and his face was filthy, with a semi-permanent indent around his mouth from a rebreather that was currently perched upon his head. ‘What? I went to scholam. Just because we’re farmers, it does not mean we have no education.’

The stairs creaked worryingly under their feet. They were on the outside and had no guard rail. Inside the conical hopper, five thousand tonnes of grain was quietly mouldering away, the last harvest this world would see. They took one last turn in the stairs and reached a platform running around the top.

‘There we are. This is the best vantage point. Make the most of it, because they’ll shell it as soon as they realise we’re up here. They would have already, if they weren’t so busy with you boys.’

Forty metres above the agricola complex, Assan could see a long way. The mist was clearing a little. Though the clouds still raced, there was only a light breeze at ground level. The roofs of the barns and sheds below were full of holes. One at the eastern edge had collapsed completely. Twisted plasteel beams, blackened by fire, poked at the sky. Otherwise, it was remarkably whole.

‘They don’t bother pursuing a course of ruination any more,’ Bardovar explained, as if catching Assan’s thoughts. ‘This lot started by destroying everything they could, and they had a good try, but we’ve got them on the run. There’ll be a little left, once they’re dead. Damn traitors.’ He spat over the side, as if warding off evil.

Assan played his magnoculars over the landscape. The cruisers of the Death Guard were fixed to the sky about eight kilometres away. Ships shuttled constantly up and down to the ground.

‘Got them on the run. They thought they’d finish us, but they weren’t the first unwelcome guests we’ve dealt with.’

Throughout Assan’s reconnoitre, Bardovar kept up a similar commentary, and Assan realised the man’s sanity hung by a thread. Hardly surprising, he thought. He tried to shut out Bardovar’s monologue, to concentrate on what he could see through his magnoculars.

The Death Guard’s auxiliaries, the Bleak Marchers, were ranged in a perimeter around the extraction site. A network of trenches and bunkers faced out into the murk. Already, lead elements of Saiphan armour were engaging.

‘That cordon’s full of holes,’ Bardovar said. ‘They lost a lot of men on the equator. Bastards stripped the jungles bare. You should have seen the poisons they sprayed on us. The ones that did that are still out there, somewhere. It’s going to take a while to rid ourselves of them. I reckon only half their remaining number is here today, no more. The rest are scattered planetwide. I don’t think it’s enough to stop us. Not now you’re here.’ He slapped Assan on his shoulder. ‘Eh?’

‘Are you willing to submit yourselves to my command?’ Assan asked.

Bardovar’s friendly nature shifted. ‘No. We fight under our own. Too used to it by now. But we’ll fight alongside you, for sure.’

‘Very well,’ said Assan. ‘Any recommendations on the weakest spot of the trench lines? We want to punch through, disrupt the evacuation as much as possible, draw attention to ourselves and keep them pinned while the rest of our fleet closes in. We’re an advance party. There are others coming.’

‘What about them?’ Bardovar flicked his eyes skyward to the cruisers.

‘Let our masters worry about the enemy ships. We have our role to play down here. Now, weak spots, or shall I choose our plan of attack myself?’

‘Over there. The soil is shallow in that part. Hard rock beneath, wasn’t ever ploughed. There are no trenches there. They’ve barricades, not much else. A hard push will knock them right over.’

Assan narrowed his eyes against the diffuse, painful light filtering through the mist. He could just about see what Bardovar meant. Ad hoc defence lines made of scavenged sheeting and farm machinery. Then Assan spotted squat shapes behind – several Malcador heavy tanks and, though he could not be sure, what looked like a Valdor tank destroyer.

‘They’ve got tanks.’

‘Don’t you?’ Bardovar said.

‘We do,’ said Assan. ‘And air support.’

‘Then no problem,’ said Bardovar, and grinned his broken-toothed grin.

Raldoron looked down from the Stormbird at the ravaged world. They were running exo-atmospheric, where the border between attenuated gases and true void is impossible to define. There was one advantage to the damage the enemy had done – the energy unleashed by planetary murder made any sort of auspex or augury readings nigh on impossible, and so it was that Raldoron’s small task force still flew unseen, even as their ship’s bellies kissed the atmosphere, towards the enemy fleet.

‘The Forty-Sixth are on the ground and beginning operations, my lord,’ the ship’s communications officer told him.

The plan was made, now to action.

‘Patch me through to the long-range vox, task-force wide.’

‘It is done, Archein.’

‘All fleet, all fleet,’ Raldoron said. ‘Commence attack. Repeat, begin drop runs now.’

The enemy would have heard that, if they still had not seen the Blood Angels approaching. But as the Cobra destroyers, heavy bombers, and their fighter escorts pulled ahead of the troop landers on their attack runs, Raldoron was confident it was far too late for them to do anything about it.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

DAY OF REVELATION

Assan gathered the forces he deemed necessary to break the weak spot in the enemy line. Two squadrons of Leman Russ assault tanks and a heavier Malcador to back them up. An exchange of cannon fire commenced between the line and the 46th's positions, enough to keep the enemy from sallying out to meet them. They'd have been idiots to try, Assan thought; they were heavily outnumbered. But he wasn't making any assumptions.

In the short time it took Assan to rally his troops and advance, the world became more violent still. The battlefield expanded from ground combat into the air, where every stratum of three-dimensional space was filled with war. At the highest level, outside the atmosphere, torpedoes burned ahead of the attacking destroyers. Flights of smaller one-man fighters and two-man bombers escorted them home, ready to exploit weakened void shields with their own armaments. The cruisers opened fire in return, and the upper airs were filled with energy beams and tracer fire.

When all was ready, Qaziz called in an airstrike. As the torpedoes hit the leading cruiser's shields, and ugly mauve light spilled into the tortured skies, Thunderbolt heavy fighters in Blood Angels colours roared in low over Assan's positions. Anti-aircraft fire stabbed up into the sky, but it was scattered and ineffectual. The Thunderbolts tilted their wings lazily to avoid the gunfire, and launched their Hellstrike missiles. Four detonations marked hits, and hopefully, the destruction of the enemy armour, especially the

worrying might of the Valdor. The Thunderbolts raced off, the sound of their autocannons strafing the extraction zone beyond diminishing to an excited avian chatter.

Porios set to work with his auspex equipment. Qaziz sought confirmation of artillery support. Assan looked to Qaziz. His friend shook his head. Not yet, not yet. A shell landed in the yard of the agricola. Earth and rockcrete fragments clattered off the corrugated plasteel roofs of the barns.

A light flashed in his helm. Qaziz held up a finger.

‘Rear line confirms artillery strike ready. Company vox is open, captain.’

‘Move!’ Assan yelled. ‘Move! Move! Move!’ The single, repeated word was carried to all elements of his company and its supporting assets, the tank tercio, the Malcador, his own company, the Gallian Irregulars. Engines rumbled. A whistling of shells passed overhead, and a thousand men rose up from their hiding places, filling the yard from nowhere like revenants rising en masse from their graves.

Explosions crumped ahead. Bursts of soil erupted skyward. Sheets of metal wheeled through the air. There would be broken flesh mixed in with that. The tanks moved in a broad spread off the hardstanding into the fields, wallowing but never foundering in the poisoned, muddy earth. Their guns boomed as they advanced.

‘Fall in behind the armour,’ Assan ordered. His voice seemed trapped in his helm. The outside world was a confusion of competing explosions, but they heard, and they obeyed. His men fell into columns, each one marching in the lee of the tanks. They went with their bayonets fixed and ready.

Nearing the line, the tanks opened up with their lighter armaments. Lascannons burned thick cobalt beams through the fog. Heavy bolters spoke with the mechanical voices of manufactory machines, their only product death.

Visibility was poor. Smoke washed from fresh shell holes. The bombardment was imprecise, ranged by eye, hoping by luck to smash as many of the enemy as possible by creeping forward.

A shell whizzed by him a bare metre away. It struck the agricola with a hollow bang, then a boom. Deadly shrapnel sliced the air. There were cries from further back in the column.

Assan did not look. He kept a steady, determined pace. His men matched his tempo boldly, all of them bravely ignoring the possibility of death,

moving well, though mud sucked at their boots and cannon fire racked the world around them.

The Leman Russ tanks were turning to the right, their turrets tracking a target he could neither see nor his squad's auspex detect. The guns fired together, three battle cannons booming thunder. The backwash of exhaust expelled from their muzzle vents was palpably hot.

In reply, there were explosions close by. The first ruby and blue beams of lasrifles flicked through the murk, colourful streamers to welcome estranged brothers.

The tanks corrected course, turrets remaining locked on to whatever they were firing at while their hulls rotated beneath. One fired.

This time, they were answered.

A fat, horizontal beam of collimated light stabbed out. Assan's eyes stung; the beam was almost white, bright, as merciless as the light of fierce blue stars. The passage of it superheated the air, torturing it to emit a tremendous thunderclap. He saw – or rather he had an impression of – one of the Leman Russes in silhouette, transfixed by a glaring, murderous spear. The unbelievably cruel light punched through the front glacis as if it were made of shadow, running right through and out the back of the tank. He perceived this as a still image, pieces of debris lifted up from the engine block frozen in flight.

He had presence of mind enough to open his mouth to stop his lungs bursting from the overpressure.

The tank detonated with an almighty roar, all its shells, all its fuel, all its powercells exploding together. The shockwave punched him with a giant's force, lifting him off the ground. All the air went from him. Something deadlier still clanged from his helm. He fell. So inconveniently yielding before, the ground now contrived to turn hard as stone.

He lay stunned, ears ringing. Blood trickled from his nose. With a blast hit that strong, he might be dead already. He waited for pulverised organs to spread their insidious agonies through his belly.

But his heart had not collapsed, and his lungs responded when he commanded them to draw in breath. His guts remained free of the cold fire of rupture. He felt relief, interrupted by a hand on his arm, tugging him up.

'Cousin, are you injured? Cousin!'

'Bruised only.'

Qaziz pulled Assan to his feet. The Leman Russ' shattered hulk burned merrily twenty metres away, its position marked by a high column of thick smoke bent into a curve by the wind. His men were hunkered down, exchanging shots with the Traitor Solar Auxilia. The remaining tanks were falling back, still firing at the tank hunter. Another beam of the awful light scored the day. Assan blinked, still suffering after-images from the first shot. The fog of war was thinning out again now the creeping barrage had advanced away from them. More bright fires and more columns of smoke burned behind the enemy's line a hundred metres ahead.

The rest of their armour was wrecked, he was relieved to see. All but the Valdor, which hunkered behind a berm of earth half-demolished by the Hellfire hit, the tank still hale, squat and threatening, the long snout of its neutron laser tracking round to follow the loyalist tanks. The dance of armour was in full flow, the slow, deadly gavotte one tank performed with another. Involved in their game, they ignored the infantry.

Assan shook his head. His senses were scrambled. Bright bands branded his retina, and there was ringing in his ears. A las beam cracked the air. He and Qaziz dropped, then ran crouched to join the rest of the squad in a shell crater.

He had the squads of his command tercio sound off. One casualty: a Veletarii named Gluvil, shredded by the tank blast. His troopmasters and sergeants from the other tercios reported in. That news was not so good. There were twenty dead, at least.

'That Valdor has to go,' Assan said. 'Without the tanks to break the defence line, we're going to get pinned down here. Qaziz, get all squads on line. We have to move fast.'

Roaring. The roaring of dragons. The roaring of guns. The roaring of rage.

It is the roaring of engines, Simeon told himself. Nothing but the roaring of engines!

Within his helm his jaw clenched. His teeth ground. He did not hear the noise as engines. He could not, no matter how hard he tried. To him it was the roar of the Thirst. He could not tease the thunder of his pulse apart from the engines, so therefore they must be the same, and the engines thirsted, just as he did. The whole galaxy was howling for blood. The noise pounded in Simeon's head, in his limbs. His hands twitched with it. It had been

building ever since they had departed the fleet, locked into the belly of a Thunderhawk two days before, forty of the Angforia left to stew in their own psychic fug. He had tried to fight it, but battle called, and with that came the insistent cry of blood. Shut into their armour, he and his men retreated into themselves.

To start with, he had focused on the techniques the veterans had taught him. But the lessons he had been given meant nothing. What were words against madness? After Raldoron's lesson there had been lectures; there had been more sparring so they might call up the Thirst, then control it; there had been meditative restorations of their armour. Sessions in the workshops had fulfilled at least one purpose – their wargear now gleamed. But in the chief respect it had failed. They had no peace. Their souls were as tarnished as ever.

Space Marines thrashed and moaned restively in their crash harnesses.

Be calm, Simeon told himself. He forced his jaws apart. He relaxed his muscles. His teeth were spikes of bone, not his, alien to him, hard, puncturing weapons that yearned to be used. He wanted to bite. *Be calm, like Raldoron*, he told himself. *Be calm, like the tranquil angel*.

He found no tranquillity. Anticipating combat, his altered genes responded. He was concentrating so hard on the control inevitably slipping from him that he did not notice the Thunderhawk's pilot announce the start of their landing run, nor, a few moments later, when they entered the planet's atmosphere with a bruising thump. The ship shook all the way down, and at the bottom of its swift, curved flight path, it came under fire. Twice it was hit.

Simeon noticed none of this.

All he could hear was the roar of blood in his ears.

'Come at it from the left! Squad Eta, move! You're in its line of fire!'

Assan had no idea if his men heard. He was in a shell hole, directing the advance as lumps of earth and shrapnel rained down on him from every side, his helm welded to his magnoculars. The Valdor swivelled, tracks turning in opposite directions, churning the already muddy ground to a slurry. Heavy bolter fire chattered from its single sponson mount, sending streaks of hard rounds after Squad Eta. A straggler was caught and felled;

the rest ducked under the line of its neutron laser. It did not fire, and then they were clear.

The sponson was on the right-hand side of the tank. The lack of a matching partner on the left was the Valdor's greatest weakness. Infantry could assault from the tank's uncovered side and overpower it with grenades, which was precisely Assan's plan once the tank destroyer's supporting squads were dealt with. The tanks shelled the Valdor from further back, covered by folds in terrain, constant repositioning, and the smoke pouring from their wrecked squadron mate. The Valdor's attention was occupied by the Saiphan Leman Russes. That gave men on foot an opening.

Meanwhile, his men marched upon the trench line in tight ranks, guns volleying. The tercios advanced in classic style, one squad stopping to shoot, covering their brother squads as they made ground. They maintained close formation though the air between the Saiphan Elevatii and the Bleak Marchers was rodded by beams of blue las light. Men fell on both sides. The tercio relied on thick void armour to preserve its men. It was close-packed, slow, vulnerable to artillery fire, but it worked. There were few infantry formations that could project as much firepower forward.

'The enemy are locked down, Adjutant Phaazid – your advance, please,' Assan voxed.

A little off to the right, Phaazid's squad of Veletarii finished working their way forward unseen. With a shout in west-desert Saiphani they rose up and unleashed their volkite chargers at close range.

The battlefield became unbearably bright with the jagged ribbons of volkite fire. Phaazid's men broke into a run, firing from the hip. Howling energy streams punched holes in the barricades, incinerating the men behind.

'Demolition team, go,' Assan commanded.

The neutron laser fired again, its thunderclap report setting ears ringing and flattening lungs. Assan frantically blinked after-images away in time to see a five-man squad of Saiphan combat engineers run behind the advancing tercios, coming at the Valdor's vulnerable left. The infantry at the barricades did not see this threat. They were blinded and pinned by the general advance, and dying at a rate far greater than Assan's own men.

When the engineers were close to the tank, the top hatch flipped open, and a crewman clambered up, grabbing the vehicle's pintle-mounted multi-laser and swivelling it around.

'Squad One, deal with that,' Assan commanded.

Twenty lasrifle beams transected the crewman, so many they set his body ablaze. He died without firing a single shot.

Desperately, the tank ground about to face them, the burning crewman lolling in the top hatch. A shell from the loyalist back line exploded from its side. The engineers quickened their pace. At five metres they tossed shaped charges the size of refectorium plates at its side. Through the magnoculars, Assan saw one bounce off. The other three locked in place. He imagined more than heard the heavy clang of metal kissing metal.

The engineers had enough time to hit the ground before the charges blew with dull, sullen noises, like bells dropped on paving. The Valdor stopped, smoke erupting from every port and aperture.

A cheer went up. The Veletarii were over the barricade. The las-rifle sections following them broke into a run, leaping defence lines and bayoneting the few surviving enemy.

'Advance! Advance!' Assan called, standing from his shell hole, and waving at his men. A second line of the 14th Company rose up from the shelter of churned earth, and followed their captain at double time.

For a few brief, glorious moments, Assan exulted in success.

There was something ahead, moving through the smoke. Small tracked vehicles. He registered the dull, grouped thumps of quad-launchers in time to utter a pointless warning.

'Get down!'

Shells on a shallow trajectory slammed into the earth, and spilled living fire among the Saiphani.

Phosphex leaped from each shattered casing, burning white limbs seeming to actively seek victims. It burned weirdly, jerkily, hot leads of it expanding in a way more reminiscent of explosive plant growth than fire. Where it found living bodies, it clung quickly, irremovably, squirming through void suits and cooking the flesh beneath. A hideous cacophony of screams took the place of triumphant battle cries.

Someone was screaming behind him.

He knew that voice.

Slowly, as if caught in a dream, Assan turned. A couple of metres away, almost close enough to touch, his men burned.

Qaziz burned.

His cousin, his companion, his only true friend, reached out his arm slowly, the arm of a sleepwalker groping for a lumen switch, even while he screamed and screamed and screamed. The phosphex had eaten its way into the sleeve of his void suit so that it hung in a ropy swag, dripping melted plasteks. His armour plates were actively burning, only a few rivulets of molten metal escaping to drip on the ground. Most was consumed.

The same was happening to his flesh.

Skin blistered and split, fat ran. For a horrifying moment, Assan saw the gleam of bone in the blackening red of Qaziz's muscle, then the unnatural fire ate through it, and his arm fell.

Qaziz staggered towards his friend, still screaming. An atrocious heat beat at the captain, and he reeled backwards in panic. He saw the terror in Qaziz's eyes through his helm lenses, then ravenous flames poured into the helmet.

Qaziz finally fell silent.

Somehow, Assan had not been hit, but his entire command squad was dead. Porios, Lazareen, Mesen... Charcoal lumps in the dirt, limned by undying fire. He reached out his hand to Qaziz then snatched it back as a looped tongue of white flame groped hungrily at him.

Assan stumbled away. That whole part of the front was pooled with ghostly blazes, feeding on the bodies of his men. As he watched, he saw a jet of phosphex leap from a corpse to a shell-shocked survivor. Even the soil burned. The enemy had released a single barrage of phosphex canister shot against his soldiers. It had been enough to shatter his company.

A new sound joined the hellish shrieks of the dying. The flat, blating report of boltguns. He looked once more to the north, where the cruisers hung in the sky, incurious as gods of the mortals dying below them. The war up there in the heavens occupied them; flights of bombers and fighters swarmed the nearest cruiser, bruising its shields, scratching its hull. Assan wondered numbly if that was why they were not firing upon his part of the battlefield. The space was clear of their own men now, after all.

There could, of course, be another reason.

He refocused on the ground. Tall shapes were marching through the unnatural fires.

The Death Guard approached.

In the days before, when brothers fought common foes rather than one another, the Blood Angels called such actions 'the Day of Revelation'.

Ironically, they had used it more often on other humans than on xenos.

When all diplomatic overtures to resistant cultures had been exhausted, when the offer of Unity had been rebuffed for the final time, when compliance would come only at the barrel of a bolter or the tip of a bayonet, the Blood Angels unleashed death from orbit.

A drop of uncommon magnitude, designed to overwhelm and disorient, targeted most often at centres of leadership and military control; a coordinated decapitation strike. Entire governments were wiped out in moments. After that shock, compliance was all but assured.

These days, it was employed solely for survival, and where previously they had been considered overwhelming, sometimes Raldoron thought of the actions now as little more than stones cast at the avalanche of Horus' advance.

That would not be the case today.

Thunderhawks came screeching down into the heart of the Death Guard formations waiting to board their shuttles. Ranks of Barbarans in dirty white and green opened fire. A fleeing army rarely maintains discipline, yet the Blood Angels were met with heavy resistance.

It was insufficient to stop them.

Drop pods slammed into the ground, disgorging crimson-clad warriors who came out firing. The Thunderhawks and Stormbirds landed with their big guns blazing, and continued as their passengers disembarked, while from above, falling as seeds scattered from fruiting trees, came squad after squad of jump-pack troops, led by deadly Dawnbreaker cohorts, and peppered with the dour-masked Angel's Tears.

Battle was joined immediately, Blood Angels fury against Death Guard fire discipline.

Into this cauldron of boltgun volleys and whining chain weapons came both Simeon and Raldoron.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

BLOOD CALL

Simeon fought with uncanny might. Possessed by the Thirst, his last vestiges of composure were replaced by a hideous strength. He did not care. He exulted in it. That lesson of Raldoron's had stuck, at least.

The battle was a flicker-show of broken memories. A Death Guard raising his bolter too slow to take a shot before Simeon was on him, chainsword battering at his armour, the sharp teeth of the track barely necessary. A chain bayonet taking his shoulder in a glancing blow and jarring his arm in its socket. Pain registered, but not felt. A swift switch from one downed opponent to a second, the first half-decapitated by his sword, the second rendered fully headless by a bolt pistol round through his visor slit.

Beams of light, of plasma, of heat, of fire... bolts from every direction... Through them Simeon's men ran, slashing and blasting their way through one squad into the next, pausing only to rip helmets free and drink their foes' strangely tainted vitae. A few of the Angforia fell, then many. They cared little for their losses. They cared only for blood.

In the sky, the cruisers intensified their fire at attack wings of bombers. Nimble destroyers risked destruction, dipping into the upper atmosphere to deliver torpedo strikes to the cruisers' vulnerable undersides. The Blood Angels concentrated on the lowest ship. Its voids guttered, and went out. Explosions erupted all along the port side.

The damaged cruiser fired its engines in an attempt to break orbit. Chased by swarms of light craft, the thrusters of each one an active sun, it lumbered away, trailing flames, smoke and shattered metal that fell with peculiar slowness.

There were no more shuttles leaving the planet. Most were broken on the ground. The Death Guard were trapped.

A trans-atmospheric fighter sped low over the field, was caught by a heavy las shot and exploded, the pieces hurtling into the combat below, long tracks of fire and smoke describing the plummets of each, the tumbling wreckage slaying men by the score.

Simeon saw none of this. He did not perceive the greater battle. The entire landing zone had degenerated into a mass, close-range brawl the moment the Blood Angels made planetfall. Downed ships burned alongside shattered tanks. Simeon did not see these either. All he saw was his enemy, then the next, then the next, each kill over before the next began.

There came a moment wreathed in smoke when all the enemy around him were dead, and those living were moving out of the zone. Some more restrained part of him perceived they were trying to break out, to get away from the trap the evacuation point had become. The greater part, that which ruled his soul, saw only more lives to snuff out.

His fangs dug into the meat of his mouth. Only with enormous effort did he manage to speak.

‘Angforia, follow me.’

As smoothly as a pack of hunting dogs, Simeon’s remaining men drew together, and ran after their foe.

‘Fire by rank, priority targets forward legionaries!’

Assan gathered those few score of his men who were left after the phospex bombardment – the resourceful, the lucky, and the blessed. In a tight crescent they volleyed las fire into the approaching legionaries. The Death Guard walked right into it. Their modified suits of Mark II and Mark III armour kept them safe. Lasrifles dotted the war plate with molten points, but precious few of the legionaries fell.

Their response was devastating. Bolts flew into the tercio, blasting men to pieces. Those hit by two or three bolts proved a further hazard to their fellows, spraying bone and armour shrapnel into them.

The legionaries reached thirty metres, then they charged.

‘Fire!’ Assan screamed.

He shot with his blast pistol. The overcharged las bolt hit the chestplate of a running Death Guard, cracking it wide. A large piece fell free, and Assan finished him with a follow-up shot worthy of the finest marksman. The legionaries were slowed only a little by the ruined terrain. In seconds they were among the auxiliaries.

A Death Guard sought out Assan, a champion armed with a power sword crackling with deadly energies and already coated with blackening blood. He swatted aside an auxiliary, the blow reducing him to bloody scraps.

Assan drew his charnabal sabre and saluted.

The enemy sergeant did not return the honour. Assan stepped aside from his first blow barely in time. The Space Marine’s power sword buzzed past his face, the edge of the field brushing so closely the power indicators in his helmet jumped. He was so fast. In his armour, the Space Marine outweighed Assan by hundreds of kilograms, and yet he was nimble still, moving with a fluid grace. The captain’s sole advantage was the soft ground, which dragged at the giant’s feet, slowing him just enough.

He dodged the Space Marine’s attacks, often clumsily. No amount of duellist’s skill would parry a hit from that sword. Lacking a disruption field of its own, the charnabal sabre would be obliterated. Assan must rely on timing, and precision. Though unpowered, his sword, the finest work of Saturnine bladesmiths, was strengthened with an adamantine spine and had a monomolecular edge. Despite its lightness, it was a particularly deadly blade.

So he waited for the right moment. A swing, he dodged; another swing, he stepped aside, his blade held back, keeping it safe. Again the Death Guard sergeant’s boot plunged deep into the churned soil. He grunted with frustration, pulled himself free, and swung one last time. Assan ducked, but he was deceived.

The Space Marine grabbed at him, seizing his left wrist, and he squeezed. Bones ground against each other. Sickening pain erupted as they were crushed in the Space Marine’s powered grip. The Death Guard pulled him close and laughed.

That was his mistake.

Fighting a wave of dizziness and nausea, Assan saw his opening. He brought his sword low, angled the point up, and thrust. A difficult cut, but he was the equal of it. The blade met the underside of the Space Marine's helmet, and pushed in as easily as slicing silk, spearing the man's brain.

Assan twisted awkwardly. Excruciating pain made his head buzz and his eyes dim, and he barely avoided being crushed by the dead sergeant's immense weight as he fell. Assan went down with him. Only by gritting his teeth and pulling hard against the agony was he able to extricate his ruined arm.

He sat a moment, then fumbled in a pouch at his belt for a pain suppressant, stabbing the needle into a medical grommet. Pain receded, like water poured from a pan. An agreeable numbness took its place. Sword still in hand, he clutched at the shoulder of his wounded arm, and staggered up.

He prepared to fight, but to his amazement there came a respite. His men would have surely been slaughtered had the Death Guard not been fixated on escape. They ignored the survivors. Having broken through the line, they ran on, shrugging off the smattering of fire directed after them as a nuisance. There were a few tanks back there, and beyond them, a loose cordon of artillery. Assan did not think that would be sufficient to stop the Death Guard, but after that, where would they go? They were dead men, all of them.

What cost this victory had demanded. All around lay dozens upon dozens of bodies, many more burned to fine ash by the phosphex that was only now going out, its chemical poisons seeping into the ground to spoil the earth for generations to come. And yet, it was victory. All three cruisers were running, abandoning the legionaries to their fate.

Raldoron's plan had worked.

It was a small mercy that he experienced the elation of triumph before he died.

More legionaries were coming, racing with vulpine speed through the craters and shell holes. He stiffened, summoned the last shreds of courage, then relaxed.

'Stand down! They are ours,' he shouted hoarsely.

Red armour, black arms and pauldrons. The Blood Angels recruits, running after the fleeing Death Guard.

The surviving Saiphani cheered. Assan recognised the leader's markings. He was sure it was the warrior he had exchanged words with at the Crossing of Praxis. He raised his hand in greeting.

In return, Simeon raised his bolt pistol.

A trooper turned to address Assan, his voice tremulous. 'Sir, what are they doing?'

His stomach was blown out before Assan could reply.

For a glacial age, the last survivors of Assan's company stood in mute shock, not capable of processing what was happening to them. Assan meant to shout out, to order his men to flee, but his throat had closed up. There had been rumours, dark ones, of the legionaries losing control and running wild. He had never seen it, nor had his father, and he had dismissed them as fireside tales, perhaps even enemy propaganda spread somehow among the loyal guardians of Terra.

But the rumours were true.

'Stop,' Assan said. His voice was barely a whisper. He swallowed, tried again. 'Stop!'

The Angforia hit the Saiphani without slowing. The first came in low at a man standing witless with fear, like an adult tackling a child. His pauldron caught the soldier in the chest. The man's body crumpled around the curved plate, and was smashed aside, broken, into the mud. The Blood Angel fell on him, crushing the dying man into the earth with the unstoppable weight of his armour.

'Stop!' Assan walked forward robotically, still unable to believe what he was seeing. 'We are yours, the Saiphan Elevatii! Stop!'

A chainsword's bestial roar became wet, the spinning teeth carving a man in two.

'We are yours! We are on your side! Please!'

Howling madmen in red-and-black plate slaughtered his men. They tore off their helmets, plunged their faces into the bloody messes they had made, and they fed.

'Stop. Please.' Assan's sword fell from his fingers. He stood alone, still clutching his injured arm, unnoticed amid the bloodshed. 'Please.'

Simeon approached him, his huge stature resolving itself from the smoke. He came directly at Assan bareheaded. His face was streaked with blood, his eyes red rounds of staring hatred, inhuman in their ferocity.

Assan met their gaze. There seemed to be no soul behind the flat black pupils, only an unending need.

For a moment, Assan saw the truth of what the Emperor had created. Then Simeon reached for him.

Assan closed his eyes. He was wrenched off his feet. An agony of teeth tore at his neck and then, mercifully, it was over.

It was only a short, panicked vox-message coming from the perimeter line, but it was enough. Raldoron knew immediately what had happened. He called in a Land Raider, gathered to him a squad of his chosen and his two Sanguinary Guard.

They drove to the killing ground in silence.

The Land Raider came to a shuddering stop, tracks locking so suddenly it skidded on the slippery ground. The assault ramp banged down, and Raldoron strode out, flanked by his veterans and Sanguinius' golden guardians.

What he saw was worse than he had expected. Angforia chased down the Saiphan Elevatii without restraint, killing everything they came across, friend or foe.

'Cease!' Raldoron shouted, broadcasting his fury across the vox. 'Cease this madness now!'

He moved fast, covering the ground to the nearest Ang-forios in long strides. The warrior was hunched over, head down, helm off. Raldoron reached down and pulled him up. The Space Marine whipped around, gory face free of reason.

'Cease this now!'

The Blood Angel snarled and lunged at him, powering up from his kneeling position. Raldoron swivelled on one foot, swiped a straightened arm at his throat, and flung him backwards.

'Subdue him!' Raldoron ordered his men. 'Kill him if necessary. Get me Apothecaries here now, a full covenant, and restraints!'

He looked about him, sweeping the battlefield with his auto-senses, and found what he sought – Simeon's signum ident bleating nearby. He followed the tracker. Simeon stood on a low rise, swaying as if drugged.

'Simeon!' he roared. 'Power Simeon! Get your men under control!'

A dying Saiphani reached a shaking hand towards Raldoron, pleading for aid. The Archein strode by.

‘Power Simeon!’

The Space Marine turned to him then, and Raldoron saw that all rational thought had fled. The Power’s face was smeared with blood, so much of it that his head was as red as his armour, putting Raldoron in mind of the daemons from his dreams.

‘By the Great Angel,’ he said, and drew his power sword. ‘Stand down now or I shall put you down.’

Simeon charged him, gunning his chainsword mindlessly. He made a powerful but clumsy swing that Raldoron easily evaded. He backhanded Simeon across the cheek, snapping the younger Space Marine’s head around and half stunning him. Simeon staggered. Raldoron could have finished him then, but did not. Instead he circled him, sword up and ready. Simeon stood a moment, panting, then shook his head and with a guttural roar came again, chainsword whirring. Raldoron cut expertly with the *Encarmine Warblade*. The chain track of Simeon’s weapon burst, and teeth wheeled through the air.

‘Simeon, stop.’

The Angforios growled, and hurled himself at Raldoron. Raldoron hit him in the face again, breaking his nose. Simeon flailed back, feet skidding in the chem-sterilised muck of the battlefield.

The Archein came forward, sidestepped, and hooked his leg round the back of Simeon’s knees, flipping him over his thigh and dropping him to the floor. Simeon rolled over onto all fours. Before he could finish rising, Raldoron drew his pistol and put four rounds into the young Space Marine’s power pack. Two blew on the surface, but the third cracked the ceramite and the fourth punched into the machinery beneath. Energy crackled from within. It died.

Still Simeon tried to rise. He grunted with effort at the weight.

‘Simeon, I do not wish to kill you. Master yourself. The Thirst is on you. You do not have to listen to it. Put it to one side. It is our burden, but you can bear it. You are strong enough.’

Through panted grunts, Simeon managed a few strangled words. ‘I have no strength to resist. Kill me.’

A fat drop of rain slapped onto Raldoron's pauldron, then another, then more and more, until the sky was weeping grey mourning veils. The rain was filthy, clotted with matter thrown up by atomic blasts. His armour spirits chimed their unease at its cargo of radiation.

Simeon collapsed, rolled over, and lay there in the mud panting. His bloodied face was streaked with filthy water.

'Are you finished?' Raldoron asked.

The Angforios gulped, and Raldoron thought him bereft of words once more, then his face crumpled, and he wept, and he cried out.

'Kill me!'

'No.'

'Have you seen what I have wrought? Can you not smell the blood of good men, blood that I have spilled?'

'I have seen.' Raldoron stood over the boy. 'I can smell the blood. Do you think it does not call to me? I do not listen, as you should not.'

'I deserve to die. I killed them. I killed them all. Our own men.'

Raldoron looked over the ruin about him, death brought by friendly hands. Not one body remained whole. He expected to find Faisal's son among the corpses, whatever was left of him pushed without dignity into the mud. Only a miracle would have saved him, and the Imperial Truth denied the existence of those.

'You did.'

'Then I deserve to die!'

Raldoron's sword and pistol remained pointing at the mud.

'Deserve death, yes. But you shall not have its release.'

Simeon cried. 'I thought I could control it, but I cannot. I cannot! The blood, the blood, the blood...' His voice trailed off. 'Kill me,' he said. 'Please, please end my suffering.'

'You will live,' said Raldoron. 'This war is not about what you or I deserve. It is about victory, at any cost. You killed many good men today. That will haunt you forevermore. But I will not lose another warrior for the sake of your guilt. Cease your puling, and stand.'

Simeon looked at him disbelievingly.

'I did not ask for this. I do not want these gifts!'

'And yet you have them, and with them your duty.'

'Please. End it!'

‘I told you to stand!’

Simeon wept in the mud, and Raldoron’s empathy curdled into contempt.

Raldoron’s men were gathering around them. Rhino transporters marked with the double helix of the medicae rumbled up. Wounded Space Marines and the few surviving auxiliaries were being attended to by Apothecaries. Void craft engines blatted. Aircraft still duelled in the thickening skies, but the cruisers of the Death Guard were now small, and dwindling. They cast petulant lance fire earthwards as they sailed, but it was inaccurate, and scattered, and did little but light up the ruined atmosphere in yellow blazes. The rearmost cruiser still trailed fire behind it, and he thought it might yet be caught, but the last movement of battle was ending, an orchestral finale of fading gunshots and screams.

‘Get him up,’ Raldoron said, gesturing to Simeon. ‘See to his injuries. I want a full psychological evaluation of them all. Determine what best use we may have of them, especially him. While they can slay the enemy, they live. Put them into hibernation, if you have to.’

‘No!’ Simeon roared. Two Space Marines bent to grasp his arms and lift him. ‘I do not want this! I did not ask to be made this way! I will not be a monster! Kill me! Kill me!’

‘You think we were made? Do you think the Emperor did this to us? We are human, Simeon. We were born monsters.’

Simeon’s protests were shut off by the clang of a tank door. Overhead, the Death Guard ships lumbered out of the atmosphere into the freedom of the void. Raldoron shut his eyes, dipping into the deep well of calm bored through his soul that no thirst could ever touch. He let it cool his anger as he stood in the rain, the stinking sludge that slithered from the sky washing over his armour, reminding him of better times, when the future was to be welcomed, not feared.

They said it had been raining on Teghar Pentaurus when Sanguinius first joined his sons. The day the Revenant Legion had been taken by him and raised up from the depths of hell to the heights of heaven.

False promises, all.

CHAPTER TWENTY

AN OFFER REFUSED

Margrave Sovos was old and proud, and he said no.

‘No?’ said Raldoron.

‘No,’ the old man repeated, firmer than before.

Sovos’ leg was twisted by a poorly healed injury, and he stood crookedly in his carapace armour, leaning upon a stout cane for support. His wild mane of white hair blew in the smoke-tainted wind. He was broken, dirty, wizened with age and yet defiant. A boy of perhaps twelve years of age stood at his side, carrying the man’s helmet. An entourage of sixteen further men, all armed to the teeth, stood behind him, their wargear dirty and heavily damaged, their attitudes unfriendly.

They were at Linim, the planet’s sole space port. Blood Angels ships came and went, the whine of their engines threatening to drown out the negotiations. The crack of vessels breaking the sound barrier as they accelerated towards escape velocity mingled with the drumbeats of thunder as the atmosphere continued to churn. According to the fleet planetologist, the storms would last for a decade or more before settling down. What kind of world would be left when that occurred was unclear. The prognosis was not good.

There was not a single undamaged building in the port. Raldoron doubted there were many left on the planet, and so he received Margrave Sovos and his men in a broad, open tent, the canvas vermillion and richly embroidered.

Raldoron occupied a heavy stone chair, and was still clad in his armour. His chief officers attended him. Faisal, ashen with grief, stood to his left.

‘You heard me. We will not leave our home,’ Sovos said with the patient care used when instructing a slow learner.

‘Your men are needed. The cluster could fall to Horus any day. You understand that the whole reason we are here is to gather men for the campaign in the core system?’ Faisal said. He was tight-voiced. Raldoron wished he would not speak. He was not in control of himself.

‘I do, marshal, but we will not leave.’

‘My son died here, for you.’

‘He died for the Emperor, not for me.’

‘How dare y—’

‘I have lost six sons and three daughters myself to Horus’ betrayal. I empathise.’

‘This is treachery. The Archein could have you all killed for this.’

Sovos’ men tensed. This was getting out of hand.

‘Marshal Subarai-Almazi, that is enough,’ Raldoron said firmly.

Faisal stood rigidly to attention. ‘Yes, my lord.’

‘Explain yourselves to me,’ Raldoron asked. ‘I want to understand. The galaxy is ripped in two. You cannot stay here. Your world is poisoned. Your chances of survival are slim. If you leave with us, you have at least the chance of living, and serving a great cause even if you do not.’

Sovos leaned on his stick. The boy – Raldoron belatedly realised he must be the man’s grandson – looked at him in concern.

‘A chance? There is none. We barely held on here. How can the remnants of my people serve against Titans and legionaries? It is they who will decide the fight at the core, not mere men. We will be less than nothing, useless.’

‘That is not the case,’ said Raldoron. ‘Every man may serve to his ability. The Emperor has a use for us all.’

Sovos shook his head. ‘No. That is optimism at best, an outright lie at worst. We have fought here for too long to leave. We have bested every army the Warmaster sent to take this place. We have lost a great deal. We have seen our families killed and our home despoiled. But we won. We will not now abandon it simply because you demand it. Our blood is in this soil.’

‘It is not I, but the primarch Sanguinius who asks you,’ Raldoron said. ‘If you will not listen to me, then consider his call for aid.’

‘We serve the Emperor, and humanity. We do not serve the Emperor’s sons, nor the Emperor’s Space Marines.’

‘The Emperor’s orders are given by His representatives,’ Raldoron said. ‘We speak with His voice. I speak for Him.’

‘No.’

‘What of the regiments you sheltered?’

Sovos smiled bitterly. ‘They are mostly dead. Their survivors feel the same way. I speak for us all. Ask them yourself, if you like.’

A young man with a badly burned face, his right eye pearly with blindness, spoke up aggressively. ‘If the Emperor wants us to leave, then He can come here and tell us Himself.’

‘Silence now, Drinus,’ Sovos said. ‘My apologies, Archein, but my answer is final. We will not go. If this is indeed the Emperor’s will, and if He came to plead with us in person, then we would still refuse. We have given everything we have. Our cities are ruins, our oceans poisoned, our fields burned.’

‘Because of that, you will die here. You know this.’

‘All men die.’ Sovos straightened his back. The knuckles of the hand holding the stick whitened with the effort of keeping himself erect. ‘We would prefer to choose where. That is all we have left. So we choose here, where we fought. Here, at home.’

Raldoron let out a pensive breath. He looked to one side. It was unlikely the enemy would return. If these people could weather the coming years, some few of them might persist. Their fighting strength had been reduced to tens of thousands, a loss to the Reprisal Fleet, but not a lamentable one. The population was a fraction of what it had been. The total number of inhabitants of the world had become less than half a million, from the pre-war census of one hundred million people. Then there were the others not under arms, the young, invalids, the old... He could not take those with him. He had no space for refugees. He could not guarantee any ships would come for them if he took Sovos’ army. Those left behind would have even less of a chance without their fittest men and women.

But refusal was unconscionable. Strictly, he should kill them all. He mulled giving the order for several seconds. Ships roared above.

He was tired of death.

He looked up at Sovos. 'I will not force you to come. I will not punish people who have done nothing but fight loyally, and against such odds, for so long. I sit here, still slathered in the blood of battle, and I say, enough. But hear this, Margrave Sovos, there can be no aid for this world. I will send no relief ships to you, there will be no evacuation for anyone if you refuse this order. I can spare no food, no supplies, no personnel. If you stay here, you will be alone. Do you understand?'

'We have been alone these last years. We are used to self-sufficiency.' Sovos dipped his head. 'All we ask is to determine our fate ourselves.'

'That I can grant.'

'Then I thank you for your clemency. It is unexpected, and gives me a small measure of hope.'

Sovos bowed. His grandson grasped his elbow, then he and his entourage departed. The men formed up around the ruler of their broken world and walked backwards, weapons low but ready. Raldoron was struck by the way Sovos' men watched the Space Marines and their auxiliaries.

They were looking at the Blood Angels as if they were the enemy.

The document on Raldoron's desk was straightforward: a reclassification of 147-Gamma Minoris-Garmon from beta-grade agri world to death world, sub-category Bello Vastatus, minoris-categories unclassified. He looked at it for a long moment, so long that Ulint Ger, the astrocartographer who had brought the paper to sign, felt obliged to prompt him.

'My lord, is there something wrong with my work?'

Raldoron glanced at him. 'Nothing is wrong.'

Though there was. There was another world dead, and here was the tidy, bureaucratic proof of it, a piece of paper so bland it made the loss of a planet seem no more serious than a rounding error.

He seized his pen, and signed. He had no say over how worlds were classified, but he had to put his approval to the work of every major adeptus in his fleet. In a way, he was glad they had settled on the death world category. It might provide a flimsy layer of protection to the remaining Gallians from outside meddling if others thought there was nothing worth taking there.

If they survived.

Ger bowed, placed the paper into an embossed card folder, tied the ribbon fastener, then departed.

Although Raldoron had a great deal of work to do he remained still, eyes unfocused. He could call it meditation, but in reality there was no purpose to it. He was suffering a form of despair, he thought, weak, but growing. He had to pay attention so that it did not become stronger. He accepted the road fate had for him and his men, though he had an inkling of what the end of that path might bring to his Legion: isolation, torment, a separation from common humanity. The Legiones Astartes who lived after the war was done would likely never be properly trusted again.

He supposed that was the crucial difference between those Space Marines who served the Emperor and those who had turned their back on Him. Most loyalists understood that they had been made to serve mankind, not rule it, yet though he tried to make this his guiding principle to govern his actions, it was not strong enough to hold back the darkness within. Space Marines would forever be a threat to peace. He had not always thought this way. It had taken Horus' betrayal for him to realise the truth of it. Raldoron was no longer human, had not been for over a century. He had been at peace with that once, but in light of recent events he feared the Blood Angels were dying from within, becoming again the monsters they had fought so hard not to be.

After some time, Faisal came. Quincus announced him. Raldoron could not turn him away, though he would have done so if he could. He would rather face any enemy than deal with a father's grief. Enemies were easy to manage; one simply killed them. Human emotion was another matter entirely.

Faisal Subarai-Almazi's uniform was dazzling, the cloth perfectly clean and pressed, the boots and buckles polished. He saluted with impeccable precision. All this saddened Raldoron from the start. There was no sign of the ease they had once enjoyed.

'Will you sit, Faisal?' Raldoron asked. Before, Faisal would have taken a chair without asking. But that had been before.

Wordlessly, Faisal sat. They looked at each other. Raldoron broke the silence.

'I do not know what to say to you.'

'No platitudes? No speeches about the legacy of a man's courage?'

‘I remain human enough to know that would do no good. For what it is worth, I am truly sorry. Assan was a fine man. His death is a loss to us all.’

Faisal was quiet a moment.

‘I think I believe that,’ he said in a small voice.

Raldoron nodded gratefully. He struggled to keep his emotions under tight control. They rarely bothered him, but right now that was not the case. Disappointment, horror, despair and misery – that day he was overly blessed with feeling.

‘What can I do for you?’ *Apart from bring back your son*, Raldoron thought. *I cannot do that.*

‘I came to say that I understand.’

Raldoron frowned quizzically.

‘I understand why you treat us the way you do,’ Faisal explained. ‘The way you use us in battle. An auxiliary is worth less than a legionary. An Angforios is worth less than a veteran. Every soldier has his worth. I accept that.’

‘No single life is worth anything any more, not alone. Have you not seen the mortification index, Faisal? This is a war of brute numbers. You and I, we are but part of the calculation. Both of us.’

‘I understand, Archein. I do. Honour, and restraint... You Angels of Death were never beholden to them anyway. In these dark times you must abandon them.’

‘You refer to my keeping of the Angforia?’

Faisal just stared at him.

‘I would do it another way if I could.’

‘You were too quick into the fray here.’

So this is it, Raldoron thought. *He seeks blame. That is no surprise. More so, he is probably right.*

‘I did what I had to. Every enemy legionary lost is one less to set foot on Terra. It is about numbers. We are all reduced to numbers.’

‘You allowed the Gallians to stay.’

‘Different numbers, different problems. To take them would have caused more complications. Too many disgruntled men dragging on army cohesion. Letting them stay was as bad an outcome as forcing them to come. There are many numbers, besides numbers of guns. There are amounts of food, amounts of time.’

‘One of those numbers was my son.’ Faisal’s voice cracked.

‘For which I am truly sorry, my friend. What are we to do? How many more sons and daughters will die before all this is over? Millions? Billions? If I had any other choice than to fight, I would take it. But there is none. Horus took choice from us.’ Raldoron tried for a sympathetic look. It felt false on his face, a sham of care. ‘Assan was brave. He was bold, he did his job well.’

‘I should be proud?’

The question was loaded, and dangerous. Raldoron had no reply.

‘Do you think I wanted him to be a soldier?’ Faisal said suddenly.

‘I am sorry?’

‘I said,’ Faisal said with taut control, ‘do you think I wanted Assan to be a soldier? Life on Saiph before the Imperium came was hard, and it was often brutal. Our sons and daughters died there then, but do you think being used to death made it acceptable?’

‘I do not understand.’

‘Of course you do not understand. You cannot have children. What do you understand other than death?’

‘Faisal...’

Faisal spoke over him. His voice quavered. ‘When the Imperium came, it is said my great-grandfather was overjoyed. He wept when the ships landed, when out marched you angels and your wonders of technology, like the stories of the way things were before Old Night. Your kind spoke of Unity, compliance, Imperium. Worthy dreams. He thought we were saved. I am glad he never learned that there was no liberty, nor any peace. That we desert warriors swapped tribal skirmishes for the destruction of cultures, whole species, whole worlds.’ Faisal’s hands clenched. ‘We are not like you Space Marines. Never, in our darkest, most savage days, would we have dreamt of annihilating our foes so thoroughly that not even their memories remained. We honoured our foes, because one day, no matter how mighty our clan, we knew we would be defeated, and that we would wish to be treated with honour when our turn came. We were fighting for that when we took up arms for the Imperium, or so we thought. For honour. For a better future. Now where is honour? Where is our future? Where are our children? Scattered across the stars. We were better off without you.’

‘Faisal, what am I to do? All those who died today were the sons and daughters of someone. You speak dangerously. Remember who I am, what I represent.’

Faisal displayed a hideous grin, fixed, humourless, and hostile. ‘How could I forget that? You can do nothing about Assan, apart from perhaps actually listening to what I am saying. Can you do that for me, as a blood price for my son? Can you try to understand? Can you listen?’

Raldoron nodded. ‘I can.’

‘My son died, Raldoron. My son died! He died in battle. As his commander I honour him, as a father I grieve. But it is understandable. It is war. What pains me is how he died, because he died at the hands of the people he served. He died at the hands of one of you, and he had no choice but to be there. The Imperium promised peace, and instead brought us bigger and more horrific wars, wars without quarter, far from our home. Wars we could not escape from nor ever return from. The Imperium deals in lies, Raldoron...’

‘Now you go too far, my friend. You speak treasonously.’

‘Listen. You promised,’ he hissed. ‘You know I am no traitor. I have known men in my position who have become appalled by what they have seen, and think it better that mankind fade from history like so many empires have before us. I am not one of those men. I see that the Imperium is the only way. But we must know for what we fight – you must know. We must be realistic. The Great Crusade pacified our ancient foes, and when they were exterminated, we turned our guns on those who might one day become a threat. While we did this, we held out the hand of friendship to every being whose ancestors once breathed the air of Old Earth, and if they spurned it, they too were destroyed. We had barely finished these bloody tasks when we turned on each other.

‘You Blood Angels present yourselves as exemplars of our best, but that is not so.’ Faisal stared at him hard. ‘You are the worst of humanity. Barbarism veneered in gold. But I am no better than you. For all that has been done to you, you are still a man like me, and I speak to you as a man. One day, Raldoron, this will be over. I pray you survive. I know I will not. My line certainly will not, now Assan is dead. If, one day, after all this is done, you find yourself in a position to do just a little good, I pray you will.

You must acknowledge that empire is a vile necessity. Only when you acknowledge the truth of that can you hope to change it for the better.'

For a long moment their gazes locked. Raldoron wrestled with what he should do. Faisal's words were outright treason, by certain definitions. Raldoron was not so removed from humanity as not to respect the marshal's grief, nor to feel no remorse for his part in it. But he had executed men for less in the past, and if his attitude got into his men...

He stopped. He thought. He had wondered so many times what drove men into Horus' insane rebellion. Just then, just for a moment, he thought he understood.

Calm, he thought. Be calm.

Unconsciously, he rested his hand on the ancient iron mask. It was a long moment before he spoke again.

'I swear I will do what I can. There is nothing more I can say than that, and certainly no more I can promise.'

'Then I hope with all my heart that it is enough,' said Faisal. He wiped a tear from his eye. Only then did Raldoron notice the man had been weeping.

How strange, he thought, that I did not see that.

Faisal got up and stood crisply to attention. 'Permission to be dismissed, Archein?'

'Permission granted, lord solar marshal.'

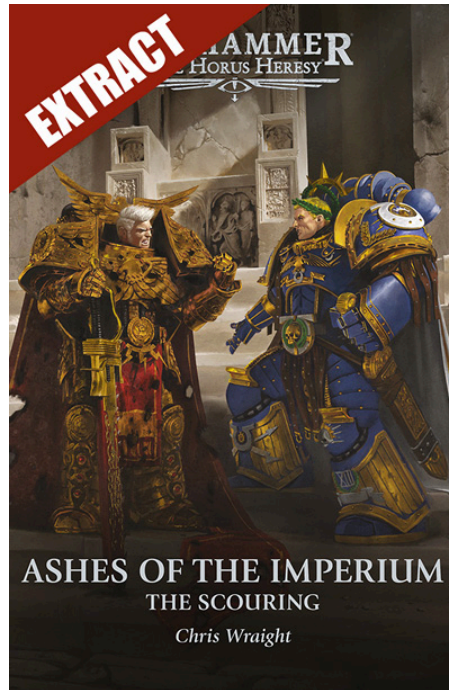
Straight-backed with dignity, Faisal departed Raldoron's office, leaving the Space Marine alone.

For a while Raldoron stared at the mask. He rotated it on the desk, losing himself in the rasp of iron on wood. The hollow eyes stared up at grim futures Raldoron could not apprehend, while out in the stars, war raged ever on.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Guy Haley's work for Black Library spans the depth and breadth of the Warhammer universes. He is the author of several Horus Heresy novels, including *The Lost and the Damned*, *Titandearth*, *Wolfsbane* and three titles in the Primarchs series. He has also written many Warhammer 40,000 books, including *Dawn of Fire: Avenging Son*, the Dark Imperium trilogy, and the Belisarius Cawl novels *The Great Work*, *Genefather* and *Archmagos*. For Age of Sigmar he has penned the Drekki Flynt novels *The Arkanaut's Oath* and *The Ghosts of Barak-Minoz* as well as many other stories. He lives in Yorkshire with his wife and son.

An extract from *Ashes of the Imperium*.



The error of history is to assume greater awareness of circumstances at the time than ever existed; to imagine those of the past knew precisely and with insight what was the case then, what was about to be the case, and what they must do to bring about their desired outcome. So it must be with those days, the days I have made my own study. Will the age come to have its own marker, as the Age of Heresy now has? Will the period become a byword for some particular human failing or accomplishment? Surely it will. And yet, even now, so long after the ashes have cooled, I do not know what it shall be. I propose this, with caution: the Age of Confusion. Or maybe, the Age of Ignorance. For it was this way; there was no certainty, and no ready means of discovering it. As a gravely wounded Terra emerged from its seven-year trial into the fog of a new era, be sure of this one truth: nobody, not a soul, from the greatest of generals to the humblest of soldiers, had the faintest idea what to do next.

– Diomedon of Luna, *A Study of the Reconstruction*

Now run. Run hard. Nothing else exists. Run, then run some more. You will be doing it forever now.

Those were the words, in the rare moments of clarity, the brief pauses in the headlong rush for doubtful sanctuary. It seemed that this was just the start, the movement into a new way of life that would become eternal. Was

death preferable? Maybe another fighter would have thought so. They might have turned, weapons held wide, bracing in defiance before the crash of fury-surf that would dash them away.

But he was not made that way. None of his Legion had been made that way. Iron within, iron without. Live. Survive. Fall back, regroup, rebuild. No pity – not for self, not for any living thing. Run. Run hard. Find a place, a distant place, where you can turn at last, and do so from strength.

A place will be found. It will. That was the other truth: the wheel shall turn. Only live long enough to see it.

So run. Run now. But no, not forever.

He had once had a reputation. The earth itself moulded and turned under his hands, they had said. He would gaze at a landscape, a terrain, a scarp that rose and fell like a drape of cloth, and know how to bend it to his will. He would gauge the substrates, the underlying strata and the surface conditions, his grey eyes glittering while his body was held perfectly still under the glow of massed augur readings.

After a minute, or an hour, or days – however long it took – the orders would come. He would signal for the machines to roll into their positions. The drills would start up, the shafts would be delved, the courses dug out. Pumps would begin to churn, soundings would be made. As he continued to observe, arms folded across his chest now, patient, still silent, the levies of slave labour would march into position, tools at the ready. The earth would be changed. It would protest – the screams and bellows of upended stone, the crack of ancient sediments being wrenched into the open – but his will was the mightier. Always, the mightier. The earth was his servant; he was its master.

Thus it had been before the great schism, the years in which he had fought under the banner of the Imperium. Thus it had remained after the break, as victory drew ever closer – the turning of fate's thumbscrew, when his Legion threw off its long humiliation and turned its talents upon old tormentors. The tools remained the same throughout. Not for him the doubtful advantages of the daemonic, the sprites and delusions of weaker minds and souls, just the old, familiar instruments, the physical things: the hammers, the machines, the hands, the mortal minds and sinews.

Bitter, they had been called. Resentful, reclusive. Well, there was a reason for that. A host of reasons. And the Emperor, for all his sins, had never forged a weapon without a purpose. You needed to be bitter to do this work. You needed to put your back into it, to channel all that surliness, to direct the force of it into the soil. Because the deep places were bitter too. They were foul and they were deep, the accumulated spoil of a thousand buried lifetimes, all of it stinking, pulling at your boots and dragging at your shoulders. Only the sour-souled endured that. Only a stomach of wormwood could out-spice the earth.

So they twisted and changed the worlds they found. They sunk their fingers into them and made the terrains into stages of death. Sometimes it was defensive – earthworks and palisades against which armies broke like sheets of glass. Sometimes it was offensive – encircling trenches that covered the advance of the Great Machines and suffocated the life out of enemy fortresses. The result, in the end, was the same. Corpses rotting into the mulch, walls slumping into the mud, war engines condemned to slow rust, and the banners of the IV Legion – the Iron Warriors – raised high once again.

It was methodical. It was patient. It had been perfect, so perfectly planned, from start to finish, the product of a mind of hard genius, and one under whom he had been so proud to serve.

The Master of Sieges. That's what they'd called him back then. Ortag Theokon, the Earth-Tormentor. Honoured among a people who only honoured the most strenuous arts, those of the tool and the instrument, the gauge and the theodolite.

What did it mean any more? There would be no building now. No patient remaking of the earth. Only running, headlong, panicked.

The humiliation of it. The raw, unbearable humiliation. That was the worst wound, far worse than any physical flesh-breaking.

Run. Feel the abjectness, the white-hot shame. Run hard.

He'd got close, though. He still remembered it all, vivid as a shell-burst in his mind – the Palace itself. Months of toil it had taken to get that near, and at times the fatigue had been too crushing even for them, but they'd made it eventually, cresting the slag heaps with their engines and gazing at last upon the wounded prize.

By then, Terra had been sunk deep into the oily embrace of the warp and everything was shifting under their feet. You'd fight your way down a processional for a week only to find yourself back where you'd started, or pursue the enemy into a dead end only to find yourself ambushed by hundreds more spilling out from new roads that had never been on the cartoliths. It had sickened him, he remembered, making him frustrated and impatient. His master had long quit the field, perhaps out of the same disgust, leaving only the most committed of the IV behind. Theokon had hauled his engines out of cussedness towards the end, losing thousands of slaves with every painful advance, no longer caring about the waste, just committed, absolutely committed, to being there when it mattered.

And he had been. He'd seen the pinnacles of the final redoubt with his own eyes, swimming amid an ocean of empyreal saturation. He'd got near enough to train his guns on their faltering structures. He'd been poised to level them all, just as he'd levelled so many other fortresses in the past.

For a moment, for one intense moment, he'd revelled in it. They had won. They *had* won. The sacrifice, the compromises, the pain – it had been worth it at last. The Tyrant would be overthrown, the Reign of the Astartes Unfettered would begin, and this time the Imperium would be constructed and maintained without lies or compromises.

Theokon did not know if he had ever been *happy*, not like they said the baseline humans were capable of being, but that moment surely got close. He'd grinned under his rusted helm, felt all the fatigue melt away, clenched his fist high. The moment he unclenched, the engines would go to work – the earth would shake, the sky would split, his accumulated hatred would pour onto those walls and render them down to ashes.

He never got to give the order. It had all happened so suddenly, so completely, so utterly without warning. The entire vista had rocked, slammed over, flexed, shuddered. The crimson skies had flared, the stars had blazed. Fires had leapt up from the earth, spontaneous, almost gleeful. These were no munitions, no fresh weapons firing – this was the universe itself in both rapture and agony, a shaking of its primordial foundations, a snapping-back of reality like a dislocated limb being reset.

The daemons were torn out of reality, howling with horror and disbelief. The warp sky exploded and then gusted back into darkness. A great crack rang out from horizon to horizon, deafening for a split second, blinding for

a mere instant, then just an echo – the resumption of physical law, the wrench of the immaterium being hauled away.

Elation was replaced, instantly, with terror. Real fear. A whirl of vertigo, of stomach-churning horror. Hardened Space Marines around him fell to their knees, dropped their weapons, looked to the heavens in dumb amazement. Theokon himself staggered, all thoughts of conquest suddenly gone, barely noticing as the greatest of his precious engines disintegrated from within. A gale whipped up, churning dust and ashes into the already filthy skies. Rumbles of collapse juddered across the poisoned soils. A greater roar rose, gathering strength, resounding and voluminous, coming now from far, far above. So he looked up at last, barely aware of himself or where he was, and saw them: the enemy, not crawling across the landscape in scraps and rags but swarming from the heavens, rank upon rank of them – drop pods, landers, heavy carriers laced with friction lightning. Where had they come from? Who *were* they? How was this *happening*?

‘Fall back!’ came a cry, a strangled outburst of wild astonishment.

Theokon might have resisted that, but then the bombardment began – curtains of fire, vengeful fire, lancing down from the hurtling atmospherics, crackling and splitting the air itself. The concentration of it was phenomenal, as if ranks of calderas had tipped out their white-hot contents in unison, dousing the surface in a tide of sizzling ingots even as more were lined up to come.

So he ran. He turned heavily, slipping in the already-boiling mud, limping back the way he’d come, along with all the rest of them, sliding and skidding and dropping to all fours, leaving weapons, leaving shields and trophies, dropping it all, forgetting it all, just scrambling out of that inferno before the waves of pain overtook them and dissolved them down to nothing.

The battlefield was vast – kilometres and kilometres of terrain crammed with millions of troops and vehicles – but the onslaught was everywhere, at all points, sudden and unrelenting. Theokon’s helm display quickly overloaded, immediately crammed with so many threat signals that he blinked it off. He was panting, gasping for oxygen. He felt very cold, even as the air shimmered with heat from the bombardment.

It wasn’t fighting. It wasn’t any kind of contest. It was a rout, an immediate rout, a switchback of vicious, unprecedented severity. Whole

squads, whole *battalions*, were consumed as they attempted to turn. Those engines that had not already been destroyed were now hunted and disabled. The drop pods plunged into the sickened earth, bracketed with insane levels of covering fire, then the doors slammed open and the hunters spilled out.

He never even saw the insignias on those doors – he never knew who was killing them all. He felt as if he might be weeping as he ran, as if he might be dying from the inside out, as if the shame would burst his hearts. He saw Krathos killed, his lieutenant blown up by charges as he tried to scale a sliding dune face of wreckage. He saw Llax and Fidec ripped apart, their limbs and weapons thrown wildly into the air. He kept going, breaking into a heavy run, his boots churning up the blood and oil that saturated the dust. The sky lit up again, then again, then flared permanently white, erasing shadows, picking them all out in savage clarity.

Somehow he got back to the earthworks, the reserve lines. He got a snatched glimpse of the lower plains beyond, the ones they'd spent months fighting across, the badlands they had conquered with so much loss and determination, now a seething mass of bodies fleeing the other way. Millions of them. Billions of them. Mutants, beasts, mortals, Astartes, screaming and slipping and going mad. No daemons. None. All gone, all pulverised. He saw the once-possessed limping around in agony and terror, their sundered souls amputated back to wholeness.

He stumbled on through the trenches, his ears filled with the roar of slaughter behind him. He glanced up again, groggily – saw a big lander coming down less than a kilometre off, its swollen hull running with friction-flame and smoke, its flanks split open to reveal rows and rows of launch cradles. Beyond that was a voidship coming down. A *voidship*! Hells, it was massive, its high-atmosphere passage kindling thunderheads and scatter-lightning, its mighty thrusters burning up what was left of the cloud cover, its stressed void shields crackling like corposant.

What had happened to the Grand Fleet? Where was the orbital defence picket? How were those things getting through?

No time to speculate, no time to think, just stagger onwards, slip and skid and stumble and keep moving. Borasc was killed, shot clean through with some kind of ice-white energy beam. Nuih and Gorkolis were dropped next, overtaken by the hunters, engaged, snarled in combat, cut to pieces. They were being chewed through, ground up, minced down to gobbets of blood-

soaked, bone-flecked detritus. The hunters were closing, coming into visual range now, loping after them with terrifying speed. He spat blood into his vox-grille, viscous and slimy. His breathing was like an old man's, wheezing out of overworked lungs.

Then he saw the Stormbird, a few hundred metres off, grounded, its marker lights on, unguarded, half lost in the tumbling smog banks and mortar flares. IV Legion – his own. He'd be able to crack it open, activate the thrusters.

Who was still with him? Alescu was on his shoulder, limping badly. Old Mnon, bitter old Mnon, just behind him. A few beyond that, struggling in the haze and the disintegrating terrain – five or six, no more.

'Take it!' he roared, his voice strangled and hoarse.

No one was guarding it, its old crew were gone. They piled inside, activating the drives while the crew-bay doors were still creaking into place. The gunship took off in an explosion of mud and filth and chem spillage, erupting out of the mire and labouring to gain loft. Almost immediately, targeting runes flashed up across the cockpit console – dozens of them, hundreds of them. Another Stormbird had achieved take-off just ahead of them, one caked in mud and bearing the symbols of the Night Lords. It took a hit to its spine that punched it back down to earth, another to its starboard flank that kicked it over, then two more to its cockpit before a seeker missile corkscrewed into its exposed underbelly and blew the whole thing up.

Theokon piloted straight into the cloud of shrapnel, risking damage to benefit from a few precious moments of sensor-overloading heat and plasma. The forward viewer ran blank with raging flames for a split second, and then they were out again, boosting and slanting through a forest of energy beams and hard rounds, a crowded airspace of descending hunters and desperate prey. Visibility was non-existent beyond a few hundred metres, just a miasma of explosions and flying wreckage and somersaulting flyer carcasses. No tactics, no possibility of evading incoming fire, just the hope that those around you, the ones you'd just been fighting alongside as part of the greatest army ever assembled, would take the las beam or the projectile strike in your stead.

This was wretched. This was base, ignoble, cowardly.

Keep running.

Somehow they had made it out of the first kill-zones, climbing erratically, pushing the envelope to gain speed, streaking clear of the core volume of airborne destruction. Theokon had tilted hard to evade a reeling Thunderhawk, turned his head for an instant, and got what he instinctively knew would be his last view of Terra.

The entire Himalazian plateau lay far below, an ellipse of fire from horizon to curved horizon, the great stage of all their dramas. It was burning, all of it now, glimmering an angry red, punctured by millions of dark points streaming down from the fleets above. In the very centre stood the mighty Sanctum Imperialis, the last redoubt, vast beyond vast, compassed by its concentric rings of trenches and earthworks, its soaring domes cracked and its towers splintered. It was solid, blackened, like a hateful pupil set in a loathsome eye, unblinking, devastated, lingering.

It would endure. They had not killed it. It would remain. It would be gazing after them as they fled into the void, staring, staring, never leaving them.

Theokon screamed. Not from fear now, but from frustration, from *fury*, from a diamond-pure hatred that surged up within him and flooded his every vein and artery.

He gazed at that eye, the great eye of the earth, fire-ringed and eternal, and screamed at it.

Live. Survive. A place will be found.

The Stormbird flew hard and fast, a spear thrust out of the heart of ruin, streaking through the burning heavens.

Live.

This was all that remained. To persist. To not be extinguished.

Survive.

They had lost. They had lost everything.

Get. Out.



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